

MEMORANDUM

Minnesota Department of Human Services
Aging and Disability Services Administration | Disability Services Division

TO Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager

FROM Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant

DATE September 18, 2026

SUBJECT The One DSD People, Access and Culture Program: what it is, where it stands, and an invitation to shape it with me

Let me begin with something I want said plainly. **In my professional judgment, both of you are genuinely interested in equity and in the cultural and organizational change this work asks for.** I have witnessed both of you earnestly engaging in that work, and it is a large part of why I am glad to bring this to you now.

I would like to show you what the One DSD People, Access and Culture Program has become, and ask for your thinking on it. **This is not a request for approval, and nothing here waits on a decision from you.** What would help me most is your honest reading by December 1 — what looks useful, what looks thin, and what you would want to see that is not here yet.

This page carries what matters immediately, and I would genuinely welcome the conversation more than the reading. So that you know what is in front of you, and what you can safely leave:

1. **This page.** A few minutes. What the Program is, what it is for, and what I am asking of you. If you read only this, you have what you need to reply.
2. **The communication in full.** Longer, and written to be entered at the section you want rather than read end to end. Every link on this page opens the part that treats that point properly.
3. **The supporting record.** The documents behind the work, at the foot of this page. You do not need to read any of them. They are there so that anything you want to check is one click away.

What has been built is usable today. Nothing here is waiting on next year, or the year after. If no further work were done from this moment, there is already enough in hand to begin operationalizing equity with staff and leadership across the Division — and to sustain that for somewhere between one and five years.

THE INSTRUMENT TO OPEN FIRST: THE EQUITY ANALYSIS TOOLKIT

If you open one thing in this package, open this. The Equity Analysis Toolkit companion takes a decision someone is actually facing — a policy, a service, a change in practice — and works through it in five stages: the decision and what is genuinely still open, who is affected and how, what the options are, how affected people can influence it, and what to review before it is settled. Each stage carries a worked example to try and a place to draft the analysis of one's own work.

Open the Equity Analysis Toolkit → (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/equity-toolkit>)

That address opens the toolkit on its own, with none of the rest of the Program around it, so it can be forwarded to anyone who should see it. It goes out to the live Program, as do the resource addresses in the next section; every other link in this package opens inside the file.

This is the Program's companion to the Minnesota Equity Analysis Toolkit, not a substitute for it. It submits nothing to DHS, it grants no approval, and it does not replace required review or engagement with the people a decision affects.

WHAT A MEMBER OF YOUR STAFF CAN OPEN TODAY

Every one of these is built and published. The Program holds far more, and all of it works the same way.

Disability, Diversity and Belonging (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/courses/di-disability-diversity-belonging>)

The grounding course. Disability as an ordinary part of any workforce and any caseload, which is the assumption the rest of the Division's work rests on.

Disability Rights, Policy and Organizational Duties (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/courses/di-rights-policy-and-organizational-duties>)

For anyone who writes, reviews or applies a rule: where the duties come from, read as obligations on the organization rather than as law in the abstract.

Conflict Resolution That Works for Neurodivergent Staff (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/courses/di-conflict-resolution-and-neurodiversity>)

For supervisors and managers. Standard conflict processes quietly assume one kind of communicator; this shows how to run one that more than one kind of person can actually use.

Capstone: Remove a Real Barrier (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/courses/di-capstone-remove-a-real-barrier>)

The Program does not stop at reading. The capstone has a staff member carry one real barrier in their own work through to a change, and produce the record of it.

[Equity impact questions for policy, budget, technology, and procurement](https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/library/ja-equity-impact-questions) (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/library/ja-equity-impact-questions>)

A single page a policy analyst or contract manager can hold beside a proposal and work through in the meeting they are already in.

[Questions about the steps, time, and effort a process requires](https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/library/ja-process-burden) (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/library/ja-process-burden>)

For service and eligibility work: what the Division asks of a person before they receive anything, counted honestly.

[Access checks before a meeting, outreach, or session](https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/library/ja-access-checks) (<https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/library/ja-access-checks>)

The shortest useful thing here. A supervisor can apply it to this afternoon's meeting without preparation.

There is an entry point for each area of work in the Division: executive and division leadership; supervision and management; policy and program analysis; eligibility and service delivery; data, research and quality; budgets, grants and contracts; hiring and workforce development; community engagement and partnership; communication and accessibility; and equity practice itself. **Every level of the Division is addressed, and no one is asked to translate someone else's material into their own job.**

WHAT IT ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

Fourteen pages of the Program, in the order a member of your staff meets them, from the front door through to what they keep. Every tab is there, and each one carries a caption saying what it shows. **[Walk through the Program](#)** → p. 26

WHAT IT IS

Somewhere a staff member can go the moment a real question comes up in real work: courses and applied practice material, community briefs on the people this Division serves, short job aids, and a way to ask a question and get a substantiated answer with its sources attached. Nearly all of it can be downloaded, adapted to a unit, or handed to a colleague.

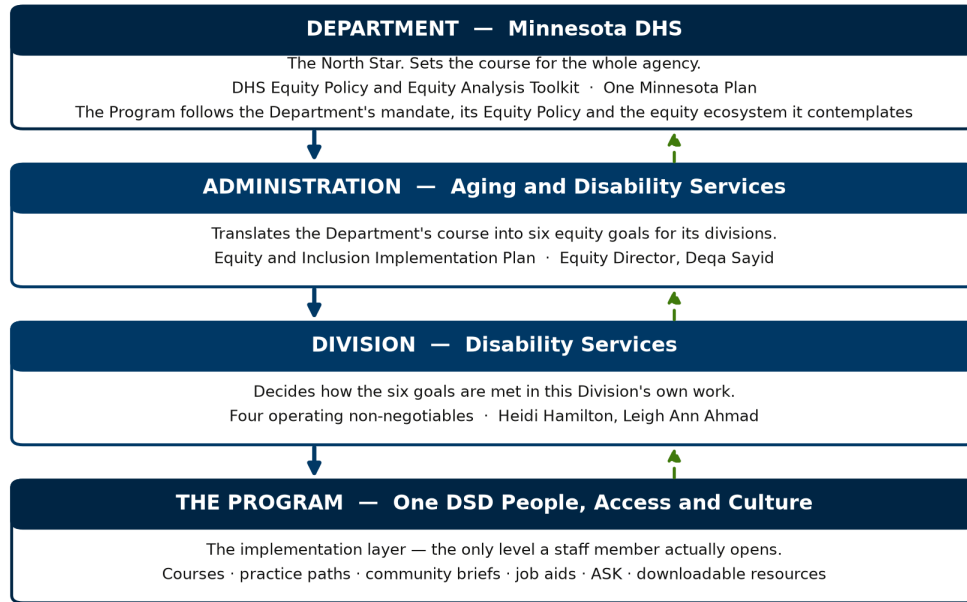
For staff, that means help at the point of need. For supervisors, material that is ready to use with a team — which matters most when preparation time is the scarcest thing you have. For you, one place to see what the Division is doing on equity, and a record you can point to whenever the Administration or the Department asks. **[What it is, and whom it serves](#)** → p. 13

HOW IT CONNECTS TO WHAT THE DEPARTMENT IS ASKING FOR

The Department sets the course. It is the North Star. My intention is to stay in alignment with the Department's mandate and its Equity Policy, working alongside the Aging and Disability Services Administration as part of the DHS equity ecosystem the Department contemplates. What I have tried to do is line the levels up, so that what we build here fits that rather than running alongside it, and to stay alert to whatever Department policy directs next so that the work here does not become disjointed from it.

AUTHORITY FLOWS DOWN

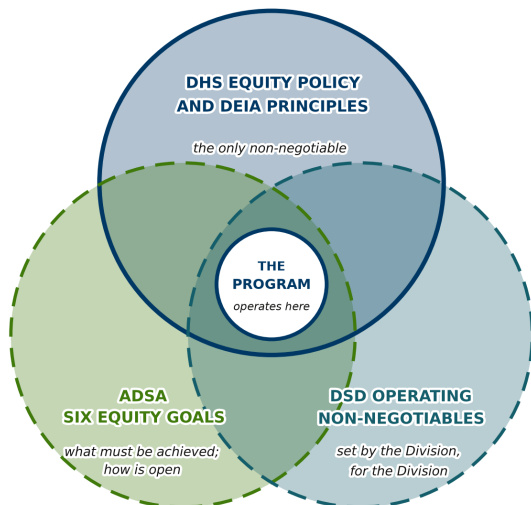
PRACTICE AND EVIDENCE FLOW UP



The Program stays in alignment with the Department's mandate and Equity Policy, working alongside the Administration within one DHS equity ecosystem. Its work is to make each level legible to the one below it, so a staff member can see how their own work connects upward.

The four levels, and the direction of authority. [How the Program connects → p. 13](#)

What is fixed, and what is flexible



One boundary is solid. The Program stays inside the DHS Equity Policy and the DEIA principles beneath it. Everything else is open: the six goals say what must be achieved, not how, and the Division's own non-negotiables are the Division's to set. The overlap is where the Program lives.

What is fixed, and what is genuinely open. [Fixed and open → p. 14](#)

Beneath that, there is real room. **The DHS Equity Policy, and the DEIA principles beneath it, are the only non-negotiable.** The Administration's six equity goals say what must be

achieved, not how — and Dega Sayid confirmed that the Division holds that discretion.

[What is fixed, and what is genuinely open → p. 14](#) · [Executing all six goals → p. 16](#) ·

[Where the organization stands → p. 16](#)

HOW THE ROLE WORKS

This is a guidance instrument. My part is to supply the knowledge, the instruments and the resources so that staff can build equity into work they already own: **the Program supplies the capability, and staff carry the work.** That is how the position was decomposed and agreed with leadership in early 2023, and the accompanying record sets it out duty by duty against what has been built. [How this role operates → p. 17](#) ·

[The position as it was decomposed and agreed → p. 18](#)

WHERE THE WORK STANDS, AND WHERE IT BEGINS

A good deal is built and a good deal remains. Three things are outstanding: a way to tell whether any of this is changing conditions for people, which is the most consequential and the one I would most value your thinking on; a defined pathway for developing leaders, which needs a decision and funding above my level; and the relationship to state law and policy.

Leigh Ann — the commitment on the pilot is unchanged. **When the Program opens, HCBS is the first unit to run it**, for whatever interval you judge right, measured for behavioral and cognitive change before anything expands. Every other unit carries on exactly as it is.

[Where this begins: the pilot in HCBS → p. 23](#)

WHAT WOULD HELP MOST

1. **Your assessment, by December 1** — whether this looks capable of genuinely helping your people, whether anything is missing, and what you would change.
2. **That staff be invited to work on this with me.** A program of this kind cannot be built well at a distance from the people it is for.
3. **A line of sight into what is under way** — the Division's OneNote, or an equivalent; for awareness, not for direction.
4. **An inventory of the equity work already under way** across the Division, so that none of us builds the same thing twice.

Several duties in the agreed decomposition name their counterpart directly — hiring managers, subject matter experts, contract managers, the DSD data team, FARM. Those parts of the work are built to be done together, and they go faster and better that way. What I am asking for is collaboration, in the ordinary sense of the word. [The four asks in full → p. 25](#)

Everything here serves something the Department has already named and that this Division is entirely capable of reaching: becoming a multicultural, anti-racist organization in daily practice, not only in commitment. In practice that means something quite specific: that when a decision is made here, more than one cultural perspective is available to the people making it, and the perspective of those the decision affects is among them. **That is work a division does together** — staff, supervisors, managers and leadership each holding a piece no one else can hold for them. My part is to make sure none of you has to invent your piece from scratch.

This is advisory, offered as a tool in service of the Division's goals, the Administration's, and the Department's. I advise, and how it is put to use is where your

judgment matters most. What I am hoping for is common ground — a shared understanding of where this work is going, and the chance to get there with you.

The memorandum in full

The landing page above carries what matters immediately. This is the complete communication, section by section — open any part directly.

Preface

An affirmation, what this memorandum is for, how the role is oriented, and what would help most.

→ p. 11

I. Origin: what the Division itself established

The 71 interviews, the 23 sessions concluding December 2023, and the question leadership itself asked after the 2024 training.

→ p. 12

II. Credit where it is due: the project manager's role

Credit where it is due: what the project manager brought, who built the Program, and why the impression was natural.

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III. What the Program is, and whom it serves

What the Program holds, and what it means for staff, for supervisors and for you.

→ p. 13

IV. How the Program connects to what the Department is asking for

Department, Administration, Division, Program — who sets what, and where direction comes from.

→ p. 13

V. What is fixed, and what is genuinely open

The DHS Equity Policy as the only non-negotiable, and how much latitude exists beneath it.

→ p. 14

VI. Executing all six goals, and how the work divides

The Equity Director's direction that the Division executes all six goals, the latitude that came with it, and the open question of how the work divides.

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VII. Where the organization stands, and the opportunity in it

Where the organization stands on the intercultural continuum, and the opportunity in it.

→ p. 16

VIII. How this role operates, and where its limits fall

How the role works, with three concrete examples of the Program supplying the capability and staff carrying the work.

→ p. 17

IX. The position as it was decomposed and agreed

The agreed decomposition of the role, crosswalked duty by duty against what has been built.

→ p. 18

X. How the work moves

The working cycle, and accountability sitting in three places at once.

→ p. 20

XI. What would help me do this well

Room for professional judgment, a line of sight into what is under way, and the appetite for this in the Division.

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XII. Where the work honestly stands

What is built, what is outstanding, and why none of it requires waiting.

→ p. 22

XIII. Where this begins: the pilot in HCBS

HCBS as the first pilot, measured for behavioral and cognitive change before any expansion.

→ p. 23

XIV. On the question of strong convictions

An answer to the question about strong convictions, and why the interest is stated openly.

→ p. 23

XV. Who leads this work, and the common understanding I am seeking

Praise for the ADSA committees, allies in the work, and the question that remains open.

→ p. 24

XVI. What would help most

The four things that would help most, set out concretely.

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XVII. A pattern worth guarding against together

A pattern worth guarding against together, and the destination all of it serves.

→ p. 26

XVIII. A walk through the Program

Fourteen pages of the Program, in the order a member of staff meets them.

→ p. 26

XIX. The supporting record

Where each supporting document sits.

→ p. 50

The supporting record

Everything referred to in the memorandum is here. There is no need to read it all — these are provided so that anything you want to look into is one click away.

01 **DHS Equity Landscape and Climate Report**

The standing assessment, offered in support: how the Department is functioning on equity, what is in place, and where the connections between the pieces could be stronger.

→ p. 51

02 **The Position, Decomposed**

The agreed decomposition of the consultant's role, co-created in early 2023 and reproduced without alteration, with what each duty requires of others.

→ p. 75

03 **Goal Allocation Worksheet**

How the six equity goals divide across the Division: what each decomposes into, who must hold it, and an owner column left blank for leadership to complete.

→ p. 80

04 **Program Requirements Document**

The executive brief: what the Program is, what it is for, what the Division gains, and how it aligns to the Administration's six equity goals.

→ p. 84

05 **Evidence Record**

The 23 division-wide sessions in full: 172 findings and 131 recommendations, attributed to teams and de-identified.

→ p. 93

06 **What the Division Said**

The axial analysis of those findings: ten categories, the central finding, and seven consultant recommendations.

→ p. 119

07 **Program Logic Model**

The chain from what was invested, to what was built, to what changes because it exists.

→ p. 128

08 **Operational Workplan**

October 2026 through June 2027: what I am working on, what it should produce, and where I will need help.

→ p. 133

09 **Reporting Process**

How progress, barriers, and decisions are tracked and reported from October 2026 forward.

→ p. 146

10 **Program Crosswalk**

The Program checked goal by goal against the DHS ecosystem and ADSA's six equity goals.

→ p. 153

11 **Three-Year Plan and Blueprint**

January 2027 through December 2029: what comes next, in order, and what is still to be built.

→ p. 159

12 **Project-Management Version**

The same plan as a timeline, a workflow diagram, a dependency map, and a decision-rights table.

→ p. 167

13 **Research and Evaluation Standard**

A working document of mine. How the Program stays steady and trustworthy over time, as people and priorities change.

→ p. 171

14 **Program Evaluation Plan**

A working document of mine. The regular checks the Program is held to as it continues.

→ p. 177

The memorandum, in full

Every section of the communication in one place. Use the contents on the landing page to go straight to a particular part.

PREFACE

Let me begin with something I want said plainly. **In my professional judgment, both of you are genuinely interested in equity and in the cultural and organizational change this work asks for.** I have witnessed both of you earnestly engaging in that work, and it is a large part of why I am glad to bring this to you now.

This memorandum sets out what the One DSD People, Access and Culture Program is, whom it serves, how it aligns with what the Department has already determined, and where the work genuinely stands. The Program is still under construction, so what I am bringing you is a work in progress rather than a finished instrument. What would help me most is your considered reading and your candid assessment by December 1. I have laid it out at length deliberately, because I would rather give you the whole picture than a tidier one.

What follows is offered in the spirit of consultation. It rests on professional judgment about how equity work is operationalized — judgment formed over twenty-two years of doing this inside organizations, no two of which have been alike. There is no template for this, and I have not worked from one here.

My orientation to the role is service: to put instruments in the hands of staff and leaders so that they can do work which belongs to them, and to credit others wherever credit is owed. The question that matters most is **what the staff of this Division genuinely need**, and my hope is that we can consider it together on that basis, above the level of any particular personality or situation, my own included.

One point belongs at the front. **What has been built is immediately usable as it stands.** A staff member could open it today and find something that answers a real question, though it is not yet open to staff and I would not want it opened before it is genuinely ready for them. The build has moved quickly and it will continue to, because I have kept it moving in the background while larger questions were being worked out above my level.

One instrument deserves naming here rather than further down, because it is the one I would most like you to open. **The Equity Analysis Toolkit companion** takes a decision someone is actually facing — a policy, a service, a change in practice — and works through it in five stages: the decision and what is genuinely still open, who is affected and how, what the options are, how affected people can influence it, and what to review before it is settled. Each stage carries a worked example to try and a place to draft the analysis of one's own work.

It has an address of its own, which opens it without the rest of the Program around it and can be forwarded to anyone who should see it: <https://one-dhs-pac.vercel.app/share/equity-toolkit>. It is the Program's companion to the Minnesota Equity Analysis Toolkit and not a substitute for it: it

submits nothing to DHS, it grants no approval, and it does not replace required review or engagement with the people a decision affects.

I. ORIGIN: WHAT THE DIVISION ITSELF ESTABLISHED

Between January and July of 2023 I conducted 71 interviews across this Division. From April of that year the inquiry widened, in collaboration with Sarah Shepherd, into 23 facilitated sessions spanning program staff through directors. **The division-wide assessment concluded in December 2023**, having produced 172 discrete findings and 131 recommendations, attributed to teams and de-identified at the individual level. That collaboration addressed general equity matters and the planning for the Program now under construction.

The finding that organizes everything since is this: what the Division exhibited was not a shortage of commitment but a shortage of infrastructure. Staff were already carrying equity work — individually, in whatever margins they could find, without common instruments, without a shared method, and without any means of determining whether their effort altered anything. One team characterized its own position precisely: willing, and in need of guidance and support on how to proceed well. Improvisation at that scale is not a culture problem. It is an operational gap, and operational gaps are addressed by building something.

The first two quarters of 2024 were given over to a different undertaking. **Maria Pabon**, an external consultant whom I vetted, was engaged to deliver basic equity training to all staff and all leadership, and that training was the bulk of what took place in that period. Sourcing outside expertise of this kind is itself one of the duties in the agreed decomposition of this position, and it is worth noting that the Division has already seen the position used that way.

At the conclusion of that series, the question leadership itself posed was what comes next, and what was to be done with what had been learned. **That question is the Program's founding premise.** Instruction concludes; the work does not. What was missing was the durable structure into which learning could be deposited and from which it could be drawn once the facilitator had left the room.

Sarah Shepherd left the agency at the end of 2024. From January 2025 I took up the work alone, and it is in that period that the main structure of the Program was completed. The pace of what has been produced since then is a matter of record, and I return to it in the next section because it bears on who built what.

II. CREDIT WHERE IT IS DUE: THE PROJECT MANAGER'S ROLE

One point of record is worth setting out, because it gives credit where it is due.

Because Sarah Shepherd, the project manager, was visible in the work, it was natural to understand her as carrying it. I want to set this out carefully, because it runs in two directions: she deserves the credit she earned, and the record of who built this should be accurate.

What she did. She was recommended by Jen Strei, the first manager I reported to on entering this Division, together with the then operations manager. What she brought was project-management expertise, and that is what she was brought for: she helped structure and organize work that had until then been solitary, and she gave the division-wide assessment reach and

continuity it would not otherwise have had. Her specialty was project management, and she brought it; in equity practice she was still developing, as many of us are. I credited her contribution at the time and I credit it now.

What was mine. The design and authorship of the Program, and two facts show it. The 71 interviews that established the need were conducted before she joined the work. And the main structure of the Program was completed after she left the agency — from January 2025 onward, working alone, I produced the bulk of what you are now looking at. The work did not pause when she left; it accelerated.

The impression that followed was a natural one, and there is a reason for it that I come back to further on, in the section on who leads this work. I record this only so that the work can be weighed on its merits, with an accurate account of who produced it.

III. WHAT THE PROGRAM IS, AND WHOM IT SERVES

The Program is an operational resource a staff member consults at the moment a question surfaces in live work. It comprises courses and applied practice material, community briefs on the populations this Division serves, concise job aids, and a facility for posing a question and receiving a substantiated answer with its sources attached. Nearly every element can be downloaded, adapted to a unit's circumstances, or transmitted to a colleague without mediation.

For staff, the relevant guidance is available at the point of need, without first locating the right person or awaiting the next scheduled training. **For supervisors and managers,** it supplies material that is ready for use with a team, which is decisive when preparation time is the scarcest resource a supervisor has. **For you and for other leaders,** it constitutes a single vantage point on what this Division is doing on equity, and a record you can point to whenever the Administration or the Department asks.

It is also, and first in order of purpose, the operating platform this role requires: the repository I draw from when preparing to facilitate, and the channel through which staff tell me what they still lack.

The courses, the curriculum, the practice material, the community briefs, the job aids and the download capability exist now and function now. What remains outstanding is the apparatus around the resource rather than the resource itself, and I set that out in section XII without minimizing it.

IV. HOW THE PROGRAM CONNECTS TO WHAT THE DEPARTMENT IS ASKING FOR

Equity work is easiest to carry when a person can see how it connects to the levels above them. The architecture below shows those connections. Four levels govern this work, each of which determines something the others do not, and the Program's function is to render each level legible to the one beneath it.



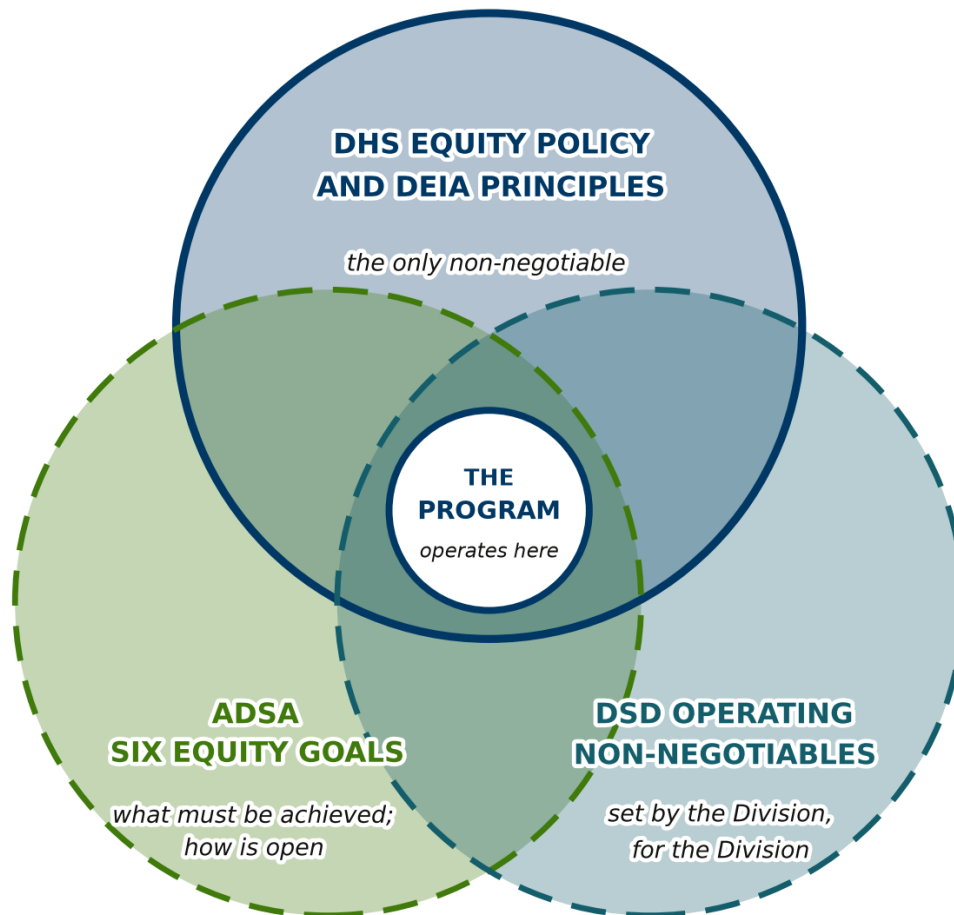
Figure 1. The four levels, what each one determines, and the direction of authority.

The Department sets the course. It is the North Star. I want to be unambiguous: my intention is to follow the Department's mandate and its Equity Policy, and to work alongside the Aging and Disability Services Administration in doing so. We are all in this together. It is all part of the DHS equity ecosystem the Department contemplates, which I hope to see rolled out in the near future, and I am trying to remain in alignment with that possibility and with everything that flows from it. I also have to recognize that Department policy and programs may direct things I cannot foresee, and I have to stay alert to those so that the work we are doing here does not become unduly disjointed from them. What I contribute is a body of resources drawn from experience in operationalizing equity, offered because I judge it capable of serving this Division, the Administration, and DHS more broadly.

V. WHAT IS FIXED, AND WHAT IS GENUINELY OPEN

One of the most useful features of the policy is how much room it leaves. Here is where the boundary sits, and how much is open beneath it.

What is fixed, and what is flexible



One boundary is solid. The Program stays inside the DHS Equity Policy and the DEIA principles beneath it. Everything else is open: the six goals say what must be achieved, not how, and the Division's own non-negotiables are the Division's to set. The overlap is where the Program lives.

Figure 2. One boundary is fixed. The remainder is open.

The DHS Equity Policy, and the DEIA principles beneath it, constitute the only non-negotiable. Everything else is eminently malleable provided it remains within those principles. The Administration's six equity goals specify what must be achieved; they do not prescribe how. That reading is not my inference alone: asked directly, Deqa Sayid, the Administration's Equity Director, affirmed that this Division is distinct and that, so long as the work remains consistent with the six goals, the Division retains discretion over the manner of their implementation. That discretion is precisely what this Program exercises.

The practical consequence is an opportunity worth naming. Across the Department, administrations and divisions are largely building their equity work in parallel. The latitude the policy affords is enough to let us connect ours with theirs, and I raise that as an opportunity worth taking.

VI. EXECUTING ALL SIX GOALS, AND HOW THE WORK DIVIDES

Leigh Ann, this section begins with a meeting we both attended, because it settled the scope of everything that follows. Before we met with Deqa Sayid, the Administration's Equity Director, the working understanding between us had been that we might concentrate on one or two of the Administration's equity goals. In that meeting she was unambiguous: **the Division is responsible for the execution of all six.** That direction is hers to set, it is consistent with the Department's own, and I support and respect it without reservation. It means the Program is built to serve all six goals rather than one or two, and that the responsibility for them is collective and belongs to the Division.

She was equally clear about something else in the same meeting, and the two statements have to be read together. **We have the freedom and the latitude to shape this work whichever way we judge best, provided it meets the Administration's goals across those six areas.** The obligation is the destination; the route is ours. That is the discretion this Program exercises, and it is why what has been built is designed for this Division rather than lifted from a template.

That changes the calculus, and it leaves one genuinely open question: **how does the work divide across this Division — who is responsible for what, staff-wise and leadership-wise?** Six goals are more than any one position can carry, and they are met through work that identifiable people own within their own areas of responsibility.

I have set out my proposal for how that division should fall in the accompanying goal allocation worksheet, which decomposes each of the six goals, names the kind of owner each part requires, and leaves the owner column itself blank because naming the owner is yours to do. Alongside it, the crosswalk sets out the starting point honestly: goal by goal, what the Program has built, what status each goal is in, and where work remains. Two of the six are substantially answered; three are partly answered, each with a specific and nameable gap rather than a general shortfall; and one — contracts and procurement — is where the most remains to be built. That is the honest starting point, and I would rather give it to you plainly.

What follows from that are workplans for managers and supervisors to use with their own staff, so that the goals are met through the Division's existing lines of supervision rather than around them. This is what the role contemplates: equity work that is the Division's own, carried through its own lines of supervision, rather than an activity one position carries on its behalf. That is how six goals become six goals in operation.

VII. WHERE THE ORGANIZATION STANDS, AND THE OPPORTUNITY IN IT

Accompanying the build, I maintain a standing assessment of how the Department is functioning with respect to equity — what exists, what is operating effectively, and where the connections

between components are attenuated. That assessment is a separate report, and I have placed it first among the accompanying documents because understanding how the organization functions is intrinsic to this role rather than incidental to it. It is offered in support. It is directed at no individual or office, and its object is to connect the equity work already under way, which I regard as promising.

Its central finding is that the Department possesses substantial foundations, and that the opportunity now is to connect learning and intention to the mechanisms that determine outcomes: budgets, contracts, data definitions, hiring, technology, and the architecture of decision-making itself.

There is a developmental dimension to this that bears stating candidly. The intercultural development work conducted within the Department, reported by Nicole Urbach, the DHS Intercultural Development Inventory coordinator, indicates that DHS as an enterprise is operating in Minimization, the orientation that emphasizes what people have in common, and from which the next step is Acceptance. The last appraisal placed DSD leadership in Acceptance already, which is a materially stronger position. The Department is moving too: the Office of Employee Culture and the Innovation and Impact team are previewing changes to our practices, which is what an organization does when it intends to grow.

This Program is built to help the organization keep moving forward. Growth of this kind asks something of all of us, and the question that matters is whether conditions are improving; the consultant develops alongside the Division, and I expect to be changed by the work as much as anyone else.

People take up equity work most readily when it is offered rather than imposed; that is well documented, and it matches my experience. It is the reason the Program is built as an invitation to learn and to reflect, which is the sequence that produces changes in behavior.

VIII. HOW THIS ROLE OPERATES, AND WHERE ITS LIMITS FALL

The position was established to serve this Division and is the only one of its kind in the Department. I collaborate with the Administration's Equity Director, and the position's work direction sits within the Division; that was written into it deliberately. This is a guidance instrument, built to support what the Division is already doing. The position was constructed with a boundary as clear as its duties: my charge is to supply the knowledge, the instruments and the resources so that staff can embed equity in work they already own.

Three examples make the boundary concrete:

- **The Program supplies the equity analysis instrument and demonstrates its application.** The manager weighing a policy change conducts that analysis on their own proposal.
- **The Program supplies the community briefs and the engagement planner.** The team entering a community conducts the engagement.
- **The Program supplies the courses, the practice paths and the job aids.** A supervisor determines what their own unit requires, and when.

In each instance the Program supplies the capability and staff carry the work. That is how the position is defined, and it is the arrangement under which equity becomes a capability the Division owns.

The resources exist so that leadership can craft and further design its own projects and programs, distinctively, according to what each area requires. The design authority stays where it belongs, with the people who own the work.

What I offer is professional judgment, honestly arrived at and honestly reported. I recommend; how it is put to use is the Division's to shape. Accountability sits in three places at once — mine, for what I produce and how faithfully I report it; staff, for what they take up; and leadership, for the determinations only leadership can make. **The DHS Equity Policy is explicit that this responsibility is shared**, and the Program is built on that: leaders, staff and consultant each carry a part, and the work goes furthest when each part is held. That is also what the DEIA principles the policy rests on describe. The Program is built to remain stable through a change in leadership, because any program resting on one individual's preferences destabilizes the moment that individual departs.

IX. THE POSITION AS IT WAS DECOMPOSED AND AGREED

In early 2023 this position was decomposed into its constituent parts, and that decomposition was agreed. It was a co-creation among three parties standing in three different relations to the work: the consultant, who knows the work; the operations manager, who wanted the work done; and the leadership team, which agreed to it. That was the operational understanding we proceeded under. The document is reproduced in full in the accompanying record, and I am setting it against what has been built so that the two can be read together.

Before the crosswalk itself, two features of the agreed document settle questions that have otherwise been left to interpretation. **The first is in the verbs.** The core duties open with provide consultation, provide expert knowledge, plan and lead and facilitate, develop recommendations, establish benchmarks, build the capacity of, lead staff and leadership to assess, work with leadership to oversee, collaborate with hiring managers, serve as technical expert, coordinate, support integration, provide expertise, provide just-in-time training. Almost without exception these are duties discharged **with** or **to** other people. The position is consultative, capacity-building and coordinating by construction. It was written as a position that works with and through others.

The second is the heading on the final section of the agreed document: “Use judgment and creativity (Secondary and/or shared duties).” The word **shared** appears in the agreement itself. The distribution of responsibility described throughout this memorandum is therefore the structure of the role as it was agreed with leadership in early 2023.

The table below sets each duty against what exists today.

The duty, as agreed	What has been built against it	Status
		Built

The duty, as agreed	What has been built against it	Status
Consultation, collaboration and leadership on the design, development and management of DEIA throughout the division, aligned to the DSD strategic plan and the DHS anti-racism initiative	The Program in its entirety, and the requirements document that governs it. Alignment traced level by level in this memorandum and goal by goal in the crosswalk.	
Expert knowledge and feedback to leadership and staff; guiding policy development, implementation and compliance	Courses, curriculum, community briefs, job aids, and a facility for asking a question and receiving a sourced answer. This memorandum and the accompanying analysis.	Built
Plan, lead and facilitate internal work groups on system and organizational culture change	The One DSD Team and Amplify Equity, and the workstream structure they run inside.	Built; needs staff time
Develop, document and present recommendations as continuous improvement	The analysis of the 2023 sessions and its seven recommendations; the reporting process; the monthly release note.	Built
Build the capacity of staff and managers; assess awareness and capacity; identify and implement professional development	The 38-module intercultural practice and equity curriculum, Intercultural Development Inventory orientation material, practice paths, and the leadership series.	Built
Establish benchmarks and targets; lead internal accountability mechanisms; collaborate with the DSD data team and FARM to measure, track and analyze effectiveness	Specified but not built. This is the largest outstanding gap in the Program, and the agreed document names the counterpart: the data team and FARM.	Not yet built
Work with leadership to oversee compliance with the DHS Equity Policy; equity considered in all DSD policies and processes	The equity analysis instrument, and the practice of conducting that analysis before a decision rather than after it.	Partly built
Promote workforce diversity with hiring managers; build pipelines of diverse talent for succession; promote consistent onboarding	Inclusive hiring and mentoring material exists. Recruitment design, succession planning and onboarding require hiring managers and Human Resources.	Partly built
Just-in-time training and consultation on equity tools, including capacity for equity analyses in legislative proposals	Job aids and the question facility are built. Legislative analysis capacity is not, and it is one of the three items named as outstanding.	Partly built
Integrate CLAS standards into grants and waiver and state plan services	Accessibility, plain language, language access and interpreter practice are built as operating standards. Their integration into grants and waiver services is not.	Partly built

The duty, as agreed	What has been built against it	Status
Culturally responsive service development; consultation to subject matter experts on policies, standard operating procedures and manuals	Community briefs, the engagement planner, and culturally responsive practice material. Consultation requires notice that a policy or manual is being revised.	Built; needs notice
Build diversity and inclusion into each phase of the contract cycle; common data elements in RFPs, scoring tools and quarterly progress reports	Nothing built. This matches, from the position's side, the finding already recorded in the crosswalk that the Administration's contracts and procurement goal has essentially no provision.	Not yet built
Secondary and shared duties: currency in the field; monitoring workforce demographics and retention; fostering culture; representing the division; assessments; employee engagement and feedback; a culture of accountability with leadership	Currency, culture, representation and feedback channels are built into how the Program operates. Demographic and retention monitoring depends on the same data access named above.	Mixed; shared by designation

Two conclusions follow. The first is that **the Program is the discharge of these duties, not an initiative running alongside them.** Every element built traces to a duty agreed in early 2023. Where the table reads “not yet built,” that is an honest gap rather than a change of direction, and each one is already named as outstanding elsewhere in this memorandum.

The second concerns what the agreement assumed. A substantial number of these duties name their counterpart in the text itself: hiring managers, subject matter experts, contract managers, the DSD data team, Fiscal Analysis and Results Management, divisional partners, division leadership. Those duties can be performed as written when that collaboration is in place. Benchmarks need the data team and FARM. Diversity in the contract cycle needs contract managers. A culturally responsive review of a policy needs notice that the policy is being written. **This is why what I ask for in section XVI is collaboration rather than endorsement.** It is not an expansion of the role; it is what the agreed decomposition already assumed would be in place.

One design point is worth drawing out, because it is the part that makes this durable. The decomposition assumed a consultant who architects and a Division that operates — and that division of labor is precisely what allows the work to outgrow any one position, including mine. The more of it that lives with the people who own the work, the less any of it depends on me being in the room. That is the outcome I am building toward, and it is the strongest argument for the collaboration set out in section XVI.

X. HOW THE WORK MOVES

The operating cycle below is the Program in motion. Its essential property is that it runs continuously.

How the work moves

*Nothing in this cycle is required of a staff member, and nothing in it is tracked against one.
The cycle runs continuously — that is the point of building it this way.*



Figure 3. The working cycle, and the division of responsibility around it.

Staff were clear on one point, and it shaped this design more than any other consideration: they want help that meets the work where it is, when it is needed. The Program is built on that principle. Nothing is compulsory, nothing must be undertaken in sequence, and nothing is recorded against an individual. A staff member takes what is useful when it is useful, and a supervisor may reconfigure any resource to suit their own unit. Equity work carries irreducible ambiguity, and a program that pretended otherwise would issue people a script that does not correspond to the work in front of them. It is built to be adapted, by design.

XI. WHAT WOULD HELP ME DO THIS WELL

What would help most is room to exercise professional judgment about method while staying squarely inside Department and Administration objectives. In practice that means letting these resources stand available at all times, which is what frees my own time for direct work with your teams and work groups. That is far and away the most valuable thing I can do for the Division, and it is the first thing lost whenever I become the sole route to every answer.

What I can offer is experience building equity programs tailored to the particular circumstances of particular organizations, and a continuing willingness to adapt this one, which is what I have been doing throughout. What no one can offer in this work is a predictive, step-by-step account of everything that will occur: equity practice is not linear, it does not end at a fixed point, and it is

conducted with human beings — some receptive, some hesitant, most somewhere in between. What I would ask is a measure of trust to build the structure, on the understanding that the conversation gets easier once there is something concrete in front of us to talk about.

The second thing would help more than anything else on this list. Where it is practical, being in the room — present where the Division's work is being planned and discussed — lets me build for what is happening rather than for what I imagine is happening. Where that is not practical, a note afterward about what is under way in an area does nearly as well. **The more of the work I can see, the better what I build will fit it.** A program built at a distance from the work fits the work less well, and I would rather build something that fits. It asks only that I be able to see the same picture you see, so that what I build is worth your people's time.

Equity work rewards a second set of eyes. This is a field where a well-intended design can land badly on the very people it was meant to serve, and where that happens it tends to fall hardest on those least able to absorb it. That is as true of my own work as of anyone's, which is exactly why I want mine looked at too. **Offering that second look is part of the function of this position.**

There is real appetite for this in the Division. More than once, staff have asked me, unprompted, for resources of exactly this kind, and that is expressly what this Program is designed to deliver. That readiness is an asset. It is here now, and it is one of the better reasons to make use of what has been built. The best use of it is the ordinary one: equity work goes better when everyone carrying it can see the whole of it, which is the familiar principle of nothing about us without us applied to ourselves as much as to the communities we serve.

XII. WHERE THE WORK HONESTLY STANDS

The work is well advanced and approaching the point of readiness. A substantial portion is built: the courses and the curriculum, the applied practice material, the community briefs, the job aids, and the capacity for any staff member to take a resource away and use it with a team. A substantial portion remains. No member of staff is using it yet, and I would not want it opened before it is genuinely ready for them. My intention is to open it across the Division in January 2027, following the November election. That date is chosen so that staff are told properly what this is before it opens; the material itself is usable now.

Three matters are outstanding. The first, and the most consequential, is establishing a means of determining whether any of this is altering conditions for people; and building a reliable instrument for seeing that is the question on which I would most value your thinking. The second is a defined pathway for developing leaders, which requires a decision and funding above my level. The third is the relationship to state law and policy, where the shape of the work remains genuinely open.

One matter should be placed beyond doubt. **If no further progress were made on the Program from today, there is already enough material in hand to begin operationalizing equity now with staff and leadership across this Division — managers, supervisors and its other leadership structures included — and to sustain that work for somewhere between one and five years.** That is not a projection. It is an inventory of what

exists. The Program will continue to evolve in coordination with the Administration and the Division, in support of the Division building and holding its own equity ecosystem, but the capacity to begin does not depend on that evolution. **It is offered in service of goals the Department has already set, and it is ready for that service now.**

One further point, offered in the same spirit. At the outset I identified several needs directly: a website, a newsletter, and occasions to recognize and celebrate the Division's work. On the first of the three I have begun: **an equity website is in development as the formal interface to the Program for all staff**, work I have been carrying on behind the scenes for the same reason as everything else set out here. Where a need is already clear, I would rather build toward it than wait, and this Program is the result of working that way. What I would most like from here is simply a closer working rhythm between the levels: my honest assessment is that the three of us in closer contact would move this further and faster than any amount of additional building on my part. That is what I am offering, and it is the part I cannot do alone.

XIII. WHERE THIS BEGINS: THE PILOT IN HCBS

Leigh Ann, this is the other commitment I want on the record. **Once the Program opens, your unit — Home and Community-Based Services — is the first to pilot it.** That commitment is unchanged. As my manager you would see firsthand what it accomplishes and what it does not, which is the correct arrangement: the person supervising this work ought to be the person best positioned to appraise it.

The design is a deliberate edge case. Rather than opening to the entire Division at once, the Program operates within a single unit for a defined interval — six months to a year, or whatever duration you judge appropriate — after which we examine whether anything changed measurably. Behavioral change first: whether staff are demonstrably conducting the work differently. Cognitive change alongside it: whether the way people construe the work has shifted. If the result withstands scrutiny, expansion across the Division proceeds on evidence rather than on assertion.

Other units continue doing exactly what they are doing. This is a controlled test within our own unit first, which is the ordinary and conservative method of introducing anything before asking an organization to adopt it.

What the pilot requires is only that the Program exist and be available, and it does. I have the means to educate, to furnish guidance, and to put resources in front of staff wherever they sit within the Division, concurrently with completing the build as it is presently architected. That matters as a point of fairness to staff, and with what is now in hand there is no reason for them to wait.

XIV. ON THE QUESTION OF STRONG CONVICTIONS

Leigh Ann, in our last meeting you raised something that has stayed with me: your sense that I appear to hold strong convictions about this work. I took it as a genuine question rather than a criticism, and I would rather answer it directly than leave it to be inferred.

The answer is yes. I do. Conviction of the kind I am describing is a positive thing. It is the reason this work is sourced, documented and open to inspection at every point. I have deliberately

constructed it so that anyone can go to the research and the underlying record and check it independently; no one has to take my word for anything.

You are also entitled to know why the conviction is there, because I would sooner state my interest than have it surmised. I am a Black man, and a member of a protected class. I belong to other marginalized groups as well, and I live with a non-apparent disability. Those facts intersect — intersectionality is not an abstraction in my case — and they mean that my interest in this work is both professional and personal. **For me this is a moral imperative.** That extends specifically to workforce matters: equitable hiring, and the other practices carrying equity implications for who is admitted, who advances, and who remains.

What I would ask is that the conviction be weighed alongside the method rather than in place of it. Holding a stake in an outcome and assessing it accurately go together when the method is visible, and I have tried throughout to keep it visible: the evidence is cited, the gaps are named as gaps, the weakest components of the Program are identified as the weakest, and the recommendation remains a recommendation. I am a better consultant for holding this work close.

XV. WHO LEADS THIS WORK, AND THE COMMON UNDERSTANDING I AM SEEKING

A word for you both, offered as praise. Equity work in open forums, and in settings that concern the Administration as a whole, is visibly **staff-led and leadership-led**, carried by colleagues on the ADSA equity and engagement committees. **I approve of it.** They are good people doing good work, and I have no question about either.

I approve of it because that is what effective practice looks like. Members of the dominant community taking the lead, and being the face of the change, is the point. At the DHS equity summit a substantial number of awards went to allies in the work, and that was exactly right — it is how a commitment becomes provable, by being converted into action by people who chose to act. **Equity work belongs to everyone in this agency**, not to people of color alone, and it asks each of us to be an active participant in it.

There is a second observation that belongs beside that one, and I want the two read together, because they are not in tension. In predominantly white organizational spaces, consultants of color frequently rely on colleagues who are white to obtain access — to carry a message into rooms that would otherwise be closed, and to reach people who do not share their background. It is a common professional reality, and it was operating in this Division's own work. **Allies stepping forward is the thing itself, and it is a good.**

The open question is a different one, and it is the question this memorandum exists to address: **what do we do with the goals that have been set forth?** That is what I am attempting to answer, in the role I hold.

That is what all of this is ultimately for. The objective is to move this organization from one centered on minimization toward acceptance and beyond. **That is the destination the work I am offering is meant to serve** — by advising, and by laying the groundwork for how an equity program can operate and what one looks like in practice.

What this memorandum is, formally, is an official communication seeking common ground: a shared understanding of how this work goes forward, and of what it was meant to achieve under the role I operate in. **That is all that is being sought here — a common understanding.**

XVI. WHAT WOULD HELP MOST

Four things would help most, and I am setting them out concretely so that none of them has to be inferred.

1. **Your assessment, by December 1**, and nothing more formal than that. It would be most useful to hear whether this appears capable of genuinely assisting your people, whether anything is absent that you would expect to find, and what you would change. I will use December to prepare how we introduce it to staff, so that people understand what this is in advance of its opening rather than simultaneously with it.
2. **That staff be invited to work with me on building this.** A program of this kind cannot be built well in isolation from the people it is for, and the quality of what the Division ends up with depends materially on that collaboration.
3. **A line of sight into what is under way — the Division's OneNote, or an equivalent.** I had that access for some six months previously, and it served exactly this purpose. This is for awareness, not for direction: what I can see, I can build for.
4. **An inventory of the equity-related work currently underway across the Division.** The reason is practical rather than procedural.

Awareness and the inventory serve the same practical purpose: making sure none of us builds the same thing twice. If something I am working on already exists somewhere in the Division, you and your teams are the only people who would know, and I would far rather hear that than spend months producing a second version of it. Knowing what is already under way also lets me build around good work rather than past it, which makes everything I produce more useful to you.

What I am offering is advice, guidance, and whatever leadership is useful to you — to staff and to leadership alike. I am glad to take either of you through any portion of it, at whatever length is useful, and I would welcome the conversation more than the reading.

Why this is written out at such length: **so that our conversation rests on the fullest picture I am able to give you.** I would rather set out the whole of it — including the parts that are unfinished, the places where the Program is weakest, and the things I am uncertain about — than present a tidier account that leaves you with less than you should have. That is the whole of what I am trying to serve here.

What is presented here is meant to be dispassionate, objective and substantiated. That is precisely why the accompanying documents carry their sources and citations throughout: the research and the underlying record are there to examine directly, so that nothing has to rest on my word alone. This has practical weight, and the Program is constructed to address what staff and leaders require now as well as what they will require subsequently.

This is advisory. It is offered as a tool in service of the Division's goals, the Administration's six equity goals, and the Department's Equity Policy. I advise, and how the Program is put to use is where your judgment matters most. My own professional judgment is

that what is presented here is sound, that it rests on defensible ground, and that it constitutes a substantial step toward where the Department has said we are going. This is what I am presenting for your consideration, and I am grateful for the time you give it.

XVII. A PATTERN WORTH GUARDING AGAINST TOGETHER

There is a pattern worth guarding against together, and I raise it as a shared risk rather than as a comment on anyone here. Equity work has a tendency, in every organization I have worked in, to soften as it travels. Nobody decides to dilute it. It happens through ordinary and well-meant adjustments — a sharper question rounded off, a measure postponed because the timing is awkward, a commitment restated in gentler terms each time it is repeated — until what remains is comfortable and no longer does very much. I have seen it happen in places where everyone involved was acting in good faith, and the way to keep this work strong is to name the pattern early and watch for it together. If you see me doing it, I would want you to say so.

This belongs with the first of those four. Where any part of this seems off to you, the most useful thing you can give me is the thinking behind that, so I can adjust rather than guess. I am asking to understand how you see it well enough to be genuinely useful to you.

A last word, and it is the one I would most like to leave with you. Everything here serves something the Department has already named and that this Division is entirely capable of reaching: becoming a multicultural, anti-racist organization in daily practice, and not only in commitment. **It is work a division does together** — not a consultant's alone, or a manager's, or a director's — and a division is the smallest thing large enough to do it. Staff, supervisors, managers and leadership each hold a piece of it that no one else can hold for them, and my part is simply to make sure none of you has to invent your piece from scratch. **What I am asking for, in the end, is the chance to do this with you.** I think we are capable of it. I would be glad to be part of it. I am ready to begin, and I would be glad to begin alongside you.

XVIII. A WALK THROUGH THE PROGRAM

What follows is the Program as a member of your staff meets it, page by page, in the order they meet them. Every tab is here. The Program was built from this branch and served on this machine, and the pages were photographed there in the One DSD view. The site itself could not be reached from the machine that took them. The images are taken from the same list of pages this record is written from, so the two cannot drift apart. Two things do not appear in a local run and are not defects of the Program: files attached to a resource, which need the program database, and live checking of current public sources, which needs the research service. Neither was fabricated and nothing in any image was altered.

Arriving. The first thirty seconds. What the Program is, and that it is for this person.

People at the heart of public service

One DSD People, Access and Culture Program

Practical support for workplace culture and equitable workforce, policy, program, and service decisions.

[Ask a question](#)

[Start with your work](#)



The idea behind the work

Operationalizing equity

Making equity a continuing part of how we plan, carry out and review our work—with the people affected by our decisions.

[Explore equity in practice](#)

An everyday example

Whose perspective could make this decision better?

When planning a meeting, consider how people can contribute before, during and afterward—and how they will hear what happened to their ideas.

Your next step

What brings you here?

[Explore all areas of work](#)

01 / Discover

Learn and explore

A fresh perspective, a useful resource, or a moment to reflect. Follow your curiosity.

[Minnesota Communities](#)

02 / Apply

Put equity into practice

Bring a decision or challenge. Find questions and tools to help you move it forward.

[Browse the resource library](#)

03 / Connect

Connect with colleagues

Share perspectives, learn together, and see how ideas take shape through One DSD.

[Find support](#)

A place to begin. Room to grow. Explore what is useful to you, at your own pace.

[Get to know the program](#)

One DSD People, Access and Culture Program

A resource for DHS staff, run by the program.

[About this resource](#)

Find your next step

[Ask a question](#)

[Library](#)

[Minnesota Communities](#)

[Support and DSD consultation guidance](#)

[Find the right person or office](#)

Privacy and access

Please leave out case, medical, personnel, complaint, and identifying details anywhere in this program. Notes you write are saved only on this computer, so another person who uses it could see them. If any part of the program is hard to use with assistive technology, Support explains how to tell us.

The front door — /. The home page as a Disability Services Division staff member first sees it, with the One DSD view selected. The opening line is “Practical support for workplace culture and equitable workforce, policy, program, and service decisions.” Two buttons, Ask a question and Start with your work, are the whole of what is asked of a newcomer.

Begin with the work in front of you

Where would you like to start?

Choose your role, the kind of work you are doing, and when you need to act. You will get a good place to begin, and the reason it fits.

New here, or taking a fresh look?

See how the whole program fits together and discover a place to begin.

[Explore the program
orientation →](#)

► One DSD

[Open the One DSD program map](#)

Three short choices

Tell us where the work sits

Choose the closest answer. You can change your answers at any time.

What role are you bringing to this work?

Choose a role ▼

What kind of work are you doing?

Choose an area of work ▼

When do you need to act?

- ☐ I'm planning ahead
- ☐ I need support within two weeks
- ☐ I have a firm deadline
- ☐ The work is already in use and needs prompt attention

Show a place to start

A good place to begin

A practical next step will appear here

Your answers here are not saved. They are not scored or sent to a supervisor.

These optional questions help you find a place to begin. Your choices stay on this page and disappear when you leave it.

One DSD People, Access and Culture Program

A resource for DHS staff, run by the program.

► About this resource

Find your next step

[Ask a question](#)

[Library](#)

[Minnesota Communities](#)

[Support and DSD consultation guidance](#)

[Find the right person or office](#)

Privacy and access

Please leave out case, medical, personnel, complaint, and identifying details anywhere in this program. Notes you write are saved only on this computer, so another person who uses it could see them. If any part of the program is hard to use with assistive technology, Support explains how to tell us.

Three questions, then a route — /start. The Start page asks three short questions — what role you bring, what kind of work you are doing, and when you need to act — and returns a practical next step. It states on the page that the answers are not saved, not scored, and not sent to a supervisor.

Finding the work. Entry by responsibility rather than by subject. This is where the 360-degree view is visible.

Equity in everyday decisions

Areas of work

Enter through the decision or practice you are responsible for. Each area connects knowledge, questions, tools, a practice path, and the people who hold the relevant authority.

► One DSD

[Open the One DSD program map](#)

Jump to an area

Choose the work closest to yours

Workforce equity

Policy, program, and service design

Community engagement and co-design

Accessibility and language access

Culture, trust, and repair

Leadership and systems change

Data, research, quality, and measurement

Fiscal, grants, procurement, and contracts

Communications and public information

Area 1 of 9

Workforce equity

Build fair opportunities and working conditions across the employee experience.

Work this area can support

- Design a position and its qualifications
- Review recruitment, selection, onboarding, pay, or classification
- Plan advancement, sponsorship, stay conversations, retention, or exit learning

[Workforce equity and the employee lifecycle](#)

[Ask a question](#)

[Find reviewed material](#)

[Start a practice path](#)

[Find the right person](#)

Area 2 of 9

Policy, program, and service design

Shape decisions and services with attention to access, burden, resources, and real-world effects.

Work this area can support

- Complete an equity scan or analysis
- Review a policy, form, notice, budget, or service design
- Plan implementation and a useful review cycle

[Equitable policy, program, and service design](#)

[Ask a question](#)

[Find reviewed material](#)

[Start a practice path](#)

[Find the right person](#)

Area 3 of 9

Community engagement and co-design

Plan respectful participation, shared influence, access, feedback, and lasting relationships.

Work this area can support

- Plan engagement, listening, outreach, or co-design
- Consider compensation, language, access, and feedback loops
- Follow the separate Tribal consultation process when it applies

[Community engagement and co-design](#)

[Ask a question](#)

[Find reviewed material](#)

[Start a practice path](#)

[Find the right person](#)

Area 4 of 9

Accessibility and language access

Make information, services, meetings, and media usable across disability and language needs.

Work this area can support

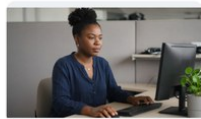
- Review a document, digital service, meeting, or multimedia item

Nine doors, one for each kind of responsibility — /areas. Areas of work is entry by responsibility rather than by subject. Nine areas run from workforce equity through policy and service design to leadership and systems change, and each one gathers the knowledge, questions, tools, practice path and the person who holds the relevant authority.

Learning. What a staff member can actually study, and what a course looks like inside.

The screenshot shows the 'Learning and resources' page of the Department of Human Services website. The header includes the department logo, the 'One DSD People, Access and Culture Program' title, and buttons for 'Share', 'One DHS', and 'One DSD'. A navigation bar contains links for 'Home', 'Start', 'Ask', 'Areas of work', 'Learning and resources' (which is highlighted), 'Practice', 'One DSD', 'Support', and 'My Work'. The main content area features the heading 'KNOWLEDGE FOR EVERYDAY PRACTICE' followed by 'Learning and resources' in a large font. Below this is a sub-header: 'Knowledge, practical tools, and perspectives for fair services and inclusive workplaces.' Three links are provided: 'Explore the collection ↓', 'Bring a question to ASK →', and 'Research and sources →'. The page is divided into two columns. The left column has a light blue background and contains the heading 'Find a path from learning to practice', a paragraph about curiosity and adaptation, and a link 'Explore intercultural learning →'. The right column has a white background and contains the heading 'PUT LEARNING INTO PRACTICE' followed by 'Equity Analysis Toolkit' and a paragraph about examining decisions and preparing for conversations. Below these columns is a horizontal menu with links: 'Courses and learning', 'Tools and resources', 'Podcasts', 'Ways to grow', and 'Practice paths'. A search section follows, with a 'Search learning and resources' label, a search input field, and a 'Search' button. Below the search field are two dropdown menus: 'Explore by theme' (set to 'All themes') and 'Format' (set to 'All formats'). A row of six topic tags is displayed: 'Workplace culture and well-being', 'Intercultural practice', 'Accessibility and responsive services', 'Anti-racism and structural equity', 'Community partnership and planning', and 'Learning together'. At the bottom of the search section, it says '240 resources found'. The page ends with the heading 'Learning modules'.

Learning and resources — /learn. Learning and resources is one page, not two systems. Courses, tools, podcasts, ways to grow and practice paths sit behind a single row of links, with the Equity Analysis Toolkit given its own place, so nobody has to guess which of four places holds what they need.



Native American (Compass profile — not the 11 nations)

A compact, practice-first guide for learning without turning people into checklists.

Learning



Disability, Diversity and Belonging

Who is already in the room, what a barrier actually is, and why being present is not the same as belonging.

Learning



Disability Models and Perspectives

Learn six ways of seeing disability, notice which one your team reaches for first, and use a barrier-removal view on a real decision.

Learning



Language, Etiquette and Respectful Interaction

Choose words that describe rather than define, ask before helping, speak to the person, and handle interpreters, communication devices and service animals with...

Learning



Accessibility Basics

Find the barriers hiding in rooms, documents, meetings, videos and emergency plans, and fix the ones you own before anyone has to ask.

Learning



Allyship, Accountability and Everyday Action

Notice ableism in ordinary assumptions, interrupt exclusion without speaking over anyone, build access into what you already own, and know how to escalate when...

Learning



Access Needs and Individualized Support

Tell equal treatment from equitable access, ask about needs without asking for a diagnosis, and keep the person in charge of their own decisions.

Learning



Inclusive Communication Across Disabilities

Adapt how you communicate for Deaf and hard-of-hearing people, people with speech disabilities, blind and low-vision people, people with cognitive disabilities...

Learning



The course selection — /learn. Part of the course selection, in the two-column tile format every published course uses. This band is the disability sequence and its leadership courses; the tiles carry the course title, a short program-authored description and a photograph, and open the whole course.

Disability, Diversity and Belonging

Who is already in the room, what a barrier actually is, and why being present is not the same as belonging.

45-50 minutes · 4 lessons

You're viewing a shared link to this course only. It doesn't include the rest of the program.



Lessons [Disability, diversity and belonging](#) [Sources and further reading](#)

About one in four adults in the United States lives with a disability, and most disabilities are not visible. That means disabled people are already your colleagues, your applicants, the households you serve and the partners you meet. This course gives you four words to keep apart, a way to see barriers before someone is stopped by one, and a clear picture of the difference between being present and belonging. It is the foundation for every other course in the series.

What you'll be able to do

Explore and practice

Describe disability as a common, varied part of human diversity, including non-apparent, episodic and acquired disability.

Distinguish impairment, disability, access need and disabling barrier in a real workplace or service example.

Identify at least four sources of barriers: design, policy, training, attitude, communication and assumption.

Explain the difference between presence and belonging using participation, agency, influence and return.

Complete a barrier map of one process you touch and name one barrier you will look for.

What you can take into your work

A sorting exercise separating facts, barriers and assumptions.

A knowledge check in every lesson with feedback that explains the inclusive answer.

A completed barrier map and one written commitment.

Walk one process you own as a participant would, registration, a meeting, a form, a notice or an application, and record the first barrier you find, who owns it, and what you will do about it.

Explore the lessons

- | | | |
|-------|---|------------|
| 01 | Disability is ordinary: who is already in the room
How common disability is, how varied it is, and why "we do not serve people with disabilities here" is never true of any DHS team. | 12 minutes |
| <hr/> | | |
| 02 | Four words, kept apart
Impairment, disability, access need and barrier are not synonyms. Keeping them apart is what lets you fix the right thing. | 12 minutes |
| <hr/> | | |
| 03 | Presence is not belonging
A disabled person in the room proves nothing. Participation, agency, influence and the wish to come back are what inclusion looks like. | 12 minutes |
| <hr/> | | |
| 04 | Your barrier map
Walk one process as a participant would, find where a person is stopped, name the owner, and commit to the first fix. | 12 minutes |

Disability, diversity and belonging

One page for any staff member, any process

One in four. Most of them you cannot see. Fix the design, not the person.

Inside a course — /share/courses/di-disability-diversity-belonging. A course opened: Disability, Diversity and Belonging, the foundation of the disability sequence. Forty-five to fifty minutes, four lessons, and a stated set of things a person will be able to do afterwards rather than a list of things they will have been shown.

QUESTION BANK · DEEPER METHOD

Equity impact questions for policy, budget, technology, and procurement

Use this short question set for high-stakes decisions. Consider which authority and rights apply, who benefits, who carries the burden, which assumptions shape the outcome, what can change, and what must stay with the responsible official.

Attached files are not connected in this environment. Audio, images, and documents for this resource are not shown.

Download this resource: [Word](#) [Excel](#) [PowerPoint](#) [PDF](#)

Prepared by Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant. Planned review March 1, 2027. For: One DHS People, Access and Culture Program.

Guidance A practical job aid or checklist from this program. Confirm policy questions with the person responsible for that policy.

Why this matters

These questions can help frame a decision, but they are not legal advice and do not make the decision for you. After working through them, seek guidance from the appropriate person if a high-stakes procurement, budget, or policy decision has a significant equity impact and no official guidance.

1. Policy: Which laws, rules, rights, and required safeguards apply? Who benefits, who carries added work or risk, and whose needs are missing? Which rules or routine practices shape the result? What can your team change, and what must be reviewed by the person with authority to decide?
2. Budget: Which costs cover interpreting, translation, accessible formats, and payment for community partners? Which costs have been treated as free? If funding is reduced, whose services would be affected first?
3. Technology: Are accessibility requirements written into the specifications and tested by people who use assistive technology? What information is collected? Could it be used to sort, rank, or profile people?
4. Procurement: Do the selection criteria give real weight to accessibility, language access, and community knowledge? Do the requirements create unnecessary barriers for small providers or community organizations?

You're viewing a shared link to this resource only. It doesn't include the rest of the program.

Please leave out case, medical, personnel, complaint, and identifying details anywhere in this program. It is not connected to DHS information systems, does not hold DHS case or personnel records, and does not replace decisions made by responsible department offices.

A job aid, ready to use in the meeting you are already in — /share/library/ja-equity-impact-questions. A job aid, opened on its own address. Equity impact questions for policy, budget, technology, and procurement is four numbered question sets a person can work through before a high-stakes decision, downloadable as Word, Excel, PowerPoint or PDF, and explicit that it frames a decision rather than making it.

Doing the work. Where the Program stops being reading and becomes a work product.

Turn understanding into useful work

Practice

Create a checklist, analysis, plan, agenda, or review for work you are doing now.
Your notes stay in this browser on this computer unless you choose to share them.

► One DSD

[Open the One DSD program map](#)

[Explore how guided practice connects to operationalizing equity](#)

Find a path from learning to practice

[Explore intercultural learning](#)

Choose a starting point

Guided practice paths

Each guided practice connects questions, reviewed material, working notes, a private self-review, and a way to reach the right person if you want one. Nothing here scores or ranks you.

I'm planning something new

New program or service concept

You have a program idea and want a clear way to consider equity and access before the design is settled.

CREATES

Equity and access planning checklist

I'm changing a form, notice, or policy

Policy, form, or notice change

You are preparing a policy, form, notice, or letter and want to make sure it is clear, accessible, and workable for the people who will use it.

CREATES

Change impact notes and access checklist

I'm planning work with a community

Community engagement or co-design effort

You are planning community engagement and want the work to be respectful, useful, and grounded in what people actually need.

CREATES

Engagement plan

I'm strengthening team climate

Workplace culture and team climate

You have noticed a concern with participation or team climate and want practical ways to improve everyday team practices.

CREATES

Team climate action plan

I'm planning a session

Planning a learning or facilitation session

You have a session to lead and want participants to leave with something they can use in their work.

CREATES

Session plan

I'm hiring or designing a role

Inclusive hiring and selection

You are responsible for a hiring process and want it to find capable people the current process may be screening out.

CREATES

Inclusive hiring plan

I'm making or shaping a decision that needs an equity look

Equity analysis for a decision

CREATES

Turn understanding into a useful work product — /practice. Practice is where the Program stops being reading. A guided practice path produces a real work product — a checklist, an analysis, a plan, an agenda or a review — for work the person is doing now, and the page states that nothing there scores or ranks anyone.

Equity Analysis Toolkit

Examine how a decision may affect people differently, consider alternatives, and prepare for a conversation about what should happen next.

These five learning stages are a program companion, not the official toolkit sequence. Optional practice does not replace the toolkit, required review, or engagement with affected people.

[Optional practice](#) [Your actual work](#) [Toolkit and related resources](#)

You're viewing a shared link to this toolkit only. It doesn't include the rest of the program.



DHS equity policy and toolkit

Listen to the podcast about DHS equity policy and the toolkit.

▶ 0:00 / 0:00

Share

[Open the podcast page](#)

Choose a chapter

[Play from 0:00 · Policy purpose and who it applies to](#)

[Play from 2:34 · Roles, tools and administration goals](#)

[Play from 9:27 · Applying the policy in decisions and daily work](#)

[Play from 15:44 · Shared terms: access, equity and engagement](#)

[Play from 26:51 · The equity analysis quick guide](#)

[Play from 29:33 · Steps 1-3: outcomes, data and engagement](#)

[Play from 33:45 · Steps 4-8: impacts, accountability and sustainability](#)

[Play from 38:29 · The equity scan](#)

[Play from 41:47 · Using the tools, collaborating and checking progress](#)

This transcript has not been checked word for word against the recording. Listen to the recording before quoting it.

▶ [Read the complete transcript](#)

Your area of work

Choose an area to connect the example with your responsibilities. You can explore any area.

Explore without choosing an area

1. Describe the decision

2. Consider who may be affected

3. Compare possible approaches

4. Plan participation and action

5. Review and revisit

Describe the decision

The Equity Analysis Toolkit — </share/equity-toolkit>. The Equity Analysis Toolkit companion, on the standalone address that can be forwarded on its own. It says plainly on the page that its five learning stages are a program companion and not the official toolkit sequence, and that optional practice does not replace the toolkit, required review, or engagement with affected people.

Ask on your own

Ask

Ask about any subject, work through a question, get help with writing or calculations, and find program resources. Ask can also check current public sources when helpful.

What would you like help thinking through?

Ask about any subject, request help with writing or a calculation, or find a program resource. Up to four recent questions and answers are sent with your question to help answer follow-ups. Your most recent ASK draft is also included for context until you start a new topic or clear the conversation. Leave out private or confidential information about people.

For example: We're planning a new digital application for benefits renewals. What equity questions should we consider before making design decisions?

Where should Ask look?

Answer the question; check current public sources when helpful

Current public sources are not available right now. Ask can still help with general knowledge and available program resources, and will identify facts it cannot verify.

Ask can help with general questions on any subject. Questions and responses are kept so the program owner can review them and improve the service. Clearing your history in this tab does not delete that copy. Up to four recent questions and answers are sent with your question to help answer follow-ups. Your most recent ASK draft is also included for context until you start a new topic or clear the conversation. For public-source research, only the current question is sent to an outside research service. Do not include names, private case details, medical or personnel information, confidential material, or anything else that should stay private.

Get an answer

Search the Library instead

How answers work

- Ask can explain any subject, help with writing and calculations, and connect you with program resources.
- You can ask follow-up questions. Up to four recent answers from this conversation help Ask understand what you mean.
- Public information appears separately from program resources. Check important details at the original source before you act.
- Ask can help you think through your work. It does not create official policy or make decisions for you.
- You will see steps you can take before the option to preview a DSD consultation request.
- You can review or clear your question history from My Work.

If an answer is not enough

Choose Preview a consultation request to review what would be shared if submissions open. No consultation request is created or scheduled, and the form content is not stored.

► Your privacy and program view

One DSD People, Access and Culture Program

A resource for DHS staff, run by the program.

► About this resource

Find your next step

[Ask a question](#)

[Library](#)

[Minnesota Communities](#)

[Support and DSD consultation guidance](#)

[Find the right person or office](#)

Privacy and access

Please leave out case, medical, personnel, complaint, and identifying details anywhere in this program. Notes you write are saved only on this computer, so another person who uses it could see them. If any part of the program is hard to use with assistive technology, Support explains how to tell us.

Ask a real question and get a substantiated answer — /ask. Ask, with a real question typed in: how to make a hiring panel accessible for a candidate who is Deaf. It is not limited to a fixed list of program topics — it can reason, use the Program's own material, and check current public sources. The panel beside it sets out how answers work and what Ask will not do, including that it does not create official policy or make decisions.

The Division's own program. Where One DSD stops being a copy of One DHS and becomes the Division's.

The Disability Services Division reference program

One DSD

One DSD shows how the shared People, Access and Culture foundation can become a complete, practical program within a division. It adds DSD situations, services, relationships, and learning while remaining connected to One DHS.

One DSD view is active. Shared One DHS material stays available, with DSD examples, scenarios, and support added.

People and connection

Programs and services

Practice situations

Areas of work

Support

One DSD Team

Colleagues working together to make equity part of everyday decisions, programs, and services.

Amplify Equity

Connect with colleagues, explore something new, or bring an idea that could make everyday work better. Find what interests you and take part in a way that fits.

The shared foundation

What One DSD inherits

- Reviewed One DHS knowledge, sources, and practical tools
- Shared standards for privacy, participation, and accessibility
- Shared learning stages and ways to enter through real work
- Clear ways to reach the people and offices that hold the authority to decide

Choose what would help

Use One DSD in the flow of work

Understand and learn

Build from a welcoming introduction through intercultural practice, structural analysis, and systems change without being scored.

[Explore learning](#)

Prepare with community context

Use reviewed, question-led material to plan access and engagement without treating group information as a label for a person.

[Explore Minnesota Communities](#)

Where equity shows up in DSD work

► Find a program through a work question

The DSD layer

What One DSD adds

- DSD examples, scenarios, programs, and service-delivery applications
- Division-specific learning, facilitation, and practice support
- A One DSD collaboration space for authorized participants
- Direct consultation for eligible DSD work

Apply the work

Use questions, checklists, reviews, and working tools to shape a program, policy, service, meeting, or workforce decision.

[Open Practice](#)

Find support

Work independently when that is enough, identify the responsible person, or request a DSD consultation when the work is eligible.

[Review support choices](#)

Home and community-based services policy and waivers

Equity entry points

Sets policy for waiver and community-based services, including eligibility, service menus, rates, and provider standards.

- Who gets which service mix and why
- Burden of documentation and authorization steps
- Language and format of notices
- Provider capacity in different communities

One DSD — /one-dsd. The One DSD tab is where the shared foundation becomes the Division's own. A banner confirms the One DSD view is active, and DSD situations, services, relationships and learning are added while everything shared with One DHS stays available.

← One DSD

Download this page:

Word

Excel

PowerPoint

PDF

PEOPLE GROW. LEADERSHIP GROWS WITH THEM.

Grow your DEIA leadership

Bring your experience, your curiosity, and the kind of leader you want to become. Develop a practice that makes equity, inclusion, and accessibility part of how DSD works.

Explore DEIA in the practice of leadership—whether you are discovering your potential, supporting a team, or shaping the division's future.

[Find your starting point →](#)



[Your starting point](#)

[The employee life cycle](#)

[Your development](#)

[Succession in practice](#)

[Learning and colleagues](#)

Learn. Reflect. Practice. Return.

Diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility shape how we interpret experience, distribute opportunities, and make decisions. This One DSD experience brings One DHS learning into the employee life cycle, with room to examine assumptions and improve the conditions in which people work.

Learn

Explore a resource and the leadership decision it can inform.

Reflect

Separate what you observed from what you assumed. Consider whose perspective is missing.

Practice

Try a supported change or work through a realistic situation.

Return

Seek feedback, examine what happened, and decide what to keep or change.

Your interest is a starting point

You can begin through your own curiosity, an encouraging conversation, or a desire to strengthen your current practice. No nomination or minimum service is needed to explore this learning experience.

I want to explore leadership

Your own curiosity is enough to begin. Explore what leadership could mean for you, with or without a future management role.

Someone has encouraged me

An invitation can open a possibility. You decide whether it fits your interests and what you would like to explore.

I want to strengthen my leadership

Bring a decision, a recurring challenge, or a skill you want to refresh. Use your experience as a starting point for deeper DEIA practice.

I want to explore leadership

Leadership can begin in how you listen, explain a decision, or make room for another person's contribution. Through a DEIA lens, the question is also whose experience informs the work and who can access the opportunity to shape it.

You may already bring relevant experience from community work, professional practice, caregiving, or collaboration. Connect that experience with a specific capability and test it in a manageable situation. Feedback helps you see both your contribution and what you want to

What is here for leadership specifically — </one-dsd/leadership>. The leadership material inside One DSD, headed “Grow your DEIA leadership”. It runs from a starting point through the employee life cycle, personal development, succession in practice, and learning with colleagues, and the whole page can be taken away as Word, Excel, PowerPoint or PDF.

Getting help, and keeping the work. What happens when the Program is not enough on its own.

Find the right support

Support

Work independently when that is enough, or connect with the person who holds the needed responsibility. One DSD also offers direct consultation for eligible DSD work.

► One DSD

[Open the One DSD program map](#)

[DHS offices and guidance](#)

Ask



Ask a general work question and receive an answer with clear sources and limits. No meeting is needed.

Library



Find reviewed checklists, job aids, learning material, and practice guidance.

Find the right person



Match the work to the responsible supervisor, Equity Director or Specialist, policy owner, or other office.

Explore an area of work



Begin with the decision, task, or professional practice in front of you.

One DSD support

Preview a consultation request

See the questions and summary a request would include. Requests are not open yet, so nothing is saved or sent.

[See what a request includes](#)

When another team can help

Complaints, investigations, grievances, accommodation decisions, and discipline about a named person go to Employee Culture, Human Resources, or the civil-rights channel. Legal interpretation goes to the policy or legal owner. Anything touching a Tribal Nation goes to the Office of Indian Policy or your Tribal liaison first.

[Find the right person for this work](#)

Found an access barrier?

This program aims to meet the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2, Level AA. If something does not work with your assistive technology, tell your Equity Director or the person who maintains this program so the barrier can be reviewed promptly.

Share a result

Tell us about a change you tried and what happened. Your experience can help improve the program.

One DSD People, Access and Culture Program

A resource for DHS staff, run by the program.

► [About this resource](#)

Find your next step

[Ask a question](#)

[Library](#)

[Minnesota Communities](#)

[Support and DSD consultation guidance](#)

[Find the right person or office](#)

Privacy and access

Please leave out case, medical, personnel, complaint, and identifying details anywhere in this program. Notes you write are saved only on this computer, so another person who uses it could see them. If any part of the program is hard to use with assistive technology, Support explains how to tell us.

Work independently, or find the person who decides — /support. Support is the honest edge of the Program. Ask, the Library, finding the right person and exploring an area of work sit together, and a panel names what belongs elsewhere: complaints, investigations, grievances, accommodation decisions and discipline go to Employee Culture, Human Resources or the civil-rights channel, and anything touching a Tribal Nation goes to the Office of Indian Policy or the Tribal liaison first. Consultation requests are not open yet, and the page says so rather than taking a request it cannot answer.

Your work, saved on this computer

My Work

Return to working notes, learning progress, recent Ask history, and consultation references you chose to save. You can remove them at any time.

Learning for your work

Different responsibilities call for different examples and tools. Explore a starting point that fits what you are doing today.

Working notes

No working notes yet. Start a learning path when you are ready.

Path progress

No path progress yet.

Saved consultation references

No consultation references are saved on this computer.

Recent Ask questions

No recent Ask questions.

Your privacy and choices

- Consultation requests are not open yet. Nothing you enter is sent or saved for the Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant.
- Removing a saved reference clears its reference number and access key from this computer. It does not withdraw a request that was already submitted.

Delete everything saved here

Your saved notes, progress, and request references stay on this device until you delete them. Recent Ask conversations on this computer disappear when you clear them or close the tab; the program owner's copy stays. Anyone using this computer may see this information; it is not sent to your supervisor.

Deleting a saved request reference here does not withdraw or delete a submitted consultation request.

► **See how one meeting change can lead to learning**

One DSD People, Access and Culture Program

A resource for DHS staff, run by the program.

► About this resource

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What the person keeps — /my-work. My Work is the whole of what the Program keeps, and it keeps it on the person's own computer. Working notes, path progress, saved consultation references and recent Ask questions, each removable, with a single control to delete everything. There is no sign-in and no staff record of who studied what.

XIX. THE SUPPORTING RECORD

The One DSD People, Access and Culture package — opens in any browser — nothing to install, and no link capable of expiring

There is no expectation that you read it in full. It opens with the equity landscape and climate report, and then holds the Program's requirements document, the complete record of what staff said, the analysis of those findings, the operational workplan for the coming months, the three-year plan beyond it, and the process by which I intend to keep you informed.

DHS Equity Landscape and Climate Report

The standing assessment, offered in support: how the Department is functioning on equity, what is in place, and where the connections between the pieces could be stronger.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
DATE	August 2026
DOCUMENT	Leadership companion report
POSTURE	Offered in support of the equity work already under way across the agency

Executive update: One DHS as equity infrastructure

Leadership finding. The One DHS prototype is a credible strategy for making trusted equity knowledge easier for DHS staff to find, understand, apply, and improve. Its promise is not simply that resources are placed on one website. Its value is that a governed platform can connect learning, tools, examples, reflection, practitioner expertise, and feedback at the moment staff need them.

Why this strengthens the climate strategy

- It reduces friction created by scattered resources and inconsistent pathways to guidance.
- It supports self-directed learning that staff can enter by task, role, question, or level of prior knowledge.
- It converts practitioner expertise into durable organizational memory rather than leaving knowledge in isolated teams or individuals.
- It gives equity tools a visible operational home while connecting users to human consultation when a resource alone is insufficient.
- It creates a practical feedback loop in which staff questions, search behavior, and contribution patterns identify gaps in policy, guidance, training, and implementation.

Research validation

The approach is consistent with public-sector evidence and guidance. Digital.gov and the U.S. Web Design System emphasize user needs, accessibility, search, authoritative content, governance, measurement, and empowered content teams. CDC has implemented a self-guided, web-accessible Foundations of Health Equity training plan. OPM describes repositories, collaboration tools, and communities of practice as infrastructure for continuous learning, knowledge documentation, sharing, and innovation. GAO has repeatedly identified fragmentation, underused guidance, and the value of enterprise solutions, while also warning that a dashboard or platform must be evaluated through actual use, feedback, and mission value.

Featured DHS learning resource

What is Equity at DHS? — audio and transcript. This multimodal resource supports flexible access and gives staff a common point of entry into the department's equity context.

Conditions for responsible adoption

- **Governance:** Name content owners, publication authority, review cadence, version history, and retirement rules.
- **Trust:** Identify authoritative sources, dates, publication status, and the distinction between official guidance and community contribution.
- **Accessibility:** Require keyboard and screen-reader testing, captions and transcripts, alternative text, readable structure, contrast, and document remediation.
- **Privacy and security:** Collect no personally identifiable information for prototype use; establish approved upload types, moderation, records, retention, and security review.
- **Participation:** Provide contribution and feedback pathways without implying that every submission is approved policy or guidance.
- **Measurement:** Measure task success, time to trusted information, comprehension, confidence, application, accessibility, content freshness, and referrals for human support — not page views alone.

Recommended disposition

Continue as a governed, co-designed prototype. Use a bounded 90-day learning pilot before broader adoption. Expansion should remain conditional on demonstrated staff value, accessibility, content stewardship, privacy and security readiness, and a sustainable operating model.

Ninety-day learning pilot

1. **Baseline.** Confirm priority staff journeys, inventory current resources, and establish findability, confidence, and accessibility baselines.
2. **Co-design.** Test the experience with leaders, equity professionals, frontline staff, program staff, and people with different access needs.
3. **Pilot.** Release a governed collection for selected use cases, support it with office hours or consultation, and capture structured feedback.
4. **Decide.** Continue, revise, or stop based on evidence; define ownership, operating cost, and resource commitments before scale.

“Pilot decision standard. Staff can find trusted resources faster, understand how to apply them, and identify when additional human support is needed. The platform also produces actionable evidence about missing, outdated, inaccessible, or difficult-to-apply resources.”

Purpose, posture, and scope

“Important framing. This observational report is not an attack on DHS leadership, its employees, or the equity work currently underway across the agency. It is a standard assessment and opportunity-forward document intended to complement the department's existing efforts. It is not written in opposition to, and is not proposed as a replacement for, DHS equity work. In the view of the Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant, that work is promising writ large. The purpose here is to help connect and strengthen it through a systemic and integrated framework — moving from Hearts and Minds equity, to institutional and structural analysis, to practical recommendations and reforms.”

This report uses the term climate to describe the conditions in which equity work is understood, supported, implemented, experienced, and sustained. Climate includes the agency's stated commitments and the everyday signals that shape whether people believe those commitments are real: how decisions are made, whose knowledge counts, how burdens are distributed, what resources are available, how leaders respond to evidence, and whether communities and employees can see their influence in the system.

The report is designed for reflection, alignment, and action. It recognizes that DHS operates in a complex state-county-Tribal-provider environment and that some human services functions now sit across more than one state agency. It therefore focuses on the connections among policy, operations, data, workforce, procurement, accessibility, community partnership, and performance rather than assigning every outcome to a single office.

Scope and accuracy note. The report draws on the source material provided for this rewrite, including public information about DHS, the Department of Children, Youth, and Families, Minnesota's human services performance system, language and disability access requirements, procurement mechanisms, Medicaid equity work, MNbenefits, and the Olmstead planning process. Agency pages, statutory schedules, and program details should be rechecked before this report is used as a formal policy, legal, fiscal, legislative, or public accountability record.

Executive summary

DHS has meaningful equity foundations. Its strategic plan, Equity Policy, toolkit, performance-management work, language and disability access expectations, community partnerships, modernization efforts, and program-specific initiatives demonstrate that equity is already present in the department's formal direction and daily work. The central opportunity is not to start equity work over. It is to make the existing work more connected, visible, resourced, and consequential across the operating system.

The climate observed in the source material is best understood as a transition point. Hearts and Minds work — learning, intention, cultural awareness, reflection, and relationship-building — is necessary and promising. The next opportunity is to connect that work to the institutional structures that determine outcomes: policy and budget gates, technology design, eligibility and

service workflows, data definitions, contracts, workforce systems, interagency agreements, and corrective-action routines.

A complementary equity operating system would allow DHS to answer five practical questions for any priority disparity: where is the burden or unequal outcome occurring; who has authority to change the condition; what resources and partners are required; how will progress be measured; and what will happen if the expected improvement does not occur?

The recommendations in this report are intentionally forward-looking. They call for an enterprise Equity Operations Council, an equity portfolio and stage gate, full client-journey mapping, reliable language and disability access, a cross-agency data and performance architecture, a DHS-DCYF operating compact, workforce and procurement reforms, paid lived-expertise partnership, a broader evidence standard, and durable rules, budgets, contracts, and routines.

How to read this report

- **Landscape:** what the current equity climate appears to contain — strengths, signals, gaps, and opportunities.
- **Framework:** how to connect Hearts and Minds equity to organizational practice, institutional design, and structural conditions.
- **Recommendations:** practical reforms that complement DHS's current direction and can be prioritized by consequence and readiness.
- **Implementation:** a staged 36-month pathway with decision gates, evidence requirements, and leadership questions.
- **References:** source notes are consolidated at the end of the report; no inline citations are used in the body.

1. DHS equity landscape: the current climate

A useful equity landscape assessment begins with the organization as it operates, not with a generic description of diversity, equity, inclusion, accessibility, or anti-racism work. Minnesota DHS works through a network that includes state programs, counties, Tribal Nations, managed-care organizations, service delivery authorities, community providers, employees, and people who use human services. Equity climate is therefore produced across many locations and relationships.

1.1 Promising foundations

The source material reflects a substantial foundation on which to build. DHS has publicly articulated outcomes for people in Minnesota, for high-quality human services, and for employees who work in an inclusive environment. Its direction includes equitable and accessible service delivery, streamlined processes, partnership with Tribal Nations and counties, community voice, provider support, anti-racist and multicultural organizational development, psychological safety, wellbeing, and career pathways.

DHS also has an Equity Policy and Equity Analysis Toolkit that extend equity considerations beyond a single program. The policy context reaches into legislation, policy development, budgets, strategic planning, technology modernization, recruitment and retention, procurement, community engagement, and service delivery. The existence of these expectations is a strength because it positions equity as an agency responsibility rather than a discretionary add-on.

Other building blocks include MNbenefits, language and disability access requirements, human services performance measures, Medicaid equity work, disability and Olmstead planning, procurement opportunities for targeted vendors, and active child and family reforms. Collectively, these assets create a promising platform for a more integrated operating model.

1.2 The operating model is distributed by design

DHS cannot advance equity through one office or one training program alone. Many decisions that shape lived experience occur at program, county, Tribal, provider, technology, contract, or frontline levels. This distributed model makes local knowledge and partnership essential, but it also creates a risk: the department may have many good equity activities without one shared view of the outcomes, burdens, ownership, resources, and next decisions associated with them.

The opportunity is to establish a common minimum operating standard while preserving program-specific, Tribal, disability, cultural, linguistic, geographic, and community expertise. A common standard should clarify what must be analyzed, who decides, how affected people participate, what data is needed, how accessibility is assured, and how leadership will verify the result.

1.3 Current context that shapes the climate

Minnesota's human services performance-management experience suggests that a tool-centered approach is valuable for learning but may not be sufficient for sustained culture change or statewide scaling. The practical lesson is complementary: tools and training are important, and they are most effective when joined to coaching, change management, capacity, user groups, workflow ownership, and sustainability planning.

The movement of child and family functions into DCYF changes the accountability map without removing child welfare from the larger human services equity landscape. DHS remains connected through Medicaid, behavioral health, disability services, economic assistance, licensing, procurement, performance management, data infrastructure, and interagency coordination. Clarity about these relationships is a climate issue because organizational transitions can either strengthen shared accountability or create gaps that communities experience as fragmentation.

The Minnesota African American Family Preservation and Child Welfare Disproportionality Act creates a concrete opportunity to connect data disaggregation, family preservation, active efforts, case review, workforce practice, community oversight, and performance management. Its implementation should be approached as system change, with attention to service capacity and family experience as well as formal compliance.

1.4 Climate signals at a glance

Climate dimension	Promising signal	Opportunity to strengthen the system
Leadership direction	Equity and inclusion are reflected in strategic commitments and policy expectations.	Connect commitments to decision rights, resources, stage gates, and consequences.
Organizational learning	Toolkits, training, user groups, and community input create learning channels.	Pair learning with workflow redesign, coaching, accountability, and sustainability.
Client access	MNbenefits reduces friction for several economic-assistance programs.	Measure the full journey through verification, renewal, referral, and appeal.
Language and disability access	Rights and assistance expectations are identified.	Create consistent service standards, performance data, testing, and remediation.
Performance	Measures and thresholds exist across important human services outcomes.	Add equity, burden, access, intersectional, and corrective-action measures.
Community partnership	Medicaid and Olmstead work illustrate the value of lived expertise.	Compensate participation and document how it changes decisions and design.
Workforce and procurement	Existing HR and vendor systems can be equity levers.	Track advancement, retention, meaningful awards, payment, and community reach.
Durability	Equity is present in policies, plans, and initiatives.	Place requirements in recurring budgets, contracts, rules, routines, and succession plans.

2. Observations about the equity climate

The observations below are offered as constructive signals for discussion. They describe conditions that can occur even when employees and leaders are committed to equitable service and workplace outcomes. The distinction is important: an observation about system design is not a judgment about individual character or intent.

2.1 Intent and effect can diverge

A county eligibility worker may intend to treat people fairly while a process still produces unequal results if information is required in English, interpreter access is delayed, a narrow script limits judgment, or a missing document penalizes a delay outside the client's control. A social worker may value family preservation while the decision environment makes removal the easiest defensible option when services, housing, transportation, behavioral health, disability supports, or

culturally responsive providers are unavailable. A hiring manager may value diversity while an unstructured interview rewards similarity and informal rapport.

The leadership question is therefore not only whether staff have good intentions. It is whether the system gives staff the tools, time, authority, information, support, and incentives to produce equitable results — and whether the department can detect and correct the moments when it does not.

2.2 Equity tools need a consequential home

An equity analysis or scan can be completed without changing the decision it examines. If review has no stage gate, no required response to identified harm, and no accountable owner, it can become documentation attached to a decision made elsewhere. The opportunity is to make every required analysis produce a disposition: approve, revise, pause, pilot, reject, or escalate.

A material unmitigated disparity should not be silently accepted. If leadership chooses to proceed, the decision should state why, what safeguards apply, who owns the risk, what data will be reviewed, and when the decision will be revisited.

2.3 Administrative modernization should be measured by total effort

MNbenefits is an important modernization that can simplify the first step for several economic-assistance programs. A more usable front door, however, does not automatically create an integrated service journey. Clients may still encounter different verification requirements, notices, account systems, contact channels, renewal processes, or appeals across programs and delivery partners.

The relevant equity measure is total effort from first contact to stable service: repeated requests, days waiting, abandoned applications, unresolved referrals, renewal interruptions, comprehension, and successful appeals. The opportunity is to treat MNbenefits as a platform for broader integration while maintaining human support through county, Tribal, phone, in-person, and community channels.

2.4 Rights must be experienced consistently

Language access and disability access are not only notice requirements. They are service conditions. A client must be able to understand what is being asked, communicate at the point of need, receive equally effective communication, use the relevant format or technology, and obtain assistance without carrying the burden of arranging it alone.

Because delivery is distributed across program areas, counties, Tribes, and providers, the same right can feel different from one channel to another. The opportunity is a department-wide minimum standard with a shared performance dataset, accessible materials, user testing, a remediation queue, and an escalation route for repeated failures.

2.5 Performance systems should make disparities actionable

A performance system governs what it defines, measures, reviews, and connects to improvement. If healthcare access, language access, disability access, client burden, culturally relevant quality, or intersectional outcomes are not measured, they remain outside the formal performance conversation. If a measure is suspended or retired while the underlying risk remains, an interim monitoring plan is needed.

The opportunity is to add an equity layer: disaggregated outcomes, disparity thresholds, qualitative evidence, client-burden measures, and corrective-action requirements. The absence of a measure should be treated as a measurement risk, not as evidence that no problem exists.

2.6 Community voice is strongest when it changes design

Listening sessions and advisory groups can build understanding, but participation becomes more credible when people can see how their knowledge changed a policy, budget, contract, service, or evaluation. The climate signal to watch is whether communities are asked to describe harm without receiving compensation, decision influence, accessible participation, or a response record.

The opportunity is to establish paid, accessible, longitudinal partnership. Community members, Tribal governments, disability leaders, culturally specific organizations, parents, youth, relatives, employees, and people who use services should be engaged at the level of influence required by the decision.

2.7 Training is necessary but not sufficient

Training can support understanding of laws, cultural context, accessibility obligations, data practices, trauma-informed principles, and structured decision tools. It cannot by itself remove a degree requirement, create a culturally specific provider, repair a data field, translate a notice, change a contract score, fund a navigator, or require a manager to correct a promotion gap. Training is most effective when it supports a changed operating environment rather than standing in for one.

3. From Hearts and Minds to institutional and structural equity

A complementary framework can be understood as four connected levels. Each level matters; none should be treated as a substitute for the others.

Level	What it asks	What makes it durable
Hearts and Minds	What do people understand, believe, notice, and practice in relationships?	Learning, reflection, cultural humility, trust-building, psychological safety, and leadership modeling.

Level	What it asks	What makes it durable
Organizational practice	How do managers and teams make decisions and deliver services every day?	Clear workflows, structured decisions, coaching, accessible tools, workload capacity, feedback, and measurable expectations.
Institutional design	What do policies, budgets, contracts, technology, data, and governance make easier or harder?	Stage gates, resource commitments, data ownership, procurement standards, performance reviews, and corrective action.
Structural conditions	How do history, power, race, disability, culture, geography, income, language, and intersecting identities shape outcomes?	Disaggregated analysis, community power, cross-agency alignment, service capacity, and willingness to redesign the rules of the system.

“Working principle. The strongest equity climate is one in which personal commitment and institutional design reinforce one another. Employees should not have to overcome a structurally inequitable process through individual goodwill, and leadership should not ask communities to trust an equity commitment that has no operating expression.”

This four-level framework also clarifies the role of an Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant. The role is not to replace existing equity leadership, program expertise, Tribal sovereignty, disability expertise, community knowledge, or executive responsibility. It is to help connect those sources of knowledge to operational decisions, structural analysis, implementation, and measurable reform.

4. Complementary recommendations and reforms

The recommendations below are designed to strengthen and integrate work already underway. Each includes an objective, priority actions, evidence of progress, and primary ownership. They are intended to be sequenced according to consequence, readiness, capacity, and community guidance.

4.1 Establish an Equity Operations Council and executive stage gate

Objective. Create one governance mechanism that connects equity analysis to decisions, resources, risk management, and outcomes across DHS and relevant interagency partners.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Charter an Equity Operations Council chaired by an executive sponsor and including Equity and Inclusion, the Office of Indian Policy, Strategy and Performance, Employee Culture and Human Resources, Aging and Disability Services, Grants/Equity/Access/Research, procurement, IT, policy, legal, finance, program administrations, counties, Tribal Nations, labor, and community partners.

- Maintain a single equity portfolio containing priority disparities, redesign pilots, policy reviews, procurement changes, workforce risks, data dependencies, community commitments, budgets, and corrective actions.
- Establish an equity stage gate for policies, budgets, requests for proposals, major IT changes, service redesigns, and workforce initiatives. The gate should require a decision record, not only a completed scan.
- Require each stage-gate record to identify affected populations, burden, benefits, alternatives, accessibility, language, Tribal and legal considerations, data needs, cost, owner, implementation date, and outcome measures.
- Set an escalation rule: a material unmitigated disparity must be revised, piloted with safeguards, approved as an explicit exception by the responsible executive, or stopped.
- Use quarterly reviews to examine whether approved actions occurred and whether the observed effect matches the expected effect.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- A published charter, membership list, decision-rights matrix, and quarterly calendar.
- A portfolio dashboard showing owner, status, risk, budget, milestone, and outcome for each priority action.
- Sample policy, budget, IT, procurement, and workforce decisions with completed stage-gate records and documented disposition.
- A corrective-action register showing unresolved disparities and the executive responsible for resolution.

Primary ownership. Commissioner's Office, in partnership with Equity and Inclusion and Strategy and Performance.

4.2 Turn MNbenefits into a full client-journey redesign

Objective. Reduce total administrative burden from first contact through verification, renewal, change reporting, appeal, and stable receipt of services.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Map the complete journey for a household applying for economic assistance, including transition from MNbenefits to county or Tribal processing, document submission, interviews, notices, case changes, renewal, and appeal.
- Identify which adjacent programs are screened through the existing application and which remain outside the experience, including healthcare, MinnesotaCare, disability-related services, and other needs.
- Define a cross-program referral standard: a clear explanation, warm handoff, contact, time expectation, and way to confirm that the handoff occurred.
- Maintain human support through phone, in-person, county, Tribal, and community channels. Online convenience should not be treated as a replacement for accessible human assistance.

- Fund Digital Navigators and community-based application support, especially in rural areas, Tribal communities, neighborhoods with limited broadband, and communities with limited English proficiency.
- Rewrite notices and document requests so clients can identify what is needed, why it is needed, how to submit it, what happens next, and how to obtain language or disability assistance.
- Measure total client effort, including contacts, repeated submissions, days waiting, abandoned applications, successful referrals, renewal churn, denials, appeals, and comprehension.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- Current-state and future-state journey maps reviewed by clients, navigators, frontline workers, county and Tribal staff, accessibility experts, and program owners.
- A list of programs inside and outside the MNbenefits experience with a documented referral or integration plan.
- A client-effort dashboard disaggregated by language, race and ethnicity, disability, geography, age, and other relevant dimensions with privacy protections.
- Verified reduction in repeated information requests, unresolved handoffs, abandoned applications, and renewal interruptions.

Primary ownership. Economic Assistance, Health Care, county and Tribal partners, IT, Strategy and Performance, and community navigation partners.

4.3 Operationalize language and disability access as service standards

Objective. Make free, timely, meaningful language assistance and equally effective communication reliable at every client contact, not only visible in notices or policy statements.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Adopt a DHS-wide minimum service standard: assistance is free, timely, available throughout operating hours, and never placed as a burden on the person with limited English proficiency or a disability.
- Create a common performance dataset for interpreter requests, wait time, failed or delayed access, translated materials, language of service, client comprehension, accommodations, and complaint resolution.
- Review county and provider language-access plans for operational readiness: who answers, who interprets, which languages are covered, how after-hours needs are handled, and how staff document service.
- Standardize language-access and disability-access advisories in public materials while testing whether people understand the right and know how to request it.
- Require document accessibility testing with screen readers, keyboard navigation, captioning, alternative formats, and disabled users before major publications or digital releases.

- Create a centralized accessibility remediation queue with severity levels, owners, deadlines, and executive visibility. Program-area responsibility for cost should not mean program-area isolation.
- Include access standards in contracts, requests for proposals, managed-care requirements, vendor monitoring, and provider technical assistance.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- Interpreter and accommodation performance reported by program and county or Tribal delivery channel.
- Priority forms, notices, web pages, videos, and training materials pass accessibility review with documented results.
- Client testing shows that people can identify how to request assistance and understand information after assistance is provided.
- Access failures have an owner, remediation date, and escalation path.

Primary ownership. Equity and Inclusion, civil rights, accessibility leadership, program administrations, county and Tribal agencies, IT, Communications, and procurement.

4.4 Build an equity data and performance architecture

Objective. Make disparities visible, interpretable, privacy-protected, and connected to management action across DHS, DCYF, counties, Tribes, and providers.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Create a cross-agency equity data dictionary covering race, ethnicity, culture, language, disability, gender, geography, income, age, and program-specific characteristics, with definitions, collection rules, missingness, and permitted uses.
- Separate internal analytic capacity from public reporting. Use protected data for small-n and intersectional analysis while publishing safe aggregate trends and clear limitations.
- Integrate equity measures into the Human Services Performance Management System, including client burden, language access, disability access, healthcare access, culturally relevant quality, and workforce outcomes.
- Address gaps in healthcare access and effective-service measurement by developing measures with communities, counties, managed-care organizations, and people with lived experience.
- For every measure, establish a baseline, threshold, improvement target, owner, reporting schedule, and corrective-action process. A suspended or retired measure should have interim monitoring if the underlying risk remains.
- Use dashboards to identify disparities at decision points, not only final outcomes: screening, referral, approval, denial, wait, placement, service, renewal, and appeal.
- Pair quantitative results with qualitative evidence, case review, community feedback, and frontline observation so data does not erase context.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- An approved equity data dictionary and data-governance protocol.
- A minimum set of equity measures added to each priority performance domain.
- A dashboard with documented suppression rules, data-quality notes, and named owners.
- Quarterly corrective-action reviews for measures that exceed disparity thresholds or show deterioration.
- An annual review of which measures were used in budget, policy, procurement, workforce, or program decisions.

Primary ownership. Strategy and Performance, data governance, program analytics, Equity and Inclusion, DCYF where child and family data is involved, counties, Tribal Nations, and community partners.

4.5 Implement child-welfare equity reform through a DHS-DCYF operating compact

Objective. Ensure that the transfer of child and family programs strengthens rather than fragments accountability for disproportionality, family preservation, data, services, and community trust.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Create a written DHS-DCYF operating compact defining responsibilities for data sharing, Medicaid and behavioral-health linkages, disability services, benefits, procurement, workforce, performance management, community engagement, and public reporting.
- Align measures with statutory categories such as representation, reporting, maltreatment, out-of-home placement, emergency removals, reunification, permanency, family connections, relative placement, disability, culture, income, and geography.
- Treat active efforts and family preservation as operational requirements that require service capacity, culturally responsive safety planning, transportation, language access, housing support, behavioral health, disability supports, and relatives or kin who can participate.
- Use structured decision-making and case review to identify where discretion, service availability, or court and agency practice leads to unnecessary removal or unequal treatment.
- Make the African American Child Well-being Unit, Advisory Council, Tribal governments, community organizations, parents, youth, and relatives part of the implementation feedback loop with compensation and documented response.
- Use the phase-in period to identify implementation barriers before statewide rollout rather than treating the phase-in as a compliance exercise.
- Coordinate data definitions and reporting schedules so DHS, DCYF, counties, Tribes, and the public do not see conflicting versions of the same disparity.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- A signed interagency compact and RACI matrix.
- A joint dashboard or reporting package aligned with statutory categories and privacy rules.
- Case-review findings linked to specific policy, training, service-capacity, or workflow changes.
- Documented active-efforts and family-preservation implementation in phase-in counties.
- A statewide readiness assessment before rollout.

Primary ownership. DHS and DCYF Commissioners' Offices, Child Safety and Permanency leadership, the Office of Indian Policy, counties, Tribal Nations, courts, providers, and community oversight bodies.

4.6 Redesign workforce entry, advancement, and retention

Objective. Make workforce equity measurable in recruitment, hiring, pay, promotion, acting appointments, performance feedback, accommodations, psychological safety, and retention.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Audit job classifications and minimum qualifications for unnecessary degrees, experience requirements, address or schedule assumptions, and barriers that exclude lived experience or community language and cultural knowledge.
- Use trainee and paid-licensure pathways where jobs can be performed safely and effectively through training, supervised practice, and competency assessment.
- Use structured interviews, common questions, scoring rubrics, diverse panels, and documented selection rationale. Monitor who advances at each stage.
- Audit acting and interim appointments for transparency, rotation, access, and conversion to permanent positions.
- Analyze time-in-class, pay, performance ratings, promotion, disciplinary action, developmental opportunity, and turnover by race, ethnicity, disability, gender, geography, and other relevant categories.
- Create sponsorship for employees who are 'onlys' or 'firsts' in leadership roles, with executive actions rather than informal encouragement alone.
- Treat Direct Support Professionals and Personal Care Assistants as a core equity and service-quality workforce. Track wages, benefits, vacancies, caseload, training, career progression, and turnover.
- Require managers to have measurable DEIA goals that address outcomes or behavior, not merely attendance, and review those goals in performance management.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- A workforce equity baseline and annual disparity report.
- A structured-hiring protocol and acting-appointment audit.
- Promotion, pay, and retention gaps with corrective-action owners.

- Manager goals tied to measurable team conditions and service outcomes.
- A burnout, workload, moral-injury, and secondary-traumatic-stress response plan.

Primary ownership. Employee Culture and Human Resources, Workforce Strategy and Planning, program leaders, labor partners, Equity and Inclusion, and Development and Learning.

4.7 Use procurement and grants to build community capacity

Objective. Make public spending a deliberate instrument for service equity, cultural fit, disability inclusion, geographic reach, and community wealth.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Use the state's targeted-group, economically disadvantaged, and veteran-owned vendor systems and Equity Select mechanisms as starting points for a DHS vendor-equity strategy.
- Identify where solicitation size, insurance, cash flow, reporting, technical requirements, or prior-government experience exclude smaller and community-rooted organizations.
- Revise RFP and grant rubrics to assign meaningful value to cultural and linguistic competence, lived experience, disability leadership, Tribal partnership, geographic access, family preservation, and measurable outcomes.
- Provide pre-solicitation information sessions, proposal assistance, realistic payment terms, capacity-building grants, and technical assistance so community organizations can compete without imitating large institutions.
- Require vendors to meet language, accessibility, data, complaint, and community-feedback standards, with resources to do so and consequences for repeated failure.
- Analyze awards by vendor ownership, leadership, community served, geography, language, and contract value. Do not count diverse vendors without examining who receives meaningful and sustainable work.
- Use contract renewals and performance reviews to determine whether providers actually reach the communities identified in the proposal.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- A vendor-barrier assessment and revised solicitation templates.
- Award and subcontracting data disaggregated by vendor type and community reach.
- Payment-timeliness and capacity-building measures for smaller providers.
- Contract monitoring that includes access, cultural fit, disability inclusion, and outcomes.

Primary ownership. Procurement, Grants, Equity and Inclusion, program administrations, the Office of Equity in Procurement, finance, legal, and community providers.

4.8 Institutionalize co-creation, trust repair, and lived expertise

Objective. Move communities from consultation recipients to paid partners who shape policy, program design, budgets, procurement, and evaluation.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Create a department-wide compensation policy for community expertise, including time, preparation, transportation, childcare, technology, interpretation, and accessibility costs.
- Use a participation ladder that distinguishes informing, consulting, involving, collaborating, and empowering. Specify the level required for each decision.
- Create longitudinal community partnerships rather than one-time listening sessions. Trust repair requires repeated, culturally specific engagement tied to policy and administrative activity.
- Use community-defined measures of quality, trust, safety, dignity, and culturally relevant care alongside administrative outcomes.
- Publish a response record that says what community members recommended, what changed, what did not change, and why.
- Avoid extracting trauma. Do not ask employees or clients to disclose painful experiences as a substitute for paying experts, reviewing data, or redesigning the system.
- Use compensated lived-experience participation in disability planning as a practical reference while adapting the approach to other communities and decision types.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- A paid-lived-expertise policy and standard agreement.
- A community-participation plan for every major equity redesign.
- Documented changes to policy, budget, procurement, service, or evaluation resulting from participation.
- Trust, comprehension, and perceived influence measures collected over time.

Primary ownership. Equity and Inclusion, the Office of Indian Policy, program administrations, community engagement, procurement, finance, and executive sponsors.

4.9 Expand the evidence standard without abandoning rigor

Objective. Recognize culturally adapted and community-defined practices as potentially valid evidence while maintaining safety, transparency, measurable outcomes, and ethical safeguards.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Distinguish between evidence that a model works in a population, evidence that a model is culturally acceptable and accessible, and evidence that a provider can deliver it safely.
- Require cultural adaptation when a model was developed or tested in a population that differs materially from the people DHS is serving.
- Accept practice-based evidence, community-defined outcomes, traditional healing, peer support, elders, doulas, and culturally specific organizations as evidence categories for review rather than dismissing them as unproven by definition.

- Use community members and cultural experts to define meaningful outcomes while retaining independent review for safety, privacy, professional standards, and fiscal accountability.
- Track whether conventional evidence requirements exclude providers that communities trust and whether funded models produce equitable results in practice.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- A written evidence framework with definitions, review criteria, and examples.
- Procurement and program documents that allow culturally specific and practice-based evidence.
- Outcome monitoring that compares adapted and unadapted models where appropriate.
- Community feedback on whether services are culturally relevant, safe, and effective.

Primary ownership. Program administrations, research and evaluation, procurement, legal, clinical and professional leadership, Equity and Inclusion, and community partners.

4.10 Make the work durable through rules, budgets, contracts, and routines

Objective. Prevent equity work from depending on a single leader, grant, training cycle, or political moment.

PRIORITY ACTIONS

- Identify which equity requirements belong in statute, administrative rule, policy, contract, grant agreement, budget instruction, performance plan, standard operating procedure, or technology requirement.
- Use rulemaking and public notice when a durable, transparent requirement is appropriate; do not rely on an internal memo for a requirement that must survive leadership transition.
- Assign recurring budget lines for accessibility, community compensation, data capacity, change management, evaluation, and frontline workload relief.
- Embed equity outcomes in contracts, manager goals, program scorecards, procurement reviews, and annual planning.
- Build succession and continuity plans for equity leadership, data ownership, community relationships, and high-risk pilots.
- Publish annual status reports that distinguish completed activities, measured outcomes, disparities that remain, corrective actions, and decisions required from leadership.

EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS

- A durability map showing the legal, budget, contract, policy, technology, and performance home for each intervention.
- Recurring resource commitments rather than one-time project funds.
- Continuity plans for key roles and partnerships.

- Annual leadership reporting with unresolved disparities and explicit next actions.

Primary ownership. Commissioner's Office, policy, legal, finance, procurement, Human Resources, Strategy and Performance, and program leadership.

5. Thirty-six-month implementation blueprint

The blueprint is designed to support the department's current direction while reducing a common implementation risk: announcing a broad strategy, assigning it to a small office, offering training, and waiting for culture to change. Each phase has a distinct purpose, decision gate, and evidence requirement.

Timing	Purpose	Required work	Decision gate
0-90 days	Authorize and establish	Executive sponsor; Equity Operations Council charter; portfolio baseline; DHS-DCYF compact; data-access approvals; selected pilots; legal, privacy, accessibility, and Tribal review; community compensation protocol.	No pilot proceeds without a named owner, baseline, budget, affected-community plan, measure, and escalation path.
3-6 months	Map and design	Client journeys; high-discretion decision inventory; language and disability access assessment; workforce and vendor-barrier analysis; performance-measure design; community and frontline co-design.	Leadership approves future-state workflows and resource requirements, not only problem statements.
6-12 months	Pilot and learn	MNbenefits journey improvements; navigators; language and accessibility remediation; structured decision tools; data-disaggregation prototypes; revised RFP or grant cycle; manager goals.	Pilots report burden, access, outcomes, equity gaps, usability, cost, and unintended effects.
12-24 months	Scale and integrate	Expand effective pilots; integrate stage gates into policy, budget, IT, procurement, hiring, and service delivery; implement child-welfare phase-in learning; build dashboards and corrective action.	Operating procedures, contracts, budgets, and performance systems reflect the new requirements.
24-36 months	Institutionalize and renew	Rulemaking or statutory alignment where appropriate; recurring budget; succession; annual reporting; outcome review; redesign of interventions that did not work; next priority portfolio.	Equity work remains active when leadership, funding, or external conditions change.

5.1 Pilot selection criteria

Leadership should select pilots using criteria that prioritize consequence and learning value, not visibility. A strong pilot affects a high-consequence outcome, has an identifiable owner, can be measured within twelve months, involves people who experience the barrier, has a plausible intervention, and can be scaled if effective.

- High consequence for safety, access, autonomy, family stability, health, income, or employment.
- Evidence of disparate burden or outcome, with a feasible way to disaggregate or otherwise investigate it.
- A defined decision point or workflow that can be changed.
- A program owner with authority and capacity to implement.
- Community, Tribal, frontline, disability, language, or labor partners who can shape the redesign.
- A measurable baseline and a plan for privacy, accessibility, and unintended-effect review.

5.2 What should not be called progress by itself

- Training completion without evidence of changed decisions, workflow, or outcomes.
- A completed equity scan with no documented decision or corrective action.
- A translated document when interpretation is unavailable at the point of need.
- A dashboard that reports aggregate data and cannot identify or act on subgroup disparities.
- A community meeting that produces no compensation, decision record, or change in design.
- A diverse hiring slate without changes to selection, promotion, pay, retention, and psychological safety.
- A diverse vendor count without meaningful awards, timely payment, community reach, or contract outcomes.
- A new policy that says equity matters but does not assign a resource, owner, measure, or consequence.

6. Leadership scorecard

The scorecard should be reviewed quarterly by the executive sponsor and annually by the Commissioner or designated leadership body. It should show direction of change, distribution of outcomes across groups, and whether the department acted on what it learned.

Domain	Illustrative measures	Leadership question
Governance	Stage gates completed; material risks escalated; corrective actions closed on time; priority portfolio funded.	Is equity connected to decisions and consequences?
Client burden		

Domain	Illustrative measures	Leadership question
	Total contacts; repeated requests; days waiting; abandoned applications; referral completion; renewal churn; appeal success; comprehension.	Does the system make it easier to obtain and keep services?
Language and disability access	Interpreter wait and failure; accessible documents; accommodation completion; complaint resolution; assistive-technology testing.	Can people understand and use the service at the point of need?
Child and family outcomes	Disproportionality; placement; active efforts; reunification; relative connection; removals; case review; data completeness.	Are reforms changing decisions and family experience?
Health and disability outcomes	Healthcare access; culturally relevant care; waiver and HCBS access; choice; integration; wait time; community living.	Do services support health, dignity, autonomy, and community life?
Workforce	Hiring; pay; promotion; acting appointments; time-in-class; retention; accommodations; psychological safety; direct-care conditions.	Can employees enter, advance, contribute, and remain?
Procurement	Awards and value by vendor type; payment time; community reach; cultural and disability access; contract outcomes.	Who receives public resources and who has capacity to serve?
Trust and power	Paid participation; community influence; response to recommendations; perceived trust; complaint and appeal patterns.	Are communities helping govern the system or only describing its failures?
Durability	Recurring budget; rule and policy integration; contract language; succession; annual reporting; continuity during leadership change.	Will the change survive pressure?

7. Conclusion: a complementary path forward

DHS does not need to choose between the equity work already underway and the institutional reforms described here. The opportunity is to connect them. Strategic commitments, policy expectations, toolkits, performance systems, language and disability access, MNbenefits, Medicaid equity work, disability planning, procurement mechanisms, workforce efforts, community partnerships, and child and family reforms are important building blocks.

The climate question is whether those building blocks operate as a connected system. Can a person in Minnesota access, understand, influence, and benefit from human services without carrying a disproportionate administrative burden? Can employees enter, advance, contribute, and remain with fair opportunity and adequate support? Can public dollars build culturally

responsive, accessible, and community-rooted capacity? Can leaders change course when data and communities show that a process is not working?

This report's proposed shift is from equity as an additional lens to equity as a design and performance requirement — while retaining the Hearts and Minds work that makes durable change possible. That shift does not diminish existing equity leadership. It gives existing commitments more structural support through executive authority, cross-agency coordination, data discipline, community partnership, accessible systems, procurement leverage, structured decisions, workforce investment, and durable rules and budgets.

“Closing standard. The relevant test is not whether DHS has expressed care for equity. The relevant test is whether the department's operating conditions consistently turn that care into accessible services, fair opportunity, community influence, measurable improvement, and the willingness to redesign when outcomes show that more is needed.”

References and source notes

The references below consolidate the authorities, public materials, and research used in the source analysis and this rewrite. No inline citations are used in the body of the report. Each reference includes a visible source URL. In desktop Word, hold Ctrl while clicking a blue URL to open it.

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The Position, Decomposed

The agreed decomposition of the consultant's role, co-created in early 2023 and reproduced without alteration, with what each duty requires of others.

CO-CREATED BY The consultant, who knows the work — the operations manager, who wanted the work done — the leadership team, which agreed to it

AGREED Early 2023

STATUS The operational understanding under which this position has been carried out

Why this document is in the record

This is the decomposition of the Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant position as it was co-created and agreed in early 2023. It is reproduced here without alteration, so that what was agreed can be read directly.

Two features of the document deserve notice before the duties themselves. with or to other people. The position is consultative, capacity-building and coordinating by construction. It was written as a position that works with and through others.

The second is the heading on the final section: “Use judgment and creativity (Secondary and/or shared duties).” The word **shared** is in the agreed document itself. The distribution of responsibility described throughout the accompanying memorandum is the structure of the role as agreed.

A third point follows from the first two. A substantial number of these duties are impossible to discharge alone, because the document itself names the counterpart: hiring managers, subject matter experts, contract managers, the DSD data team, Fiscal Analysis and Results Management, divisional partners, division leadership. Those duties can be performed as written when that collaboration is in place.

Core responsibilities (primary duties)

Consultation, collaboration and leadership

- Provide consultation, collaboration, and leadership on the design, development, and management of diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility (DEIA) principles and activities throughout the division, in alignment with DSD’s strategic plan and DHS anti-racism initiative.

Expert knowledge and feedback to division leadership and staff

Provide expert knowledge and feedback to division leadership and staff on all matters concerning diversity, equity, and inclusion.

- This includes guiding policy development, implementation, and compliance. Work to ensure that equity and inclusion are prioritized at the highest levels of the division.
- Plan, lead, and facilitate internal work groups to address system and organizational culture changes around equity.
- Develop, document, and present recommendations for creating and sustaining system and organizational culture change around equity as continuous improvement.
- Establish benchmarks and targets to measure the division's progress on DEIA.
- Build the capacity of DSD staff and managers to collaborate with partners and promote equity work.
- Lead division staff and leadership to assess equity and inclusion awareness and capacity, identify activities to build equity and inclusion including professional development and training opportunities within the division, and implement those activities.
- Work with leadership to oversee compliance with the DHS Equity Policy, ensuring equity and inclusion are considered in all DSD policies and processes to reduce disparate outcomes for marginalized communities.
- Promote workforce diversity by collaborating with hiring managers to ensure that the recruitment process is inclusive and attracts a diverse pool of candidates.

Compliance specialist and technical expert

Serve as a compliance specialist and technical expert to provide just-in-time training and consultation to division staff. Plan, create, direct, and revise the development and implementation plan as it applies to DEIA, including strategies and processes to ensure achievement of plan objectives through a consistent and integrated approach.

- Coordinate external expertise and training as needed to meet division equity goals.
- Support integration of culturally and linguistically appropriate services (CLAS) standards into our grants and waiver and state plan services.

Leading divisional partners and subject matter experts

Lead divisional partners and subject matter experts in the development and implementation of DEIA operational work throughout the division. This involves embedding DEIA principles into all aspects of the division's operations, including policies, procedures, programs, and services.

- Provide expertise and logistical support for culturally responsive service development.
- Provide consultation to subject matter experts to update policies, standard operating procedures, and manuals with a culturally responsive lens.

- Provide just-in-time training to DSD employees on equity tools, including consultation to support DSD's internal capacity for equity analyses in legislative proposals.
- Support building pipelines of diverse talent as part of succession planning within DSD.
- Promote a consistent onboarding process for the division.

Operationalizing equity; evaluating and improving systems and structures

Operationalize equity, evaluate and improve systems and structures that support equity in division operations.

- Lead the development and maintenance of internal accountability mechanisms for the division's progress on equity-related goals. Collaborate with the DSD data team and Fiscal Analysis and Results Management (FARM) division to measure, track, and analyze the effectiveness of equity initiatives.
- Provide consultation with policy subject matter experts and contract managers to build diversity and inclusion into each phase of the contract cycle.
- Collaborate on determining common data elements across the division to measure and monitor progress on equity goals in requests for proposals (RFPs), scoring tools, and quarterly progress reports in the system.

Use judgment and creativity (secondary and/or shared duties)

"The heading is reproduced as agreed. These duties are designated shared in the document itself."

- Stay up to date on equity and inclusion trends and best practices related to equity and inclusion and use this knowledge to inform the division's policies and practices. This includes attending conferences and training sessions, reading relevant literature, and keeping up to date with changes related to equity and inclusion.
- Monitor and report such as workforce demographics and retention rates. This data should be used to identify areas for improvement and inform equity and inclusion goals.
- Foster a culture of equity and inclusion within the division by promoting open communication, respect, and inclusion of diverse perspectives. This includes developing and delivering training programs to promote equity, inclusion, and cultural competency, as well as working with employee resource groups to support underrepresented groups within the division.
- Represent the division in equity and inclusion initiatives, such as conferences, training sessions, and partnerships with other organizations. This includes sharing best practices and collaborating with other organizations to advance equity and inclusion initiatives.
- Conduct equity and inclusion assessments to evaluate the division's progress on equity and inclusion, including identifying areas for improvement and developing action plans to address any gaps.

- Promote employee engagement and feedback by providing opportunities for employees to share their perspectives and experiences related to DEIA issues. This feedback helps identify improvement areas and informs the development of DEIA initiatives.
- Work with leadership to create a culture of accountability by establishing clear expectations for DEIA work and regularly monitoring progress. This includes holding leaders and employees accountable for their contributions to DEIA initiatives, as well as providing recognition and rewards for those who excel in promoting equity and inclusion.

What the agreed decomposition requires of others

The following duties name their counterpart in the text of the document. Each depends on that counterpart, and listing them sets out what the agreement contemplated.

Duty as written	The counterpart the document names	What is required for it to be performed
Establish benchmarks and targets; lead internal accountability mechanisms	The DSD data team; Fiscal Analysis and Results Management (FARM)	Access to workforce and program data, and analytic capacity the consultant does not hold
Build diversity and inclusion into each phase of the contract cycle	Policy subject matter experts; contract managers	Inclusion in the contracting and procurement cycle at the point decisions are made
Determine common data elements across the division	The division, collectively	An agreed set of measures and their presence in RFPs, scoring tools and quarterly reports
Promote workforce diversity; build pipelines; consistent onboarding	Hiring managers; Human Resources	Participation in recruitment design, succession planning and onboarding
Plan, lead and facilitate internal work groups	Division staff and leadership	Staff time released to participate, and standing awareness of what work groups exist
Provide consultation to subject matter experts on policies, SOPs and manuals	Subject matter experts across the division	Notice that a policy, procedure or manual is being written or revised
Support equity analyses in legislative proposals	DSD legislative staff	Visibility of legislative proposals while they are still being drafted
Guide policy development, implementation and compliance	Division leadership	Presence where policy decisions are made, or current information about them

This is the substance of the request set out in the accompanying memorandum. It is not an expansion of the role. It is what the agreed decomposition already assumed would be in place.

Goal Allocation Worksheet

How the six equity goals divide across the Division: what each decomposes into, who must hold it, and an owner column left blank for leadership to complete.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
PREPARED FOR	Heidi Hamilton, Division Director — Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager
DATE	September 18, 2026
STATUS	Draft for completion by Division leadership

1. What this document is for

Dega Sayid, the Administration's Equity Director, was unambiguous that this Division is responsible for the execution of all six equity goals, and equally clear that the Division retains latitude over how they are met. That settles the scope and opens a different question, which the accompanying memorandum names as genuinely open: how does the work divide across this Division, and who is responsible for what?

This worksheet is my proposal for answering it. It is not a decision and it is not an assignment — neither is mine to make. It sets out what each goal actually decomposes into, the kind of owner each part requires, and what the Program supplies against it. The final column is intentionally empty, because naming the owner is leadership's to do.

“A goal without a named owner is an intention. A goal with a named owner is a plan. The difference is this column.”

2. The six goals, decomposed

Goal	What it decomposes into	Who must hold it	What the Program supplies	Owner
1. Eliminate disparities	Equity analysis before a decision rather than after it; a chartered equity team with named decision rights; a quarterly read on where gaps are widening.	Division leadership, for the charter and decision rights. Program managers, for running the analysis on their own proposals.	The equity analysis instrument, the guidance for using it, and the governance templates.	
2. Community engagement	Engagement planned rather than incidental, documented, and carried into a live project with a recorded outcome.	The teams that hold community-facing work, with a named lead per project.	Minnesota Communities briefs, the engagement planner, and consultation on applying them.	

Goal	What it decomposes into	Who must hold it	What the Program supplies	Owner
3. Hiring and retention	Inclusive recruitment design, pipelines of diverse talent for succession, consistent onboarding, and retention read against real data.	Hiring managers and Human Resources. This goal cannot be held inside the Division alone.	Inclusive hiring and mentoring material; the climate survey instrument the goal itself presumes.	
4. Learning and development	A documented development arc for staff and for leaders, with the leadership pathway funded.	Supervisors, for their own units. Division leadership, for the funded leadership pathway.	The 38-module curriculum, IDI orientation material, practice paths, and the leadership series.	
5. Contracts and procurement	Diversity and inclusion built into each phase of the contract cycle; common data elements in RFPs, scoring tools and quarterly reports.	Contract managers and policy subject matter experts. Nothing here can be built without them.	Consultation on the contract cycle, and the equity criteria for solicitations and scoring.	
6. Communication and accessibility	Accessibility and plain language treated as a standard rather than an accommodation added afterward.	Every unit that publishes anything, with communications support.	Accessibility checks, plain-language guidance, language access and interpreter practice, accessible-document practice.	

Two observations from the table. Goals 4 and 6 are the best served by what already exists, because both are substantially answered by instructional content and daily operating standards. Goals 3 and 5 are the least served, and for the same structural reason: neither can be discharged inside this Division alone. They require Human Resources and they require contract managers, and no amount of content substitutes for that.

3. What the work requires from outside this role

The agreed decomposition of the consultant's position names its counterparts directly. These are not requests for goodwill; they are the conditions under which the named duties can be performed at all.

The work	Who it requires	What fails without it
Establish benchmarks and targets; internal accountability mechanisms	The DSD data team; Fiscal Analysis and Results Management (FARM)	Without them, goal 1 cannot be measured and goals 2 and 3 cannot be demonstrated
Diversity and inclusion through the contract cycle	Contract managers; policy subject matter experts	Without them, goal 5 has no provision at all
Recruitment design, succession pipelines, onboarding	Hiring managers; Human Resources	Without them, goal 3 rests on instructional content alone
Equity analyses in legislative proposals	DSD legislative staff	Visibility of proposals while they are still in draft
Policies, standard operating procedures and manuals reviewed through a culturally responsive lens	Subject matter experts across the Division	Notice that a policy or manual is being written or revised

4. A suggested sequence

1. **Name the owners.** Complete the final column of the table in section 2. Nothing else in this worksheet can proceed until that is done, and it is the one step only leadership can take.
2. **Open the two that are stalled.** Goals 3 and 5 need a conversation with Human Resources and with contract managers respectively. Both are outside the Division's sole control and both will take longest, which is the argument for starting them first rather than last.
3. **Run the pilot.** Home and Community-Based Services runs the Program for a defined interval, measured for behavioral and cognitive change. Other units continue as they are.
4. **Build the measurement.** The data team and FARM establish the baseline that goals 1, 2 and 3 all depend on. Until this exists the Division has practice without evidence.
5. **Review and redistribute.** At the close of the pilot, revisit this table against what was learned rather than against what was assumed.

5. What I will do against each goal

So that this worksheet is not read as work being handed outward, the consultant's own commitments are stated plainly. For every goal in section 2 I will supply the instruments named in the fourth column, keep them current and accessible, provide consultation and just-in-time training on their use, and report honestly on what is working and what is not — including where my own contribution has not been sufficient. What I will not do is execute the work in the third column. That is not reluctance; it is the design of the position, and it is set out in full in the accompanying record.

6. Related documents

- **The memorandum** — the communication this worksheet accompanies, and the case for the approach.
- **The Position, Decomposed** — the agreed decomposition of the consultant's role, which names the counterparts in section 3.
- **Program Crosswalk** — the Program examined goal by goal, with an honest status for each.
- **Operational Workplan** — the ten workstreams that carry this work, with dates.

Program Requirements Document

The executive brief: what the Program is, what it is for, what the Division gains, and how it aligns to the Administration's six equity goals.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
PREPARED FOR	Heidi Hamilton, Division Director — Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager
DATE	September 19, 2026
STATUS	Draft for review

1. What the Program is

The One DHS / One DSD People, Access and Culture Program is a working resource being built for the Disability Services Division. It already holds 179 courses, all of them written for this Program: a 38-module curriculum on intercultural practice, a 13-module curriculum on the Minnesota disability service system, a three-module series on program integrity, and the disability inclusion, cultural intelligence and program integrity material alongside them. With the courses sit practice paths, job aids, community briefs, leadership development material, and the working spaces for the One DSD Team and Amplify Equity. Work on it continues.

It was designed from what staff across this Division said about their own work: 71 interviews, then 23 division-wide sessions producing 172 findings and 131 recommendations. Those findings were analyzed formally, and the analysis produced a single central conclusion that shaped everything built since — that equity in this Division is carried as individual effort, without an operational system behind it. The Program is that system.

The Program is still being built, and has not opened. No member of staff is using it yet. The intention is to open it throughout the Division in January 2027, following the November election.

2. What the Program is for

The Program serves two purposes. They are listed in order, because the order matters.

Order	Purpose	What this means in practice
First	An operational instrument for the equity and inclusion operations work	This is the Program's primary function. The curriculum, the practice tools, the community briefs, the analysis instruments, and the reference material are what the consultant works from and works through. Before the Program existed, this work depended on one person being in the room. The Program is how it now gets carried out at the scale of a division.
Second	A voluntary learning resource for every	Any person in the Division, at any level, can open the Program and learn — about their own Division, about the Administration it belongs to, and about

Order	Purpose	What this means in practice
	member of staff and every leader	the Department as a whole. Nothing is required. Nothing is graded. Nothing is reported about any individual.

The second purpose depends on the first. The Program became a resource staff can use because it was first built as the instrument the work is carried out through. It was not designed as a library that happens to be useful; it is the working equipment of the Division's equity and inclusion operations, opened up so that everyone can use it.

3. Who it serves, and what each gets from it

Audience	What the Program gives them
Staff	A place to find a clear answer, work through a practical example, and take a resource into their own work. Every resource other than the eLearning courses can be downloaded as a Word, Excel, PowerPoint, or PDF file.
Supervisors and managers	Material ready to use with a team: job aids, practice paths, and short guides that can be adapted for a unit meeting without preparation time the supervisor does not have.
Directors and the Administration	A single, current source of what the Division is doing on equity, and a record that can be shown to the Administration and the Department without assembling it from scratch each time.
The communities the Division serves	Staff who have prepared before an engagement, rather than during it. Community briefs and an engagement planner exist so that understanding precedes contact.

4. What the Division gains

Benefit	Why it follows
The work stops depending on one person's availability	The consultant's knowledge, references, and practice tools are in one place, usable by anyone, at any hour, without an appointment.
Practice becomes consistent across teams	Staff described results that varied by who happened to be on a team. A shared set of tools, used the same way, is what makes practice consistent.
Supervisors get material they can use immediately	Short, adaptable, and downloadable, so that using it does not cost preparation time a supervisor cannot spare.
The Division can show its work	What was asked for, what was built in response, and what remains — all documented, all traceable back to what staff themselves said.

Benefit	Why it follows
Learning connects the levels	A staff member does not learn about the Division in isolation. The Program shows how the Division sits inside the Administration, and how the Administration sits inside the Department.
Community engagement starts from preparation	Understanding a community before engaging it, rather than asking the same questions twice.

5. How the three levels connect

A staff member using this Program does not learn about the Division in isolation. The Program is built so that the connection between the levels is visible: how the Disability Services Division works, how the Division sits within the Aging and Disability Services Administration, and how the Administration sits within the Department of Human Services and the State's commitments.

That matters for a practical reason. Staff described a Division that felt disconnected from the Department around it, and described guidance arriving as an expectation without the means to meet it. When a person can see how their own work connects upward to an Administration goal and a State commitment, the requirement stops being an instruction from somewhere else and becomes something with a visible reason behind it.

6. How the Program aligns with the Administration's six equity goals

The Aging and Disability Services Administration sets six equity goals. The table below states each goal, what the Program offers against it, and an honest status. Three status words are used throughout: Built, Partly built, and Not yet built.

#	The Administration's goal	What the Program offers	Status
1	End disparities in outcomes	The practice of checking for equity before a decision is made, rather than after, and an equity team with a written charter.	Partly built
2	Engage communities	Minnesota Communities briefs and a community engagement planner, so preparation happens before contact.	Partly built
3	Hire and retain a representative workforce	The One DSD Team and Amplify Equity for belonging and engagement; inclusive hiring and mentoring material; a yearly staff survey.	Partly built
4	Develop staff and leaders		

#	The Administration's goal	What the Program offers	Status
		A 38-module intercultural practice curriculum, leadership development across the employee life cycle, and research on leadership styles with an eleven-course series.	Built, with one element proposed
5	Fair contracting and procurement	The practice of analysis before a decision reaches contracting, though no material names procurement directly.	Not yet built
6	Communicate clearly and accessibly	Accessibility checks, plain language guidance, language access planning, interpreter practice, and accessible-document practice — and every page of the Program built to the same standard it teaches.	Built

Two goals are substantially answered. Three are partly answered, and each one is missing the same thing: a way to measure whether the practice is changing anything. One goal, fair contracting and procurement, has almost nothing built against it. That uneven picture is the real state of the work, and it is more useful to state it plainly than to report that all six are in progress.

7. How the Program fits the wider Department

The Program is not a separate initiative running alongside the Department's commitments. It is an instrument for meeting commitments the Division has already accepted.

The commitment	What it requires	How the Program serves it
The One Minnesota Plan	The State's commitment to closing disparities.	The Program is one of the instruments through which a division actually meets it.
The Olmstead Plan	Minnesota's obligations on community integration for people with disabilities.	Woven through the Division's program profiles and practice scenarios.
The DHS Equity Policy and its Equity Analysis Toolkit	What the Department requires of every administration and division.	The Program includes a companion and a guided walkthrough, so the toolkit can be applied to work beyond policy development.
The Administration's equity implementation plan	Six goals, set out in the previous section.	Traced goal by goal, with an honest status for each.
The Division's own operational plan	Four requirements: analysis before major changes, documented community	The Program supports three of the four directly. The fourth, data broken

The commitment	What it requires	How the Program serves it
	engagement, accessibility and plain language, and data broken down by group.	down by group, is the requirement not yet met.

8. Program integrity, and the communities the Division serves

Across the Department there have been indications of problems in program integrity, and the Department has made responding to them a priority. A complete response has two parts. One is the integrity work itself, which sits with the offices that hold it. The other is making sure that, as that work proceeds, the people the Division serves continue to be seen accurately, and that attention meant for specific conduct does not come to rest on a whole community.

All of us carry biases; that is part of being human. What matters is whether they travel into how a program is appraised, or how the people who receive its services are appraised. The purpose of this material is to help each of us recognize our own and set them aside long enough to consider a situation from another person's perspective.

This is subtler than it first sounds. The most familiar position in a public agency is that we treat everyone the same and do not see difference at all. It is sincerely meant. It can still produce unequal results, because it applies a single lens to people whose circumstances are not the same, and traditionally, at this Department, that lens has been the dominant cultural one. The aim is not to replace it. The aim is to make sure it is not the only lens available to us, and that is what becoming a multicultural organization means.

Three courses and the community briefs were developed together for this purpose, and their purposes stay distinct. The briefs exist so that staff understand the communities the Division serves. The courses exist so that a response stays proportionate to what actually happened.

Course	What it does
What Fraud Enforcement Actually Costs	Real wrongdoing causes real harm, and so does a response that is not careful. The course holds both at once: how a publicly funded service can outgrow its safeguards, who else is affected when it does, and what a proportionate response looks like.
Public Perception, Misperception, and the Communities We Serve	How a story about one organization becomes a story about an entire community, and how to communicate accurately so that it does not.
Protecting the Program Without Becoming the Harm	Practical habits for staff whose work touches integrity review or communication: where bias risk hides, how to draft a notice, and a check a person can actually run.

One boundary holds all of it together. Understanding a community informs practice; it never substitutes for the person in front of you. A brief describes a landscape, not an individual, and the decision always belongs with the person receiving the service. That is what keeps cultural knowledge from hardening into a new set of assumptions, and what keeps the Program person-centered rather than paternalistic.

No one wants to see the program harmed, and no one wants a person penalized for what someone else did. The same practice serves both.

9. How the consultant's role works, and why the Program is shaped by it

This section is included because the design of the Program follows directly from the design of the position, and the two are easy to confuse.

The position

The Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant post is the only one of its kind in the Department of Human Services. It was created primarily to serve the Disability Services Division. There is no line of authority running from the Administration to the Division with respect to this role. The consultant collaborates, consults, and works with the Administration's Equity Director, Deqa Sayid, and the position's work direction sits within the Division. That was deliberate when the position was established, and it is why this Program is built to stand on its own.

The consultant's expectations are grounded in the Department's, the Department being the controlling authority for equity work across the agency, and in the position description itself, which Jason Flint, then the operations manager, helped to craft. Mr. Flint also co-created the agreed decomposition of the position in early 2023, the document that sets out the duties this Program is built to carry. He has since left the Department; the structure that work established is what set this Program in motion.

What the role provides, and what it does not

The consultant provides the means. Resources, tools, curriculum, practical knowledge, and skills that any staff member or leader can pick up and apply in their own work.

The consultant does not do the equity work on anyone's behalf. Building the resources and also performing the work they support are two different jobs, and only the first belongs to this role. Applying equity in the daily conduct of the Division's business belongs to everyone in it — that is what equity is. This is stated plainly because it has been misunderstood before, and because a Program that quietly assumed otherwise would relieve everyone else of accountability on the theory that the consultant is there to fix it.

The consultant does not impose a view of how equity must be executed. No workgroup, initiative, or unit is told what its equity practice must look like. The Program makes the means available; what a team does with them is that team's judgment.

The consultant is not an enforcer. Offering workshops and discussion that socialize the Equity Analysis Toolkit is squarely within this role. Holding divisions, leaders, and staff accountable for actually using the Toolkit sits with the Equity Director, across the Department. Asking one person to be both the teacher and the enforcer is inconsistent with the role, inconsistent with its purpose, and inconsistent with basic practice in this field. It would also make the consultant both the architect and the operator of the Program, which is precisely the arrangement that lets accountability dissolve.

What this Program is: a guidance tool

This Program is designed to support what is currently happening in the Division, and it leaves organizational structures and established practice where they are, with the people who own them.

It is a guidance tool. It holds the knowledge and experience of the consultant, arranged so that other people can pick it up and use it, and it is consistent with the six goals the Administration's Equity Director has set out and with the Department's own goals. The Department is the body instituting change across the agency. This Program takes its cue from that direction and makes it usable at the level of a division.

The developmental picture, and what it asks of us

There is a reason this Program takes the shape it does rather than a more directive one, and it has to do with where the organization actually is.

The Department's Intercultural Development Inventory coordinator, Nicole Urbach, reported that DHS as a whole operates in Minimization — a stage at which difference tends to be smoothed over rather than genuinely engaged. That the Office of Employee Culture and the Innovation and Impact team are actively designing changes to practice is itself an acknowledgment that the organization is not where it intends to be. The agency's stated goal is to become an anti-racist, multicultural organization.

The most recent appraisal placed Disability Services Division leadership in Acceptance, a more developed position than the Department as a whole, and that is a real asset to this work. A shift of this kind asks something of everyone involved. Some of it is uncomfortable, because examining familiar practice usually is — and that discomfort is part of the work rather than a sign that something has gone wrong.

This work exists to move the Division toward a place where multiple cultural perspectives genuinely shape how decisions are made. That is how an organization grows, individually and collectively — and that includes the consultant, who learns alongside the Division. It is a collaborative approach by design.

Where visibility into planning at the Administration level is not available to this role, the Program is built to continue regardless. That is a statement about how the work is structured rather than a grievance. It is simply the reason the Program is designed to be self-sufficient, and to remain useful whatever is or is not shared from above.

What this frees the role to do

Because the Program carries the resources, the consultant is freed to work closely where a specific need exists: with a particular workgroup, or with Charles Young on the legislative work that reports to the Division Director. A consultant can be brought in to understand what is happening and to help shape an approach without being embedded in every initiative. That was the pattern that did not work before, and the Program is the structure that replaces it.

The Division Director has expressed a wish for closer work between this role and the legislative work Charles Young carries, and the Program is what makes that possible. When the resources no longer depend on the consultant being in the room, the consultant's time can go where it is worth most: sitting with the management team and the leadership team, learning what their priorities for the Division actually are, and offering advisory input on programs under consideration while the advantages and disadvantages can still be weighed. That kind of face to face advice is difficult to offer when one person is also the only route to every resource. It is also how the work stops being siloed.

Why it cannot rest on one leader's view

If the Program depended on the understanding or preference of whoever currently holds a leadership post, it would move whenever that post changed hands, and it would be unfair to ask the work to survive that. It is also a practical matter of where the organization is starting from: the Department's own Intercultural Development Inventory coordinator, Nicole Urbach, reported that DHS as a whole operates in Minimization, while the agency's stated goal is to become an anti-racist, multicultural organization. Closing that distance is a matter of sustained practice, not a matter of any single leader's tenure.

Where responsibility sits

The consultant surfaces what is needed and supplies the means; how the Program is put to use in each area is shaped by the leaders and staff who own that work. The DHS Equity Policy is explicit that responsibility for equity is shared, and the Program is built on that: leadership, staff and consultant each carry a part, and the work goes furthest when each part is held.

10. Boundaries that protect staff

These boundaries are stated plainly because they protect both staff and the Division.

- It is not a case management system, and holds no client records.
- It is not a personnel system. It does not evaluate, rank, score, or report on any employee.
- It is not a complaint or investigation channel.
- It is not a required training program. Participation is voluntary, and completion does not count toward required training credits unless leadership expressly approves an exception.
- It does not assign anyone a developmental level, a cultural identity, or a diagnosis.

11. What is required and not yet built

Three requirements remain unmet. Each is named here so that the picture is complete.

Requirement	What is missing	What it depends on
Data and accountability	The Division needs a starting measurement, data broken down by group, and a way for a team to see how it is doing in its own area. None of that exists yet. This is the largest single gap, and every other unfinished goal traces back to it.	Requires authorization, and the cooperation of Human Resources and the data office.
Leadership competencies	A framework for the skills leaders are expected to build, connected to a recognized coaching instrument and to performance plans.	Requires a decision and a budget from the Division Director and the Administration.
State law and policy	Plain-language guidance connecting the Division's statutory obligations to its everyday practice, and equity analysis entering proposals before positions are set.	Requires an agreed scope with the Department's government relations office.

12. What is being asked of you

Your reading of this, and your thoughts, by December 1, 2026. Not approval — this is offered so that Division leadership understands what the Program is, who it helps, and where it is going. With your reflections in hand by December 1, there is time to prepare how staff are told about the Program, so that people hear what it is and what it offers them before it opens rather than at the same moment.

The work is well underway and moving toward the point where the Program is ready to open. What has been built so far is set out above. What remains is set out in section 11. The greater part of the benefit lies in what follows the opening, not in what has been assembled to reach it.

Evidence Record

The 23 division-wide sessions in full: 172 findings and 131 recommendations, attributed to teams and de-identified.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
IN COLLABORATION WITH	Sarah Shepherd, Project Manager, Disability Services Division
PREPARED FOR	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager — Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
SESSIONS RECORDED	23 · 172 findings · 131 recommendations
DATE OF THIS RECORD	September 18, 2026
STATUS	Draft for review

What this record is

This is the record of what staff said. Between January and July 2023 the consultant conducted 71 interviews independently across the Disability Services Division. From April 2023 the work continued in collaboration with Sarah Shepherd, Project Manager for the Division, and ran in that form until December 2023, producing a general equity assessment and a program of division-wide listening sessions. The interviews themselves were conducted by the consultant alone. That collaboration continued on planning matters until the project manager's departure from the agency at the end of 2024.

This document sets out the findings and recommendations from 23 of those sessions: 172 findings and 131 recommendations, as given by the teams themselves. It is the evidentiary basis for the qualitative analysis "What the Division Said" and, through it, for the One DSD People, Access and Culture Program.

How to read it

- **Findings** are what a team described about its own conditions, practice and experience.
- **Recommendations** are what that same team proposed. They are the Division's own proposals, not the consultant's.
- Sessions are grouped by program teams, then by managers, supervisors and directors, then by the session held for staff who could not attend their own team's meeting.

De-identification

Findings and recommendations are attributed to teams, never to individuals. Where the original notes named a person, the text here reads "a participant." That was the condition under which people spoke and it is preserved. Sarah Shepherd is named as facilitator and analyst, which is credit for professional work rather than identification of a participant.

Scope and limits

- This record covers what was said in these sessions. It is a record of perception and experience, which is the appropriate evidence for questions of culture, and it is not a measurement of conditions.
- Three one-to-one community engagement meetings held in the same period are excluded. They involved named external partners rather than anonymous staff participants and belong to the community engagement record.
- Editorial cleaning has been applied: duplicated passages and working notes from the original drafting have been removed. No finding or recommendation has been added, softened or reordered in substance.
- Anything concerning Native American individuals, communities or Tribal Nations defers to the Office of Indian Affairs and the Department offices that handle Tribal relations and consultation. Findings that touch Tribal relationships are reported as stated and are not developed further.

Program teams

17 sessions · 113 findings · 87 recommendations

Interagency Leads and Strategic Communications

Key findings

- **Website accessibility.** The team acknowledged that DSD's public-facing websites are difficult to navigate, posing a significant accessibility issue, particularly for people with disabilities.
- **Lack of understanding of communities.** The team expressed concern about a lack of understanding of the communities DSD serves and difficulties in effectively reaching those communities.
- **Need for collaborative community engagement.** The team emphasized the need for a more systemic and collaborative approach to community engagement, ensuring that diverse voices are heard and included in decision-making processes.
- **Document translation barriers.** The team identified significant barriers in translating documents, including funding constraints and a lack of clear processes for securing translation services. They also highlighted the need to explore alternative communication methods for communities with oral cultures.
- **Intersectional approach.** The team recognized the importance of taking an intersectional approach to disability and racial justice, acknowledging that individuals with disabilities may face multiple forms of discrimination and marginalization.

The team's recommendations

- **Enhance community engagement.** Implement a more robust and collaborative approach to community engagement, including consultation with an ethnographer and engagement

specialist. This will help DSD better understand the needs of diverse communities and develop culturally relevant programs and services.

- **Develop a user-friendly HCBS portal.** Create a more accessible and user-friendly HCBS portal that is easy to navigate for people with disabilities and their families.
- **Address translation barriers.** Develop a clear and streamlined process for translating documents, including securing adequate funding for translation services. Explore alternative communication methods, such as visual aids and oral interpretation, to ensure effective communication with communities that rely on oral traditions.
- **Prioritize intersectionality.** Adopt an intersectional approach to disability and racial justice, recognizing the unique challenges faced by individuals with disabilities from marginalized communities. Develop programs and services that address the complex needs of these individuals and promote equity and inclusion.
- **Analyze E1MN data.** Conduct a thorough analysis of E1MN baseline data to identify disparities and develop targeted interventions to address them. Foster collaboration among agencies and stakeholders to implement these interventions and improve employment outcomes for people with disabilities.

Community Capacity and Positive Supports

Key findings

- **Sustaining community engagement.** The team acknowledged the challenge of building and sustaining effective community engagement efforts. They recognized the need for ongoing support and resources to maintain these initiatives over the long term.
- **Barriers to provider diversity.** The team identified several barriers that hinder diversity in the provider workforce, including language requirements for direct support professionals and a lack of mentorship opportunities for providers from marginalized communities.
- **Equity in contracting.** The team emphasized the need for an equity review process for contracts and RFPs to ensure that these processes are fair, transparent, and accessible to all potential vendors, including those from historically underrepresented communities.
- **Inclusivity for employees with disabilities.** The team raised concerns about the inclusivity and psychological safety of employees with disabilities within DHS. They highlighted the need for greater awareness and understanding of disability-related issues and a more supportive work environment for employees with disabilities.

The team's recommendations

- **Training on cultural competency and psychological safety.** Provide training for managers and supervisors on cultural competency, implicit bias, and creating a psychologically safe work environment. This will help promote a more inclusive and supportive workplace for all employees.
- **Address barriers to provider diversity.** Review and address barriers that hinder diversity in the provider workforce, such as language requirements and lack of mentorship opportunities.

This can include providing language support and mentorship programs for providers from marginalized communities.

- **Implement equity review for contracts.** Implement an equity review process for all contracts and RFPs to ensure that these processes are fair and accessible to all vendors, including those from historically underrepresented communities.
- **Promote inclusivity for employees with disabilities.** Promote a more inclusive and supportive work environment for employees with disabilities. This can include raising awareness of disability-related issues, providing reasonable accommodations, and fostering a culture of understanding and acceptance.

Equity Needs Waiver Policy Compliance Team

Key findings

- **Challenges Communicating Equity Information.** The team identified challenges in communicating equity information effectively, particularly when discussing topics that intersect with other divisions or agencies, such as housing.
- **Need for Intersectional Cultural Competency Training.** The team expressed a desire for more cultural competency training that addresses the intersectionality of disability with other identities, such as race and LGBTQIA+ status. They acknowledged a knowledge gap in understanding the diverse needs of different communities.
- **Embedding Equity in Daily Work.** The team wants to embed equity into their daily work but feels hindered by a lack of clear direction from leadership and a fear of failure or upsetting certain groups.
- **Data Gaps and Analysis Needs.** The team identified data gaps and challenges in accessing and analyzing data, including a lack of training on qualitative data analysis and the need for a dedicated data analysis team.
- **Collaboration with Data & Quality Improvement Team.** The team noted a closer relationship with the Data & Quality Improvement Team and suggested they could potentially serve as their data analysis team.
- **Staff Readiness for DEIA.** The team expressed a willingness to engage in DEIA work but needs guidance and support from leadership on how to do so effectively.

The team's recommendations

- **Establish a Data Analysis Team.** Establish a dedicated data analysis team to support the Waiver Policy Compliance Team in accessing, analyzing, and interpreting data.
- **Clarify DEIA Leadership and Direction.** Provide clear direction and leadership on DEIA goals and priorities, empowering staff to take action and embed equity into their daily work.
- **Foster a Culture of Learning and Experimentation.** Encourage a culture of learning and experimentation, where staff feel safe to take risks and learn from mistakes.

- **Improve Data Collection and Access.** Improve data collection processes and provide staff with access to the data they need to conduct equity analyses.
- **Develop Communication Strategies.** Develop communication strategies to effectively discuss work that intersects with other divisions or agencies, ensuring clarity and avoiding confusion.

Meeting Observation:

EIDB Team

Key findings

- **Negative Perceptions and Bias.** The team experiences negative perceptions and bias from other divisions, leading to a sense of distrust and frustration.
- **Policy-Related Barriers.** The team identified policy-related barriers as a major obstacle to DEIA work, highlighting that these barriers are often internal to DHS rather than legislative.
- **Bureaucratic Delays and Inefficiencies.** The team expressed frustration with bureaucratic delays and inefficiencies, citing lengthy approval processes for essential resources and activities.
- **Lack of Flexibility in Funding and Policies.** The team highlighted a lack of flexibility in funding and policies, particularly regarding community engagement events and reimbursement processes.
- **Impact on Staff Morale.** The team noted that the challenges and frustrations they face negatively impact staff morale and contribute to a sense of discouragement.

The team's recommendations

- **Review and Revise Internal Policies.** Review and revise internal policies that create barriers to DEIA work, particularly those related to community engagement, resource allocation, and approval processes.
- **Increase Flexibility and Efficiency.** Increase flexibility and efficiency in funding and policies, particularly regarding community engagement events, reimbursements, and access to essential resources.
- **Provide Clear Decision-Making Authority.** Provide the EIDB team with clear decision-making authority and reduce bureaucratic hurdles to empower them to carry out their work effectively.
- **Develop DEIA Support Resources.** Develop a comprehensive DEIA policy and provide access to support resources, such as a how-to guide for community engagement and a dedicated administrative staff member to assist with processes like setting up interpretation services.
- **Establish Division-Level SMART Goals.** Establish division-level SMART goals for DEIA to provide clear direction and align efforts across all business units.
- **Provide Supervisory Support.** Assign a dedicated supervisor to the EIDB team to provide support, guidance, and advocacy within the division.

Service Agreement and Screening Document (SASD) Support Team

Key findings

- **Focus on Efficiency and Minimizing Bias.** The team prioritizes efficiency and minimizing bias in their work, operating on a first-come, first-serve basis and maintaining a high moral standard to ensure people receive services as quickly as possible.
- **Limited Data Analysis.** The team does not conduct demographic analysis or pull reports on inequities, as their focus is on identifying trends and errors to improve efficiency and support lead agencies.
- **Psychological Safety.** The supervisor prioritizes creating a psychologically safe environment for the team, recognizing its importance for employee success and retention.
- **Challenges Updating Forms.** The team lead identified challenges in updating required fields on the Security Access Form in MMIS to be more inclusive of gender diversity.
- **Positive Team Culture.** The team has a positive culture that values knowledge sharing and cross-training to minimize bias and ensure work gets done efficiently.

The team's recommendations

- **Continue Prioritizing Psychological Safety.** Continue to prioritize creating a psychologically safe environment for the team, encouraging open communication and support for all members.
- **Address Form Updates.** Address the challenges in updating the Security Access Form in MMIS to be more inclusive of gender diversity.
- **Explore DEIA Training Opportunities.** Explore DEIA training opportunities that are specifically relevant to the team's work, focusing on how they can contribute to equitable access to services through their role in data entry and processing requests.

Research/Evaluation Team (Data and Quality Improvement)

Key findings

- **Challenges with Data Limitations.** The team faces challenges due to data limitations, including restricted access to certain data sets and the structure of existing data collection systems, which were primarily designed for billing rather than research.
- **Reactive Research Agenda.** The team's research agenda is often driven by the needs of policy teams and external stakeholders, limiting their ability to proactively pursue research questions related to equity.
- **Communication and Collaboration Barriers.** The team experiences communication and collaboration barriers, with a desire for earlier engagement in projects and a need for greater influence in applying equity considerations to data analysis.
- **Missed Opportunities for Continuous Improvement.** The team identified missed opportunities for applying a continuous improvement model to research and evaluation efforts, with a tendency for projects to be "one and done" rather than iterative.

The team's recommendations

- **Empower Proactive Research.** Empower the Research/Evaluation team to set their own proactive research agenda, allowing them to explore equity-related questions and contribute to a deeper understanding of disparities.
- **Enhance Collaboration and Communication.** Promote early and ongoing collaboration between the Research/Evaluation team and policy teams to ensure that equity considerations are integrated into all phases of projects.
- **Implement Continuous Improvement.** Implement a continuous improvement model for research and evaluation, ensuring that findings are used to inform ongoing learning and adaptation.
- **Support Qualitative Data Analysis.** Provide training and resources to support qualitative data analysis, enabling the team to gather richer insights and tell more comprehensive stories about the data.

Fiscal Policy Team

Key findings

- **Need for Coordinated Community Outreach.** The team expressed a desire for a more coordinated approach to community outreach and a clear strategy for explaining how communities will benefit from DSD programs.
- **Challenges with County Collaboration.** The team acknowledged challenges in working with counties, who may be resistant to DSD's guidance due to their role in administering programs.
- **Communication Barriers.** The team identified communication barriers, including inaccessible communications and issues with translation and interpretation services.
- **Disconnect with Communities.** The team recognized a disconnect between DSD and the communities they serve, emphasizing the need to improve community engagement and understanding of diverse cultures.

The team's recommendations

- **Improve Communication Accessibility.** Ensure all communications are accessible, including providing translation and interpretation services as needed.
- **Strengthen Collaboration with Counties.** Strengthen collaboration with counties by establishing clear expectations, shared goals, and mutual understanding of roles and responsibilities.
- **Explore Alternative Service Delivery Models.** Explore alternative service delivery models that reduce reliance on counties and increase direct engagement with communities.
- **Address Implicit Bias.** Provide training on implicit bias to address potential disparities in hiring and promotion practices. Meeting Observation:

Program Integrity

Key findings

- **Focus on Language Accessibility.** The team is prioritizing language accessibility, particularly in Somali, and working to remove language barriers in systems like cost reporting.
- **Equity Goals in Waiver Reimagine.** The team highlighted the inclusion of equity goals in the Waiver Reimagine policy and emphasized stakeholder engagement as a key component.
- **Outreach Challenges for ABLE Accounts.** The team acknowledged challenges in reaching diverse communities to promote ABLE accounts, particularly the disability community in general.
- **Distrust and Need for Community Education.** The team recognized a need to address distrust and build stronger relationships with the disability community, suggesting community education as a potential strategy.
- **Importance of Consistent Engagement.** The team emphasized the importance of consistent engagement and resource availability to build trust with community stakeholders.
- **Addressing Stigma.** The team identified the need to address stigma surrounding disability within specific communities, such as the Hmong community, and suggested providing education and resources to promote understanding and acceptance.
- **Need for Accessible Communication.** The team highlighted the need for accessible communication, including plain language and culturally competent interpretation services.
- **Data Collection Efforts.** The team is engaged in data collection efforts, including workforce data from the provider perspective and direct input from DSP providers to inform decisions about wage increases and address equity within the workforce.
- **Challenges Accessing HR Data.** The team expressed frustration with the lack of access to HR statistics and a desire for more transparency and discussion around recruitment, hiring, and retention practices.

The team's recommendations

- **Secure Funding for Community Engagement.** Secure funding and resources to support community engagement efforts, including public education campaigns about disability services and DSD's role.
- **Build Trust with Community Stakeholders.** Prioritize building trust with community stakeholders through consistent engagement, culturally competent communication, and responsiveness to community needs.
- **Address Stigma.** Develop targeted strategies to address stigma surrounding disability within specific communities, such as providing culturally relevant education and resources.
- **Improve Access to HR Data.** Improve access to HR data and promote greater transparency and discussion around recruitment, hiring, and retention practices.
- **Support Internal Staff Development.** Invest in internal staff development to foster a healthy and inclusive workplace.

Disability Hub & Response System

Key findings

- **Need for Expanded VIP Participation.** The team expressed a desire to expand participation in the VIP and embed it as a regular part of project management plans.
- **Translation and Accessibility Challenges.** The team identified challenges and inconsistencies in the process and requirements for translating documents and ensuring accessibility, particularly for the Disability Hub website and e-Docs forms.
- **Capacity for Community Engagement.** The team highlighted the need for increased staff resources to build and maintain relationships with BIPOC communities and track the success of outreach efforts.
- **Building Trust with Communities.** The team recognized the importance of building trust with historically excluded communities and understanding the historical harm caused by DHS.
- **Internal Feedback Loop.** The team identified a need for a consistent internal feedback loop to effectively communicate community feedback across the division.
- **Siloed Nature of the Division.** The team expressed frustration with the siloed nature of the division and the lack of consultation and communication before sending out external communications.
- **Limited Communication Modalities.** The team noted that DHS relies heavily on written communication and e-list serves, limiting options for people who prefer or require alternative communication methods.

The team's recommendations

- **Clarify Translation and Accessibility Processes.** Develop clear processes, requirements, and best practices for translation and interpretation services, ensuring consistency and accessibility across all DSD materials.
 - **Increase Community Engagement Staff.** Increase staff resources dedicated to community engagement to build and maintain relationships with BIPOC and historically excluded communities.
 - **Develop Internal Feedback Loop.** Establish a consistent internal feedback loop to effectively communicate community feedback across the division and ensure responsiveness to community needs.
 - **Promote Collaboration and Communication.** Promote collaboration and communication across teams to break down silos and ensure that the RRS team is consulted before sending out external communications.
 - **Diversify Communication Modalities.** Diversify communication modalities beyond written materials and e-list serves to reach a wider audience and accommodate different communication preferences.
- Meeting Observation:

TTC (Training and Technical Consultation)

Key findings

- **Accessibility Expertise.** The team has expertise in accessibility and incorporates it into their work, but they believe accessibility should be embedded in everyone's job responsibilities.
- **Translation Challenges.** The team identified translation for non-English speaking audiences as a significant challenge, noting capacity issues and backlogs.
- **Inconsistency in Translation.** The team raised concerns about inconsistencies in translation, where different translators may produce different results for the same language.
- **Accountability for Contractors.** The team emphasized the need for greater accountability for contractors regarding accessibility, noting that contractors often do not meet contractual obligations and DHS does not hold them accountable.
- **Limited Access to Accessibility Tools.** The team has access to CommonLook, an expensive accessibility checker, but its steep learning curve and limited availability hinder wider use within the division.
- **Need for Workforce Diversity.** The team acknowledged the lack of diversity within the TTC team and the division as a whole, recognizing that a more diverse workforce would improve their ability to serve diverse communities.
- **Challenges Applying Equity Toolkit.** The team found it challenging to apply the equity toolkit to communications, suggesting that the toolkit is more geared toward policy development.

The team's recommendations

- **Establish Accessibility Standards and Training.** Require all DSD staff to complete accessibility training, potentially including both levels of the Accessibility Advocates program.
 - **Improve Contractor Accountability.** Implement stricter accountability measures for contractors regarding accessibility, ensuring that they meet contractual obligations and deliver accessible products.
 - **Increase Access to Accessibility Tools.** Explore options for increasing access to accessibility tools, such as CommonLook, and provide training and support for staff to use these tools effectively.
 - **Prioritize Workforce Diversity.** Prioritize hiring and promoting a more diverse workforce at all levels within the TTC team and the division as a whole.
 - **Develop Communications-Specific Equity Toolkit.** Develop an equity toolkit that is specifically tailored to the needs of communications professionals, providing guidance and examples for applying equity principles in a communications context.
 - **Support Employee Resource Groups (ERGs).** Ensure that all DSD supervisors and managers allow and support their staff to attend ERGs, promoting inclusivity and employee engagement.
- Meeting Observation:

Moving Home Minnesota (MHM)

Key findings

- **Tribal Liaison Role.** The team highlighted the importance of the Tribal Liaison role and the need for continued collaboration and communication between MHM and the Tribal Nations.
- **Budget Flexibility.** The team acknowledged the greater budget flexibility within MHM due to its federal funding source, suggesting it could be a potential resource for funding equity projects.
- **Onboarding Challenges.** The team identified challenges with onboarding new employees, including a lack of coordination and support in providing essential information and resources.
- **Employee Engagement.** The team highlighted the need for ongoing employee engagement and check-ins to assess and support employee well-being and morale.
- **DEIA Training and Tools.** The team expressed interest in utilizing various DEIA training and tools, such as Insight Discovery and Strengths Finder, but acknowledged the challenge of embedding these frameworks into daily work practices.
- **Consistency in DEIA Efforts.** The team identified a lack of consistency as a barrier to engaging people in DEIA work and stressed the need for better coordination and follow-through.
- **Need for Stakeholder Engagement.** The team expressed a need for an established stakeholder group to provide community engagement and feedback on various items.
- **Centralized Communication.** The team highlighted the need for centralized and easily accessible external communications with a common voice, rather than information being siloed by different teams.

The team's recommendations

- **Prioritize Employee Engagement.** Prioritize employee engagement through regular check-ins, mentorship opportunities, and support for professional development.
- **Embed DEIA Frameworks.** Develop strategies to effectively embed DEIA frameworks and tools, such as Insight Discovery and Strengths Finder, into daily work practices and team interactions.
- **Ensure Consistency in DEIA Efforts.** Ensure consistency in DEIA efforts through clear communication, coordination, and accountability across the division.
- **Establish Stakeholder Engagement Group.** Establish a formal stakeholder group, potentially leveraging the existing Virtual Insight Panel (VIP), to provide ongoing community engagement and feedback on MHM initiatives.
- **Develop Centralized Communication Strategy.** Develop a centralized communication strategy that ensures consistent messaging and easy access to information for external stakeholders.

Assessment and Support Planning Team

Key findings

- **DEIA Initiatives.** The team is engaged in several DEIA initiatives, including community engagement with BIPOC communities through Queen Health, aligning data collection with gender-inclusive terms, developing an Individual and Family Guide, and creating Tribal Nation contracts specific to MnCHOICES activities.
- **Accessibility Concerns.** The team raised concerns about the accessibility of e-DOCS forms, noting that a provider reported an employee with a screen reader being unable to access the forms. Despite escalation, the issue has not been resolved, highlighting a need for improved accessibility across DSD systems.
- **Translation Needs.** The team identified the need for document translation but currently relies on lead agencies to fulfill this responsibility.
- **Internal Ownership and Accountability.** The team emphasized the need for internal ownership and accountability for DEIA initiatives, expressing frustration with the slow pace of progress and a desire for a dedicated individual or team to champion DEIA efforts.

The team's recommendations

- **Develop Translation Processes.** Develop clear processes and allocate resources for document translation, clarifying responsibilities between DHS and lead agencies.
- **Establish DEIA Ownership.** Establish clear ownership and accountability for DEIA initiatives within DSD, potentially through a dedicated team or individual.
- **Improve Cross-Division Collaboration.** Improve collaboration and communication across divisions to streamline DEIA efforts and address systemic barriers.
- **Invest in Community Engagement.** Invest in coordinated community engagement efforts across DSD to build strong relationships with diverse communities.

Regional Resource Specialist (RRS) Team

Key findings

- **Training Accessibility.** The team noted that DEIA trainings are often not recorded, limiting access for staff who cannot attend live sessions.
- **Document Translation Barriers.** The team identified significant barriers to document translation, including funding constraints and a lack of ownership over DHS documents. They highlighted the challenge of providing translated materials to people who receive services and emphasized the need for translators who understand DSD's work.
- **Provider Support Needs.** The team identified a need for greater support for providers, particularly culturally specific providers, who may not be aware of available resources or receive adequate mentorship.
- **Wage Disparities.** The team raised concerns about wage disparities for individuals providing services in ASL, noting that hospitals offer more competitive pay.

- **Workforce Diversity.** The team acknowledged the lack of diversity within the State and lead agencies, recognizing that a predominantly white, middle-class, female workforce creates barriers to access and representation.
- **Lead Agency Accountability.** The team discussed the need for clear expectations and support from DHS before holding lead agencies accountable for DEIA initiatives. They emphasized the importance of meeting lead agencies where they are at and providing resources to support implementation.
- **Feedback Mechanisms.** The team highlighted the need for effective feedback mechanisms to gather input from people receiving services about culturally appropriate services.
- **Workforce Development.** The team suggested reaching out to local universities to diversify the workforce and address the underrepresentation of certain groups.
- **Pay Equity for Contracted Case Managers.** The team raised concerns about contracted case managers being paid less than lead agency case managers, despite providing the same services.

The team's recommendations

- **Improve Training Accessibility.** Record DEIA trainings and make them accessible to all staff.
- **Develop Translation Processes.** Develop a straightforward document translation process and secure dedicated funding for translation services.
- **Provide Provider Support.** Create a provider support role to assist providers, particularly culturally specific providers, in accessing resources and navigating DHS systems.
- **Address Wage Disparities.** Address wage disparities for individuals providing services in ASL to ensure competitive pay and attract qualified professionals.
- **Increase Workforce Diversity.** Develop strategies to increase workforce diversity within the State and lead agencies, including reviewing hiring requirements and building relationships with local universities.
- **Clarify Expectations for Lead Agencies.** Clarify DEIA expectations for lead agencies and provide support and resources to facilitate implementation.
- **Develop Feedback Mechanisms.** Develop effective feedback mechanisms to gather input from people receiving services about culturally appropriate services.
- **Address Pay Equity for Case Managers.** Explore options for addressing pay equity concerns between lead agency and contracted case managers.

Division Supports

Key findings

- **Community Engagement Resources.** The team identified a need for dedicated staff and funding to support community engagement efforts, including "boots-on-the-ground" engagement specialists who can build trust with diverse communities.

- **Innovation and Action.** The team encouraged DSD to take ownership of DEIA initiatives and act independently, rather than waiting for guidance or permission from the agency level.
- **Building Trust.** The team acknowledged the lack of trust between DHS and communities, highlighting the need to prioritize building trust through consistent engagement and action.
- **Clarity of Expectations.** The team expressed a desire for clearer guidance on DEIA expectations and requirements, noting that the Office of Grants Management does not provide sufficient support.
- **Challenges with Community Reviewers.** The team identified challenges in incorporating community reviewers into RFP processes, citing the need for significant planning time, resources, and a robust infrastructure to support their involvement.

The team's recommendations

- **Hire Engagement Specialists.** Hire "boots-on-the-ground" engagement specialists who can build trust with diverse communities and facilitate authentic engagement.
- **Empower DSD to Take Action.** Empower DSD to take ownership of DEIA initiatives and act independently, fostering a culture of innovation and action.
- **Prioritize Building Trust.** Prioritize building trust with communities through consistent engagement, transparency, and responsiveness to community needs.
- **Clarify DEIA Expectations.** Provide clear guidance and support on DEIA expectations and requirements for all DSD staff.
- **Develop Infrastructure for Community Reviewers.** Develop a robust infrastructure to support the meaningful involvement of community reviewers in RFP processes, including dedicated funding, training, and mentorship opportunities.

Home Care and Self-Directed Services

Key findings

- **Knowledge of Accessibility.** Team members are developing personal goals for improving their understanding of accessibility and applying it to their work.
- **BIPOC Representation in Home Care.** The team recognized that the home care workforce is predominantly BIPOC, highlighting the need for greater representation within DSD staff to reflect the communities they serve.
- **Plain Language Needs.** The team identified a need for plain language in EVV training materials and process guides, noting that current materials are not accessible or user-friendly.
- **Training Development.** The team expressed a desire for DSD to develop its own EVV training materials, as existing materials from the vendor are inadequate.
- **Prioritizing PCA Services.** The team highlighted the need to prioritize PCA services, which serve a larger proportion of BIPOC individuals compared to waiver services, and suggested using Moving Home Minnesota funds to support PCA providers and individuals.

- **Challenges with Advancement.** The team discussed challenges with career advancement within DSD, particularly for individuals transitioning from direct care roles to policy or administrative positions.
- **Gatekeeping in Hiring.** The team raised concerns about hiring requirements, such as degree requirements, acting as gatekeepers and limiting opportunities for individuals from diverse backgrounds.
- **Internal Accessibility.** The team emphasized the need for internal staff to have access to accessible materials and resources.

The team's recommendations

- **Review Hiring and Promotion Practices.** Review hiring and promotion practices to address barriers to advancement for individuals from direct care roles and ensure that qualifications are assessed equitably.
- **Revisit Job Requirements.** Revisit job requirements and consider removing unnecessary barriers, such as degree requirements, to promote diversity and inclusivity in hiring.
- **Provide Accessible Training Materials.** Ensure all training materials and resources are accessible to internal staff, including those with disabilities.
- **Develop EVV Training.** Develop clear and accessible EVV training materials and process guides in plain language.
- **Prioritize PCA Services.** Prioritize PCA services and allocate resources to support PCA providers and individuals, recognizing the disproportionate impact on BIPOC communities.

HCBS Compliance Coordination

Key findings

- **Workforce Diversity.** The team acknowledges a lack of diversity within their section and a need for better representation to reflect the communities they serve.
- **PCA Workforce Concerns.** The team raised concerns about the potential risks and increased overhead associated with workforce shortage initiatives for PCAs, which could lead to DHS becoming the employer of a large number of PCAs.
- **Accessibility Efforts.** The team is actively trying to improve accessibility for people with a variety of disabilities.
- **HR Barriers.** The team identified Human Resources as a barrier to DEIA efforts, citing issues with inaccessible job application processes, plain language impacting job classifications, and a lack of collaboration with HR on DEIA goals.
- **Legislative Challenges.** The team highlighted challenges with the legislative process, including insufficient funding for FTEs and difficulties working with HR to implement legislative changes.
- **Community Engagement Needs.** The team acknowledged a need for improved community engagement, particularly with BIPOC communities and those of low socioeconomic status.

- **Language Barriers.** The team identified language barriers as a significant issue, noting that providers and families are often required to communicate with DSD in English, while DSD does not sufficiently communicate in other languages.
- **Workplace Stress and Pressure.** The team experiences significant workplace stress and pressure due to political pressure, high visibility, and high-risk work, particularly related to the SEIU bargaining agreement.
- **Communication Challenges.** The team highlighted communication challenges, including the need for clearer communication about changes and initiatives to reduce fear and uncertainty among providers.
- **Individual DEIA Efforts.** Team members are individually incorporating equity into their work, particularly by focusing on accessibility and language accessibility.

The team's recommendations

- **Improve Community Engagement.** Develop and implement a comprehensive community engagement strategy to reach BIPOC communities and those of low socioeconomic status.
- **Address Language Barriers.** Address language barriers by providing translation and interpretation services and ensuring that DSD communicates effectively in languages other than English.
- **Reduce Workplace Stress.** Explore strategies to reduce workplace stress and pressure, potentially through increased staffing, clearer communication, and improved workload management.
- **Provide DEIA Learning Opportunities.** Provide dedicated time and resources for staff to learn about and apply equity principles to their work.
- **Re-evaluate Large Projects.** Re-evaluate large, ongoing projects to identify opportunities for incorporating equity and ensure alignment with DEIA goals.
- **Improve Cross-Team Collaboration.** Improve collaboration and support across teams to distribute workload more equitably and address specific needs, such as SEIU-related issues.
- **Clarify Roles and Responsibilities.** Clarify roles and responsibilities related to DEIA, particularly between DSD, the Governor's Office, and MMB, to ensure effective collaboration and avoid overburdening DSD staff.

Support Planning and Informed Choice Team

Key findings

- **Focus on Case Management Workforce.** The team is focused on identifying cultural competency training for onboarding new case managers and evaluating the existing case management workforce.
- **Equity Analyses.** The team intends to conduct equity analyses as part of their work and incorporate discussions about equity experiences into team meetings.

- **Equitable Hiring Practices.** The team has been using tools to evaluate candidates for open positions through a more equitable lens, considering factors like secondary language skills and partner engagement.
- **Frustration with Delays.** The team expressed frustration with delays and setbacks in rolling out DEIA initiatives, feeling "stymied" by leadership and a lack of clear direction.
- **Equity Analysis in Legislative Session.** The team suggested incorporating equity analysis into the legislative session, including refresher sessions and one-pagers for each proposal.
- **Data Analysis Needs.** The team acknowledged the need for expertise in understanding and interpreting data and expressed a desire to work more closely with the Data and Quality Improvement team.
- **Representation in Advisory Committees.** The team raised concerns about the lack of representation in advisory committees, particularly the TBI Advisory Committee, and the barriers faced by community members in participating, such as lack of stipends and reimbursement for transportation.
- **Language Accessibility.** The team highlighted the need for automatic communication in multiple languages, similar to practices in schools, and noted that DHS currently only communicates in one language.
- **Addressing "Political" Concerns.** The team encountered resistance from a provider who deemed sharing information about Pride month as "political," underscoring the need for DEIA training and education.
- **Training Audience Clarity.** The team emphasized the need for clarity on the target audience for DEIA trainings, considering whether to focus on provider leadership, direct service staff, or both.
- **Learning from External Best Practices.** The team suggested consulting with other businesses, corporations, and states to learn about their DEIA practices, particularly in the disability services sector.
- **Lack of Division-Wide Work Plan.** The team identified a lack of a clear division-wide DEIA work plan and leadership as a barrier to progress.
- **Data Collection Needs.** The team highlighted the need for robust and valid data collection systems to inform DEIA efforts.

The team's recommendations

- **Support Training Efforts.** Support the team's efforts to provide DEIA training to case managers, potentially leveraging new legislation that increases continuing education requirements.
- **Strengthen Collaboration with Data Team.** Strengthen collaboration with the Data and Quality Improvement team to support data analysis and interpretation.
- **Improve Advisory Committee Representation.** Address barriers to participation in advisory committees, such as providing stipends and reimbursement for transportation, to ensure diverse representation.

- **Expand Language Accessibility.** Expand language accessibility in DHS communications by automatically providing information in multiple languages.
- **Develop a DEIA Work Plan.** Develop a clear division-wide DEIA work plan with measurable goals and designated leadership.
- **Improve Data Collection Systems.** Invest in robust and valid data collection systems to capture relevant information for DEIA analysis.

Meeting Observation:

Managers, supervisors and directors

5 sessions · 48 findings · 36 recommendations

Managers

Key findings

- **Transitioning from Conceptualization to Action.** The team acknowledged a need to move from a conceptual understanding of DEIA to concrete action and external engagement. They emphasized the importance of data-driven decision-making and continuous quality improvement.
- **Data Accessibility and Analysis.** The team highlighted challenges in accessing and analyzing data, including navigating large datasets and identifying relevant starting points for analysis. They expressed a desire for clearer guidance and support in using data to inform DEIA efforts.
- **Integrating Equity into Daily Work.** The team recognized the tendency to treat equity as separate from other work, despite stating a desire to integrate it into everything. They emphasized the need for management to make explicit connections between equity and all aspects of DSD's work.
- **Culture of Perfection.** The team identified a culture of perfection within DSD as a barrier to creating a safe space for staff to take risks and learn from mistakes. They stressed the need for vulnerability and grace in modeling responses to mistakes and fostering a growth mindset.
- **Efficiency vs. Equity.** The team acknowledged the tension between efficiency and equity, noting that a focus on efficiency can sometimes overshadow opportunities to apply an equity lens. They emphasized the need to create space and prioritize equity, even if it means slowing down or adjusting timelines.

The team's recommendations

- **Provide Data and Analysis Support.** Provide managers with access to relevant data, training on data analysis and interpretation, and support in using data to inform DEIA efforts. Consider developing an internal performance playbook to guide data-driven decision-making.
- **Integrate Equity into All Aspects of Work.** Explicitly integrate equity into all aspects of DSD's work, ensuring that it is not treated as a separate or optional add-on.

- **Foster a Culture of Learning and Risk-Taking.** Foster a culture of learning and risk-taking, where staff feel safe to experiment, make mistakes, and learn from them. Model vulnerability and grace in responding to errors.
- **Prioritize Equity.** Prioritize equity in decision-making, even if it requires adjusting timelines or slowing down processes. Create space for staff to engage in equity work and provide the necessary resources and support.

Additional Equity Needs Meeting - Managers

Key findings

- **HR Collaboration.** The team is actively working with HR on hiring and recruitment strategies to promote diversity and inclusion.
- **Integrating Equity into Meetings.** The team is intentionally integrating equity into their meetings by including the equity consultant and a colleague, demonstrating a commitment to incorporating diverse perspectives and expertise.
- **Equity Toolkit Utilization.** The team is actively utilizing the equity toolkit to guide their DEIA efforts.
- **Classification Concerns.** The team raised concerns about positions being lowered in their classification levels, potentially creating equity issues and impacting compensation.
- **HR Collaboration Challenges.** The team acknowledged challenges in collaborating with HR, noting staff turnover and a lack of systemic change despite a willingness to engage.
- **Building an Inclusive Culture.** The team recognized the challenge of building an inclusive culture within DSD, given the predominantly white workforce, and emphasized the need to actively de-center dominant identities.
- **Multi-Pronged Approach.** The team expressed optimism about the potential impact of Dr. Pabon's multi-pronged approach to DEIA training and its potential to drive meaningful change.

The team's recommendations

- **Strengthen HR Collaboration.** Strengthen collaboration with HR to promote systemic change and ensure alignment with DEIA goals. Develop shared understanding and language to effectively advocate for DEIA within HR processes.
- **De-Center Dominant Identities.** Develop strategies to actively de-center dominant identities and create a welcoming and inclusive culture for staff from non-dominant backgrounds.
- **Continue DEIA Training and Support.** Continue investing in DEIA training and support for staff, building on the momentum generated by Dr. Pabon's work.
- **Clarify Authority and Data Needs.** Clarify the management team's authority to implement DEIA initiatives and identify data gaps that hinder their ability to address disparities.
- **Maintain Momentum and Passion.** Maintain the current momentum and passion for DEIA work across the division by providing ongoing support, resources, and opportunities for engagement.

Supervisors

Key findings

- **Focus on Accessibility.** The team views accessibility as a key component of DEIA and actively works to ensure diverse communities receive information in accessible formats.
- **Workload Challenges.** The team expressed concerns about the increasing volume of work and the challenge of prioritizing DEIA efforts amidst competing demands and tight deadlines.
- **Standardized Expectations.** The team identified the need for clear, standardized expectations for staff at different classification levels to facilitate feedback and accountability.
- **Competing Demands and Resources.** The team highlighted the tension between prioritizing DEIA and meeting other competing demands, particularly when faced with limited resources and a lack of dedicated funding for equity work.
- **Creating Space for Equity.** The team emphasized the need to create intentional space for applying equity and integrating it into daily work practices, recognizing that this may require slowing down or adjusting timelines.
- **Organic Integration of DEIA.** The team envisions a future where applying DEIA is an organic part of the division's culture, rather than a separate or add-on effort.
- **Relationship with DHS/ADSA Equity Work.** The team questioned the relationship between DHS/ADSA/DSD equity work and the potential challenges in integrating these efforts across different levels of the organization.
- **Top-Down Approach.** The team raised concerns about the top-down approach to DEIA, noting that senior leadership may not feel empowered to push back against directives from higher levels, potentially impacting the division's culture.
- **Tribal Consultation in Legislative Proposals.** The team highlighted the need for Tribal consultation in legislative proposals, emphasizing the importance of aligning actions with stated values and priorities.
- **Lack of Collective Legislative Plan.** The team identified a lack of a collective legislative plan for the division, hindering proactive planning and prioritization of DEIA efforts in the legislative process.
- **Need for Long-Range Planning.** The team expressed a desire for a longer-range plan and vision for the division, allowing for more intentional and strategic integration of DEIA into future goals and initiatives.
- **Communication Challenges.** The team noted challenges with communication and information sharing, particularly receiving critical information secondhand or thirdhand, which can be demotivating.
- **Siloed Work.** The team acknowledged the siloed nature of work within DSD and the need for improved collaboration and communication across teams.

The team's recommendations

- **Develop Standardized Expectations.** Develop clear, standardized expectations for staff at all classification levels, facilitating feedback, accountability, and consistent application of DEIA principles.
- **Create Intentional Space for Equity.** Create intentional space for applying equity by slowing down processes, adjusting timelines, and providing dedicated time and resources for DEIA learning and implementation.
- **Clarify Roles and Responsibilities.** Clarify roles and responsibilities for DEIA across different levels of the organization, ensuring clear communication and collaboration between DHS/ADSA/DSD equity efforts.
- **Empower Senior Leadership.** Empower senior leadership to advocate for DEIA and push back against top-down directives that may conflict with the division's values and priorities.
- **Require Tribal Consultation.** Require Tribal consultation in all legislative proposals, ensuring alignment between actions and stated commitments to equity and inclusion.
- **Develop a Collective Legislative Plan.** Develop a collective legislative plan for the division, incorporating DEIA considerations and allowing for proactive planning and prioritization.
- **Create a Long-Range Vision.** Create a long-range vision for the division, incorporating DEIA goals and providing a roadmap for future planning and decision-making.
- **Improve Communication and Collaboration.** Improve communication and collaboration across teams, breaking down silos and ensuring that critical information is shared effectively.

Additional Equity Needs Meeting - DSD Supervisors

Key findings

- **Performative Equity.** The team expressed concern that DEIA efforts within DSD have been largely performative, despite attempts to integrate equity since 2017.
- **Pushback on Legislative Proposals.** The team witnessed pushback from DSD leadership on legislative proposals during the legislative session, highlighting the need for timely and assertive advocacy for DEIA priorities.
- **Time Constraints.** The team acknowledged the challenge of finding time to integrate DEIA into their work, given the numerous tools and expectations placed upon them, coupled with limited time in a day.
- **Prioritization of Equity.** The team questioned whether equity is truly a top priority within DSD and suggested that other priorities may need to be slowed down or paused to create space for meaningful DEIA implementation.
- **Pressure to Meet Timelines.** The team described feeling pressure to meet timelines and get things done, which can make it difficult to prioritize equity and create space for learning and application of DEIA principles.
- **Political Influence.** The team expressed concern about political influence hindering DEIA efforts, noting that equity can be sidelined when political considerations take precedence.

- **Performative Equity Assessments.** The team criticized the practice of conducting equity assessments after decisions have been made, describing it as a "check the box" exercise rather than a genuine effort to integrate equity into decision-making processes.
- **Lack of Cumulative Decision-Making.** The team observed a lack of cumulative decision-making, with a tendency to focus on immediate crises rather than long-term planning and incorporating lessons learned.
- **Sense of Urgency.** The team acknowledged the "constant go-go-go" culture within DSD and the challenge of balancing speed with achieving desired outcomes, including equity.
- **Lack of Empowerment.** The team described feeling a lack of empowerment to push back against the pressure to "manage everything" and avoid saying "no," highlighting a cultural barrier to prioritizing equity.
- **Reactive Approach.** The team identified a reactive approach to equity, with a tendency to address issues after they arise rather than proactively integrating equity into planning and implementation processes.
- **Lack of Leadership Empowerment.** The team perceived that people in leadership positions are not empowered to "stop, pause, and figure out how to collaborate," hindering effective integration of DEIA.

The team's recommendations

- **Improve Legislative Proposal Process.** Improve the legislative proposal process to ensure that equity is integrated from the beginning, rather than being an afterthought. Provide staff with the knowledge and resources to conduct meaningful equity analyses and engage with relevant communities.
- **Incorporate Implementation Perspectives.** Incorporate the perspectives of staff who implement policies into the policy development phase to ensure that policies are feasible, equitable, and aligned with the needs of the people they serve.
- **Slow Down and Prioritize Equity.** Create a culture that values slowing down and prioritizing equity, even if it means adjusting timelines or re-evaluating priorities. Communicate clearly that equity is a top priority and provide staff with the support and resources to integrate it into their work.

Directors

Key findings

- **Focus on Recruitment.** The directors emphasized the importance of recruiting diverse staff and ensuring that managers and supervisors are committed to hiring practices that promote equity and inclusion.
- **Re-Opening Positions for Diversity.** The directors advocated for re-opening positions if a diverse pool of applicants is not received, even if there is an urgent need to fill the position, recognizing the importance of prioritizing diversity in hiring.

- **Addressing Advantages and Biases.** The directors acknowledged the advantages that white, able-bodied applicants may have and encouraged mindfulness of implicit biases in evaluating qualifications and making hiring decisions.
- **Utilizing the Disability ERG.** The directors noted the increased use of the Disability ERG for job postings, demonstrating a commitment to reaching a diverse pool of candidates.
- **Expanding the VIP.** The directors encouraged expanding the use of the Virtual Insight Panel (VIP) but emphasized the need to limit the representation of parents and guardians to ensure the voices of people with disabilities are centered.
- **Learning from EIDBI.** The directors highlighted the EIDBI team's successful community engagement efforts as a potential model for other teams to learn from and adapt.
- **ADSA Alignment and Independent Action.** The directors acknowledged the need to align DEIA efforts with ADSA but emphasized that DSD cannot wait for ADSA to take the lead. They encouraged DSD to act independently and proactively in advancing equity and inclusion.
- **Challenges with References and Mindsets.** The directors discussed challenges with references sometimes influencing hiring decisions and the need to shift mindsets to center the expertise of people with lived experience.
- **Reaching People with Lived Experience.** The directors emphasized the importance of reaching people with lived experience, particularly those receiving services, and ensuring their voices are heard and included in decision-making processes.
- **Accountability to Partners.** The directors stressed the need for accountability to community partners, ensuring that engagement leads to action and tangible results.
- **Utilizing the Equity Analysis Tool.** The directors highlighted the importance of utilizing the equity analysis tool and encouraged Deqa to provide training and support for staff to use the tool effectively.

The team's recommendations

- **Expand and Diversify the VIP.** Expand and diversify the VIP, ensuring that the representation of parents and guardians is limited to center the voices of people with disabilities.
- **Share EIDBI Best Practices.** Share and promote the EIDBI team's successful community engagement strategies as a model for other teams to learn from and adapt.
- **Promote Independent Action.** Encourage DSD to act independently and proactively in advancing DEIA, even while aligning efforts with ADSA.
- **Center Lived Experience.** Develop strategies to center the lived experience of people with disabilities in all aspects of DSD's work, including policy development and community engagement.
- **Ensure Accountability to Partners.** Ensure accountability to community partners by following through on commitments and taking action based on feedback and engagement.
- **Promote Equity Analysis Tool Utilization.** Promote the utilization of the equity analysis tool and provide staff with training and support to use it effectively.

- **Dedicated Resources for DEIA.** Allocate dedicated time, funding, and staff resources to support DEIA implementation across all teams and initiatives.
- **Develop Clear DEIA Processes and Guidelines.** Create clear, accessible processes and guidelines for key DEIA activities, including document translation, accessibility compliance, and community engagement.
- **Enhance Communication and Collaboration.** Foster a culture of communication and collaboration across teams and with external partners, breaking down silos and promoting information sharing.
- **Improve Data Collection and Analysis.** Improve data collection processes to gather comprehensive demographic data and provide staff with training and support for data analysis and interpretation.
- **Strengthen Leadership Commitment and Accountability.** Establish clear, measurable DEIA goals, communicate them effectively, and implement accountability mechanisms to ensure progress.
- **Prioritize Community Engagement.** Develop a comprehensive community engagement plan that centers the voices of people with disabilities, particularly those from marginalized communities.
- **Invest in Training and Development.** Provide ongoing training and development opportunities for all staff on DEIA topics, including cultural competency, accessibility, and implicit bias.
- **Ensure Equitable Hiring Practices.** Review and revise hiring practices to ensure equity and inclusion throughout the recruitment and selection process.
- **Prioritize Accessibility.** Ensure all internal and external communications and resources are accessible to people with a variety of disabilities.
- **Embed DEIA in Legislative Advocacy.** Embed DEIA considerations into the legislative process, including conducting equity analyses and engaging with communities before proposing legislation.

Staff unable to attend their team session

1 session · 11 findings · 8 recommendations

Equity Needs: Team Absentees

Key findings

- **Need for Ongoing DEIA Conversations.** A participant highlighted the need for ongoing conversations and support from trusted individuals to effectively apply DEIA principles to her work. The participant emphasized the value of coaching and mentoring in this process.
- **Data Ownership and Organizational Capacity.** A participant noted that organizations, rather than DHS, often own and maintain the data collected through training programs. The

participant stressed the importance of building organizational capacity for DEIA implementation.

- **Varied Understanding of DEIA.** A participant pointed out the varying levels of understanding and commitment to DEIA across the division and raised concerns about potential pushback from individuals with privileged identities.
- **Accountability and Space for DEIA.** A participant emphasized the need for accountability and creating space for staff to engage in DEIA work, suggesting strategies like "No Meeting Fridays" to allow for learning and application of DEIA principles.
- **Prioritizing DEIA.** A participant highlighted the challenge of prioritizing DEIA amidst competing demands and stressed the need for clear expectations and modeling from supervisors and leadership.
- **Addressing Loneliness and Relationship Needs.** A participant raised important questions about how DSD addresses the relationship and sexual needs of people with disabilities, highlighting the issue of loneliness and the need for more inclusive approaches.
- **Tribal Nations Relationships.** A participant emphasized the need for greater resources and support for building and maintaining relationships with Tribal Nations.
- **Accessibility of Information Sharing.** A participant raised concerns about the accessibility of information sharing platforms, such as Teams vs. SharePoint, and the need to prioritize accessibility to ensure inclusivity.
- **Religious Inclusivity.** A participant highlighted the need for flexibility and accommodation for non-Christian holidays, moving away from a Christian-centric workplace culture.
- **Equity Analysis in Legislative Proposals.** A participant advocated for requiring objective equity analysis and community support for all legislative proposals before they move forward.
- **Agility and Adaptability.** A participant stressed the need for agility and adaptability in responding to changing needs and priorities, even if it means shifting direction on long-standing projects or initiatives.

The team's recommendations

- **Create Space for DEIA Learning.** Create dedicated time and space for staff to engage in DEIA learning and application, potentially through strategies like "No Meeting Fridays."
- **Clarify Expectations for Staff Engagement.** Clarify expectations for staff engagement in DEIA, including the role of supervisors and leadership in modeling and supporting these efforts.
- **Address Relationship and Sexuality Needs.** Explore ways to address the relationship and sexuality needs of people with disabilities, promoting inclusivity and combating loneliness.
- **Increase Support for Tribal Nations.** Increase resources and support for building and maintaining strong relationships with Tribal Nations.
- **Prioritize Accessibility.** Prioritize accessibility in all aspects of DSD's work, including information sharing platforms and communication practices.

- **Promote Religious Inclusivity.** Promote religious inclusivity by providing flexibility and accommodation for non-Christian holidays and observances.
- **Require Equity Analysis for Legislation.** Require objective equity analysis and community support for all legislative proposals before they are advanced.
- **Foster Agility and Adaptability.** Foster a culture of agility and adaptability within DSD, allowing for shifts in direction and priorities to effectively respond to changing needs.

Closing note

Staff in eleven of these sessions described feedback loops that do not close — information given, with nothing returned. Publishing this record back to the Division, alongside the analysis built from it, is the least expensive and most credible answer to that finding.

What the Division Said

The axial analysis of those findings: ten categories, the central finding, and seven consultant recommendations.

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1. Purpose and standing

This document sets out what staff across the Disability Services Division said about equity in their own work, and what a formal qualitative analysis of those statements shows. It exists for one reason: the One DSD People, Access and Culture Program should be able to demonstrate, not assert, that it was built from the Division's own account of itself.

It is an analysis of what was said. It does not measure any individual, it does not evaluate any team's performance, and it does not establish policy. Where it recommends, it recommends as a consultant to the Division.

2. The evidence base

Between January and July 2023 the consultant conducted **71 interviews** independently with staff and leaders across the Division. From April 2023 the work continued in collaboration with Sarah Shepherd, Project Manager for the Disability Services Division, and ran in that form until December 2023. Together this produced a general equity assessment and a program of division-wide listening sessions; the 71 interviews preceding them were conducted by the consultant alone. The collaboration continued on planning matters until the project manager's departure from the agency at the end of 2024.

The record analyzed here covers 23 distinct sessions, producing 172 findings and 131 recommendations. Participation reached the whole vertical of the Division:

- **Seventeen program teams** — including waiver policy compliance, EIDBI, service agreement and screening support, research and evaluation, fiscal policy, program integrity, the Disability Hub and Response System, training and technical consultation, Moving Home Minnesota, assessment and support planning, regional resource specialists, division supports, home care and self-directed services, HCBS compliance coordination, support planning and informed

choice, community capacity and positive supports, and interagency leads and strategic communications.

- **Managers, supervisors and directors** in their own sessions, with additional sessions held for managers and supervisors.
- **A session for those who could not attend** their own team's meeting, so that absence did not mean exclusion.

Three one-to-one community engagement meetings held in the same period are set aside from this analysis. They involved named external partners rather than anonymous staff participants, and belong to the community engagement record.

De-identification. Findings are attributed to teams, never to individuals. That was the condition under which people spoke and it is preserved here. Sarah Shepherd is named as facilitator and analyst, which is credit for professional work rather than identification of a participant.

3. Method

The analysis follows standard qualitative procedure. Open coding assigned preliminary labels to each of the 172 findings. Axial coding then connected those labels into categories and established the relationships between them, using the coding paradigm of phenomenon, causal conditions, context, intervening conditions, action and interaction strategies, and consequences.

The purpose of axial coding is to move beyond description. A list of complaints tells you what people said; an axial analysis tells you how the parts relate — what produces the condition, what makes it better or worse, what people do about it, and what follows. That is what a program has to be designed against.

4. Open coding: ten categories

The 172 findings resolved into ten categories. The prevalence column states how many of the 23 sessions raised the category independently.

Category	Sessions	What staff described
Equity carried without operational means	10 of 23	Staff want equity in their daily work and lack the direction, shared definition and usable tools to put it there. The Equity Analysis Toolkit is described as built for policy development and hard to apply elsewhere.
Community trust, built or spent	12 of 23	A recognized disconnect between the Division and the communities it serves; distrust that must be addressed before engagement works; engagement that is not sustained; difficulty reaching people with lived experience.
Access and language as everyday work	12 of 23	Translation backlogs, inconsistency between translators, inaccessible public websites, accessibility tools too costly or complex to use widely,

Category	Sessions	What staff described
		and a view that accessibility belongs in everyone's job rather than a specialist's.
Silos and broken feedback loops	11 of 23	External communications issued without internal consultation; no consistent way to carry community feedback across the Division; no division-wide work plan; reliance on written channels only.
Policy, bureaucracy and politics as constraint	11 of 23	Barriers described as internal to DHS more often than legislative; approval delays; funding and reimbursement inflexibility; contractors not held to accessibility terms; counties and lead agencies outside direct control.
Who gets in, who advances, who is paid	10 of 23	A predominantly white workforce serving communities that are not; a predominantly BIPOC home care workforce unmatched by Division staffing; gatekeeping in hiring; wage and classification disparities; opaque HR data.
Time and workload crowd it out	7 of 23	Competing demands, tight deadlines and a stated tension between efficiency and equity, in which efficiency wins by default unless space is made deliberately.
Data that cannot be reached	7 of 23	Restricted data sets, no access to human resources statistics, no training in qualitative analysis, research agendas driven reactively by others' needs.
Fear that the work is performative	5 of 23	Equity assessments conducted after decisions are made, described as a check-the-box exercise; a culture of perfection that discourages risk; a sense that effort since 2017 has been largely performative.
Psychological safety and belonging	5 of 23	Bias and distrust experienced from other divisions; morale and discouragement; loneliness and relationship needs of people served; a Christian-centric holiday calendar; and, in several teams, genuine psychological safety and strong culture.

5. Axial analysis

5.1 The central phenomenon

Equity is carried as individual effort without an operational system.

This is the condition every other finding organizes around, and it is important to state what it is not. It is not an absence of commitment. Commitment appears at every level of the Division, unprompted, including from teams under considerable pressure. What staff described is people doing equity work on their own initiative, in the margins of their workload, without shared tools, shared language, reachable data or protected time — and doubting that it changes anything.

“The team expressed a willingness to engage in this work but needs guidance and support from leadership on how to do so effectively.” — A program team

“Team members are individually incorporating equity into their work, particularly by focusing on accessibility and language accessibility.” — A program team

That is a capability problem, not a motivation problem. It has a remedy, and the remedy is operational.

5.2 Causal conditions

Four conditions produce the phenomenon.

1. **A mandate that arrives as expectation without capability.** The One Minnesota Plan, the DHS Equity Policy, the Olmstead Plan and the Administration's equity implementation plan all require equity work. Ten of twenty-three sessions described wanting to meet that requirement in daily work and not knowing how.
2. **Genuine commitment across the Division.** This is a causal condition rather than a mitigating one: because people want to act, the absence of means produces frustration and moral fatigue rather than indifference.
3. **Work organized for throughput.** Managers named the tension directly — a focus on efficiency overshadows the opportunity to apply an equity lens. Without deliberate space, efficiency wins by default.
4. **Tools built for another purpose.** The Equity Analysis Toolkit is described as geared toward policy development and difficult to apply to communications and other work, so teams outside policy have a requirement without an instrument.

5.3 Context

The conditions operate in a specific setting, and the setting explains why generic approaches do not transfer.

- A division administering complex, federally regulated programs — waivers, personal care assistance, home and community-based services, early intensive developmental and behavioral intervention — where requirements and funding rules constrain what can change locally.
- Delivery distributed across lead agencies, counties and contracted providers, so that the Division guides work it does not directly control.
- A predominantly white workforce serving communities that are substantially not, and a direct support and home care workforce that is predominantly BIPOC without matching representation inside the Division.
- A legislative and political environment that shapes what can be proposed and when.
- A history of attempts: staff date efforts to integrate equity to 2017, which is why credibility, not novelty, is the scarce resource.

5.4 Intervening conditions

These determine whether the same commitment produces change or exhaustion.

Condition	How it operates
Protected time	The single most frequently named constraint. Where no space is made, equity work is displaced by deadlines rather than rejected.
Empowerment, not direction	Supervisors described a top-down approach in which even senior leaders may not feel able to push back. Direction without authority produces compliance, not practice.
Psychological safety	Present in several teams and named as a supervisor's priority; absent where a culture of perfection discourages risk and learning from error.
Working feedback loops	Where community feedback and internal consultation do not travel, teams repeat each other's work and communities are asked the same questions twice.
Reachable data	Without disaggregated data, teams cannot see disparity, and cannot show whether anything they changed worked.
Fit of the tools	A tool that does not fit the work is not used, however strong the requirement behind it.
Prior community trust	Engagement is not starting from zero. Distrust already exists in places and is either repaired or deepened by each contact.

5.5 Action and interaction strategies

What staff are already doing, unprompted, is the clearest statement of what they need supported.

- Incorporating equity individually, most often through accessibility and language, without a shared standard.
- Asking for clear expectations and visible modeling from supervisors.
- Building equity into team meetings deliberately, including bringing the equity consultant into them.
- Applying the Equity Analysis Toolkit where it fits, and improvising where it does not.
- Seeking partnership with the Data and Quality Improvement team to obtain analysis they cannot perform alone.
- Pressing for equity analysis earlier in legislative proposals rather than after.
- Cross-training and sharing knowledge within teams explicitly in order to reduce bias.
- Building and expanding community participation, including through the Voice of the Individual Project.

5.6 Consequences

Two outcomes follow, and both are visible in the record.

Where there is no system: equity assessments are conducted after decisions are made and experienced as a check-the-box exercise; the work becomes reactive to immediate crises; results vary by who happens to be on a team, so translation quality and accessibility differ across the same Division; and staff report discouragement, pressure and a sense that effort since 2017 has been largely performative. The cost is credibility, and credibility once spent is expensive to recover.

Where conditions are right: teams reported genuine psychological safety, a culture of knowledge-sharing and cross-training adopted specifically to minimize bias, and accessibility expertise embedded in everyday practice. This matters more than any single finding in this analysis. The conditions that make equity work possible are not hypothetical for this Division — they already exist inside it, in named teams, under the same constraints as everyone else. The task is not invention. It is extension.

6. How the categories relate

The relationships form a cycle rather than a list. Causal conditions — a real mandate, real commitment, throughput pressure and ill-fitting tools — produce equity carried as individual effort. That effort meets a context of regulated complexity, distributed delivery and a workforce that does not mirror the communities served.

Intervening conditions then decide the outcome. Where time is protected, authority is real, safety exists, feedback travels, data is reachable and tools fit, individual effort becomes shared practice. Where those are missing, the same effort produces performative assessment and fatigue.

The consequences feed back. Performative work erodes the credibility that makes the next attempt possible, which strengthens the original condition. Conversely, each visible instance of equity work that changed something — and teams described these — rebuilds the conditions for the next one. This is why an operational system matters more than any single initiative: it is what converts individual effort into the kind of result that makes further effort credible.

7. What the Division asked for, and what the Program provides

The Program was designed against this analysis. The table states each category, what staff asked for, what the Program now offers, and its honest status. The Program is built and has not launched: “built” means complete and ready for staff when the Division opens it in January 2027, not in use today.

Category	What staff asked for	What the Program provides	Status
		Equity Analysis Toolkit companion and guided walkthrough that records an	Built

Category	What staff asked for	What the Program provides	Status
Equity carried without operational means	Direction, a shared definition, and tools that work outside policy development	analysis; Operationalizing equity; practice paths; job aids attached to courses	
Community trust, built or spent	Understanding of communities before engaging them; sustained rather than episodic contact	Minnesota Communities briefs; community engagement and connections; the community engagement planner	Built
Access and language as everyday work	Accessibility as everyone's responsibility, with plain language and usable checks	Access checks; plain language in human services; language access planning; working with an interpreter; accessible-document practice	Built
Silos and broken feedback loops	One place to look, and a way for feedback to come back	One DSD Team work-item cycle with a named decision owner and a return; Amplify; ASK; the Program as a single source	Built
Policy, bureaucracy and politics as constraint	Equity considered in legislative proposals and contracting, not after	Legislative dimension of the work	Not yet built
Who gets in, who advances, who is paid	Fair hiring, visible advancement, honest workforce data	Inclusive hiring practice; leadership development across the employee life cycle; mentoring, sponsorship and accessible pathways	Built
Time and workload crowd it out	Resources usable inside the work, not added on top	Short job aids; resources downloadable in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and PDF; ASK for a direct answer with its sources and limits	Built
Data that cannot be reached	Baseline data, disaggregated, that teams can actually see	Measurement and evaluation plan; baseline collection; quarterly disaggregated reporting	Not yet built
Fear that the work is performative	Analysis before the decision, and proof that participation is not assessment	Equity Pause and analysis before decisions; voluntary participation; evaluation that examines program support and never an individual	Partly built
Psychological safety and belonging	Skills for difficult conversation, and a culture that makes room	Intercultural practice curriculum; conflict, repair and accountability; emotional intelligence; employee resource groups; Amplify well-being	Built

Two things this analysis asks for that the Program does not yet answer

Data and accountability measures. Seven sessions described data they cannot reach. The Program offers no baseline, no disaggregated reporting and no way for a team to see disparity in its own area. This is the largest single gap between what the Division asked for and what exists.

The legislative dimension. Eleven sessions named policy, bureaucratic and legislative constraint, and several asked specifically for equity analysis to enter legislative proposals before positions are set. The Program has no legislative content.

Both are named in the consultant's operational workplan as work to be undertaken, and both are carried through to their planned outcome in the program logic model that accompanies this analysis. They are stated here because an analysis that claimed the Program answered everything would not deserve to be believed.

8. Consultant's recommendations

1. **Conduct a general division-wide equity assessment once every two years.** The assessment analyzed here concluded in 2024; on a two-year cycle the next was due in 2026 and the findings this Program rests on are now three years old. Resuming the cycle gives the Division a repeated, comparable read on its own culture and gives the Program its own feedback loop: the second assessment measures whether the tools built from the first changed what staff actually experience.
2. **Keep the biennial assessment distinct from the annual climate survey.** A survey counts; this instrument listens. Findings such as performative equity, a culture of perfection, loneliness and moral fatigue do not appear on a scale. Both are needed and neither substitutes for the other.
3. **Build the data and accountability capability.** Establish the baseline, disaggregate it, and give teams sight of their own area. Until this exists the Division cannot show whether any equity effort worked.
4. **Move equity analysis before the decision.** The most damaging single finding in this record is that assessments are performed after decisions are made. No amount of tooling repairs that; it is a sequencing rule that leadership sets.
5. **Protect time explicitly.** Every other recommendation depends on it. Equity work is not declined in this Division; it is displaced.
6. **Return these findings to the staff who gave them.** Staff named broken feedback loops in eleven of twenty-three sessions. Publishing this analysis back to the Division is the least expensive and most credible demonstration that speaking up produced something.
7. **Extend what already works.** Identify the teams that reported psychological safety, cross-training and embedded accessibility, and use their practice as the Division's model rather than importing one.

9. Method note and limits

- This analysis covers what was said in 23 sessions between 2023 and 2024. It is a record of perception and experience, which is the appropriate evidence for questions of culture, and it is not a measurement of conditions.
- Findings are attributed to teams. Individual participants are not identified anywhere in this document.
- Prevalence counts state how many sessions raised a category independently. They indicate breadth, not magnitude, and a category raised in five sessions is not thereby less serious than one raised in twelve.
- The three one-to-one community engagement meetings from the same period are excluded, as described in section 2.
- Anything concerning Native American individuals, communities or Tribal Nations defers to the Office of Indian Affairs and the Department offices that handle Tribal relations and consultation. Findings in this record that touch Tribal relationships are reported as stated and are not developed further here.
- The underlying session record requires editorial cleaning before circulation. It contains duplicated passages and named individuals in its present form.

Program Logic Model

The chain from what was invested, to what was built, to what changes because it exists.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
IN COLLABORATION WITH	Sarah Shepherd, Project Manager, Disability Services Division
PREPARED FOR	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager — Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
DATE	September 18, 2026
STATUS	Draft for review

1. What this document is

A logic model is a single page that reads left to right: what was invested, what was done with it, what exists as a result, what changes because it exists, and what that means over years. It is the plainest way to show that the Program is not a collection of separate initiatives. It is one chain, running from the 2023 interviews to the outcomes the Division asked for, and every link in it is accounted for in the evidence record, the analysis, the operational workplan or this document.

It exists to answer one question directly: this work produces, and over what time. The table below is the chain in outline. The sections that follow it give each stage in full.

2. The chain, in outline

Stage	What it means	In this Program
Inputs	What was invested to get here	71 interviews · the Shepherd collaboration · 23 sessions, 172 findings · the governing plans · one consultant
Activities	What was done with it	Coding and analysis · institutional and landscape research · curriculum and requirements design · the Program build
Outputs	What exists because of it	The built Program · the evidence record · the analysis · the Framework · this document set
Outcomes	What changes for staff and the Division	Shared tools reach every level · feedback loops close · governance seated · a data baseline exists
Impact	What it means over years	Equity operational, not individual · hiring, advancement and trust measurably improved · the governing plans met in practice

3. Inputs — what was invested

- 71 interviews conducted independently across the Disability Services Division, January to July 2023.
- **A project management collaboration with Sarah Shepherd**, Project Manager for the Disability Services Division, April 2023 until her departure from the agency at the end of 2024, which carried the division-wide equity assessment — concluded December 2023 — and the institutional examination.
- 23 division-wide listening sessions, producing 172 findings and 131 recommendations, attributed to teams and de-identified.
- Enterprise relationships and equity expertise built across the Department since 2016.
- The governing commitments the Program has to serve: the One Minnesota Plan, the Olmstead Plan, the DHS Equity Policy and its Equity Analysis Toolkit, the Aging and Disability Services Administration's equity implementation plan, and the Disability Services Division's own operational non-negotiables.
- The DSD DEIA Integration Framework, version 1.0, completed January 2026: a three-year implementation manual with ten sequential steps, gate checks and RACI assignments.
- One equity and inclusion operations consultant, working largely alone, with project management support through the end of 2024; from January 2025 the build was carried by the consultant alone.

4. Activities — what was done with it

- Open coding assigned labels to each of the 172 findings; axial coding connected them into categories and relationships.
- A critical examination of the Office of Employee Culture, undertaken to understand how an established administration shapes its equity work, not as a candidate or a model to copy; alongside it, an examination of the DHS Equity Policy and its toolkit, and of the equity work of every Minnesota state agency and county.
- Synthesis of that research into an evidence- and practitioner-based approach, and the decision that the answer is an operational program rather than a training calendar or a committee.
- Design of the program requirements (version 2.0), a cross-cultural curriculum, and the 38-module Intercultural Practice and Equity curriculum.
- Build of the Program itself: the learning library, courses, ASK, practice paths, job aids, Minnesota Communities briefs, the One DSD Team, Amplify Equity, leadership development, and the ability to take away every non-course resource as a Word, Excel, PowerPoint or PDF file.
- Two activities added on your direction: a short, voluntary suggestion prompt at the end of every course and practice path, and aggregate, program-level usage instrumentation — neither one tied to an individual, both routed into the same monthly content review.

- Ongoing content stewardship: verifying outside sources, publishing a monthly release note, and logging what staff say is missing.

5. Outputs — what exists because of it

- The Program: a complete, built application, with functional completion reached September 8, 2026, and the download capability completed September 18, 2026.
- The evidence record: 23 sessions documented in full, de-identified, attributed to teams.
- The analysis, “What the Division Said”: the coding, the central finding, and seven consultant recommendations.
- The DSD DEIA Integration Framework, version 1.0.
- This document set: the memorandum, the operational workplan, the reporting process, and this logic model.
- **Not yet produced, and named honestly as ahead:** a baseline climate survey and disaggregated workforce data; the Executive Council and Division DEIA Council charters; a legislative brief series. Each has an owner and a target date in the operational workplan.

6. Outcomes — what changes for staff and the Division

Short-term, in the first two quarters after launch

- Staff at every level can find, use and share equity resources without the consultant as the sole conduit.
- Recurring ASK questions and module suggestions are converted into content, closing a feedback loop eleven of twenty-three sessions described as broken.
- The One DSD Team runs its first accepted work item, with a named decision owner and a documented return.
- The Executive Council and the Division DEIA Council are chartered and seated.

Medium-term, through 2027 and into 2028

- A baseline climate survey and disaggregated data exist; a quarterly disparities report and a correction-plan protocol are in operation.
- The general division-wide equity assessment resumes on its two-year cycle, giving the Division its first comparable read against the 2023–2024 baseline.
- Equity analysis moves before the decision, in legislative proposals and contracting, rather than after.
- Community engagement becomes sustained rather than episodic, documented through the Minnesota Communities briefs and the engagement planner in use on real projects.

7. Impact — what it means over years

This is the central finding answered: equity carried as an operational capability of the Division, not as individual effort that depends on who happens to be in the room. Read against the 2023–2024 baseline at each future assessment — 2027 alongside launch, then 2029 and 2031 — the measure of impact is whether hiring, advancement, pay and community trust move, and whether the practice several DSD teams already show today becomes the Division's practice rather than the exception.

8. Where the work stands

The stages above are not equal in size or duration, and the work does not divide evenly among them. The table below states where each stands.

Stage	Status	What that means
Inputs	Complete	The evidence, the collaboration, the governing mandate and the Framework are all in hand.
Activities	Build activities complete; launch activities not started	Coding, research, curriculum and program build are done. Governance, data collection, working groups and communications begin at launch.
Outputs	Program, evidence and analysis built; governance, baseline and legislative outputs ahead	What can be produced before a decision to launch has been produced.
Outcomes	Not yet realized	Nothing opens to staff, and no outcome can occur, until the Division opens the Program.
Impact	Ahead, by design	Measured over years against the 2023–2024 baseline, at the 2027, 2029 and 2031 assessments.

The inputs, the work done with them, and what that work produced are largely in place — the first three links in the chain. Outcomes and impact, which is where most of the value lies, cannot begin until the Division opens the Program to staff. The foundation is well advanced; the greater share of the work, and the greater share of the benefit, is still ahead.

9. Assumptions this model depends on

- Leigh Ann Ahmad and Heidi Hamilton share their thoughts by December 1, 2026, and the Division opens the Program division-wide in January 2027.
- Participation in surveys, courses and the suggestion prompts stays voluntary; nothing here evaluates a person.

- Leigh Ann Ahmad and Heidi Hamilton continue to support the work, and the Executive Council is chartered as planned.
- HR and Data and Analytics make time available to build the baseline described in Workstream 4.

10. External factors outside this plan's control

- The November 2026 election and the political environment it sets for a January 2027 launch.
- State budget and legislative session decisions, which affect funding and the legislative dimension of the work.
- Turnover among staff, managers or leadership sponsors.
- DHS enterprise equity priorities, which the Program is built to serve rather than replace, and which could shift.

11. Where each piece lives

- **Evidence record** — the 23 sessions in full, the source for every Input above.
- **What the Division Said** — the analysis and the central finding this whole chain answers.
- **Operational workplan** — the nine workstreams that carry each Activity and Output through to its Outcome, with owners and dates.
- **Reporting process** — how progress against this model is tracked and reported from October 2026 forward.

Operational Workplan

October 2026 through June 2027: what I am working on, what it should produce, and where I will need help.

TO Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager, Disability Services Division

CC Heidi Hamilton, Division Director, Disability Services Division

FROM Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant

DATE September 18, 2026

STATUS Draft for review

Following our conversation, this is the operational workplan you asked for. It is built to be used, not filed. Each workstream sets out what I am doing day to day, the outcome it is meant to produce, the timeline I am working to, the barriers I am meeting, and the specific support that would move it — including where the managers or Heidi Hamilton as Director would need to be brought in. I will bring an updated copy to each check-in with the status column current.

The Program is built and has not launched: no member of staff is using it yet. The plan is to open it throughout the Division beginning in January 2027, after the November election, which is the common understanding among equity professionals across DHS, though I cannot speak for everyone. Every timeline below is set to that launch, and to your thoughts on this plan by December 1, 2026.

Where the work stands. The work is well underway and moving toward the point where the Program is ready to open. Discovery, the research behind it, and the design and build of the Program are largely done, which is Workstream 1 below. What remains — opening it to the Division, governance, the data baseline, the working groups and communications, and the legislative dimension — is Workstreams 2 through 10, and is the greater share of what is still ahead.

What informs this plan

The priorities of the broader modular DSD equity workplan run through it. Five sources set those priorities:

- **The Division's own account of itself.** The analysis “What the Division Said” codes 172 findings from 23 division-wide sessions held in 2023 and 2024. Its central finding — that equity is carried as individual effort without an operational system — is what this workplan exists to answer. Each workstream below names the analysis categories it addresses.
- **The DSD DEIA Integration Framework** (January 2026): ten sequential steps over three years. Year One, 2026, is Foundation — governance, a data baseline, communications. Year Two, 2027, is Implementation. Gate checks decide when a step may proceed.

- **The ADSA Equity and Inclusion Implementation Plan:** six goals — eliminate disparities; community engagement; hiring and retention; learning and development; contracts and procurement; communication and accessibility.
- **The DSD Equity and Inclusion Operational Plan:** four non-negotiables — mandatory equity analysis before major changes; documented community engagement; accessibility and plain language; disaggregated data — with a quarterly correction loop.
- **The Program's launch standard:** a division-wide opening from January 2027, a readiness checklist, and an evaluation that examines program support and practice, never employee beliefs or individual performance.

Behind all five stand the commitments in the One Minnesota Plan, the Olmstead Plan and the DHS Equity Policy. Status values: Built · In progress · Proposed · Needs decision. “Built” means complete in the Program and ready for staff at launch, not in use today.

At a glance

Workstream	Status	Target	First support needed
1. Keep the Program current, accurate and ready for launch	Built	Continuous; first quarterly summary January 2027	A decision on whether the Program serves as the DSD system of record for equity tools and decision logs, alongside or instead of a dedicated SharePoint site.
2. Launch the Program throughout the Division from January 2027	In progress · decisions needed	Decision to open, December 2026; opening January 2027	Each manager: thirty minutes to confirm their unit's map.
3. Governance and leadership accountability	Needs decision	Councils seated Q1 2027	Heidi Hamilton, as Director: to charter and chair the Executive Council.
4. Assessment, data baseline and accountability measures	Proposed · largest gap	Survey Q1 2027; analysis Q2 2027; next assessment 2027	You: to broker data access with HR and Data and Analytics.
5. Vision, working-group charters and communications	Proposed	Charters Q1 2027; plan Q2 2027	You and Heidi Hamilton: approval of the message platform and the plan.
6. Learning, leadership competencies and	Built · competencies proposed	Framework draft Q4 2026; first cohort Q2 2027	Heidi Hamilton and ADSA: the IDI administration decision and budget.

Workstream	Status	Target	First support needed
intercultural development			
7. Equity analysis in everyday decisions	In progress	Core workflows Q4 2026 to Q1 2027	Heidi Hamilton: to make equity analysis before the decision a standing requirement.
8. Community engagement and service delivery	Proposed for 2027	First engagements Q2 2027	Managers: to identify their projects that affect communities.
9. The legislative dimension	Scope to agree · gap	Scope Q4 2026; briefs Q1 to Q2 2027	You: to agree the scope.
10. One DSD Team and Amplify Equity	Planned start January 2027	First meeting January 2027	Managers: to permit and protect participation.

Workstreams

1. Keep the Program current, accurate and ready for launch

Status: Built

Aligned to: ADSA Goals 4 and 6 · DSD non-negotiable 3 (accessibility and plain language) · Framework Step Three · Analysis categories 1, 5 and 6

What I am doing now

- Maintain the Program as the Division's working resource: publish and review content in place, keep the staff voice standard on every page, and re-verify the register of outside sources before each release.
- Keep every resource downloadable as Word, Excel, PowerPoint or PDF (completed September 18) and every eLearning course on the Program.
- Add a short, voluntary suggestion prompt to the end of every course and practice path — what would have made this more useful, what is missing — answered or skipped in one click, never scored and never attributed to a person. It routes straight into the content log below, so the person who does not ask ASK a question is heard too.
- Answer what ASK cannot, log gaps as content work, and turn recurring questions and module suggestions into resources.
- Instrument the Program itself, in aggregate only: course and practice-path completion, downloads by resource and format, the questions most often put to ASK, and where in a lesson

people most often stop. Nothing here is tied to a person; the count is the unit, not the individual.

- Send a short release note each month: what changed, what was withdrawn, what is waiting.

Planned outcomes

- The Program is the Division's single, current source for equity resources: the system of record the DSD operational plan calls for, or its companion if a SharePoint site is chosen.
- No broken or unverified outside source at any release.
- A quarterly summary of program use, drawn from the module suggestion prompts and the usage counts above, about program support only and never about individuals (first: January 2027).

Timeline

Continuous. Monthly release note; quarterly summary.

Challenges and barriers

- One person carries publication, verification and support; the tooling multiplies reach but does not replace review time.
- Anything concerning Native American communities or Tribal Nations defers to the Office of Indian Affairs and the Department offices that handle Tribal relations.

Support I need

- A decision on whether the Program serves as the DSD system of record for equity tools and decision logs, alongside or instead of a dedicated SharePoint site.
- A division-wide channel to announce downloads and new curricula to all staff.

2. Launch the Program throughout the Division from January 2027

Status: In progress · decisions needed

Aligned to: Program launch standard and readiness checklist · Framework transition from Year One to Year Two · the January 2027, post-election launch timing shared among DHS equity professionals

What I am doing now

- Closing the remaining readiness items: a complete DSD organizational map confirmed locally; the ERG roster and joining arrangements verified; one real accepted work item run through the One DSD Team workspace with a decision owner and outcome; the retention decision for consultation and staff-result records made before intake opens; deployment evidence recorded for the launch head.
- Preparing the launch evaluation: moderated task success on Home, One DSD entry and ASK; voluntary participant accounts; escalation paths visible; recorded dispositions with owners and review dates; work-item outcomes with delivery, application and benefit kept distinct.

Planned outcomes

- A confirmed division-wide launch date in January 2027, agreed with colleagues before it appears on any staff page.
- Every readiness item closed, or carrying an agreed exception with a date to resolve it.
- The evaluation standard in operation from day one: it examines program support and practice, never employee beliefs or performance.

Timeline

Readiness items October–November 2026 · the decision to open, December 2026 · division-wide opening from January 2027, after the election.

Challenges and barriers

- The organizational map cannot be completed from public sources; it needs each unit's confirmation.
- The ERG roster is unverified.
- The first real work item needs a sponsoring manager and a decision owner.
- The records-retention decision needs policy and records input I do not hold.

Support I need

- Each manager: thirty minutes to confirm their unit's map.
- One manager to sponsor the first Team work item.
- You and Heidi Hamilton: the decision on whether to open, and the date.
- Records or legal input on retention before intake opens.

3. Governance and leadership accountability

Status: Needs decision

Aligned to: Framework Step One · ADSA Goal 1 (an equity team in each division) · DSD operational plan: named owners, a charter, a decision tracker · Analysis intervening condition: empowerment, not direction

What I am doing now

- Preparing, from the Framework, the Executive Council charter (decision rights, monthly meetings in year one, quorum, documentation, annual review) and the Division DEIA Council criteria (eight to ten members from at least four units, two-year staggered terms, four protected hours a month) for the Director's decision.
- Drafting DEIA performance-plan goal language by role, and the decision log and tracker the councils would use.

Planned outcomes

- Executive Council chartered and meeting.

- Division DEIA Council seated, with its chair connected to the ADSA Equity Committee.
- DEIA goals in the performance plans of council members; protected time documented.
- Framework gate checks One-A, One-B and One-C met.

Timeline

Charter decision Q4 2026 · councils seated Q1 2027 · gate checks by end of Q1 2027.

Challenges and barriers

- Supervisors described a top-down approach in which even senior leaders may not feel empowered to push back. Direction without authority produces compliance, not practice.
- Protected time and performance-plan integration need HR and supervisors, not only goodwill.

Support I need

- Heidi Hamilton, as Director: to charter and chair the Executive Council.
- Managers: to nominate council members and protect four hours a month.
- HR: performance-plan integration.
- You: to broker the decision meeting with Heidi Hamilton.

4. Assessment, data baseline and accountability measures

Status: Proposed · largest gap

Aligned to: Framework Step Two · ADSA Goal 1 (data-driven) and Goal 3 (yearly climate survey) · DSD non-negotiable 4 and the quarterly correction loop · Analysis category 4, the largest gap between what staff asked for and what exists

What I am doing now

- Turning the baseline data collection planning template into a plan: inventory of existing HR and survey data; climate survey design (psychological safety, fairness, accommodation, belonging, leadership commitment) on an accessible platform; data standards (EEOC-aligned categories, voluntary self-identification, validation, minimum cell size of five).
- Preparing the next general division-wide equity assessment on a two-year cycle. The last concluded in 2024; on that cadence the next was due in 2026, and the findings the Program rests on are now three years old.
- Using the Equity Outcome Map as the outcome frame the measures report against.

Planned outcomes

- Baseline climate survey with at least a sixty-five percent response.
- Barrier analysis across recruitment, retention, advancement, accommodation and pay, presented to the Executive Council with priority areas approved.
- Data standards ratified; a quarterly disparities report and the correction-plan protocol in operation.

- A general division-wide qualitative assessment repeated every two years, giving the Division a comparable read on its own culture and the Program its own feedback loop.

Timeline

Plan Q4 2026 · survey Q1 2027 · next general assessment alongside the launch, 2027 · analysis and Executive Council presentation Q2 2027 · assessments thereafter 2029, 2031.

Challenges and barriers

- Seven of twenty-three sessions described data they cannot reach: restricted data sets, no access to HR statistics, no training in qualitative analysis.
- Needs workforce data from HR, Data and Analytics capacity, privacy and legal review, and Executive Council authorization.
- Response rates depend on managers encouraging participation and on staff trusting how results are used.

Support I need

- You: to broker data access with HR and Data and Analytics.
- Heidi Hamilton: to authorize baseline collection and the biennial assessment cycle.
- Managers: to encourage survey participation in their units.

5. Vision, working-group charters and communications

Status: Proposed

Aligned to: Framework Step Three · ADSA Goal 6 · Analysis category 6: silos and broken feedback loops

What I am doing now

- Drafting the working-group charter template (purpose, scope, deliverables, success criteria, membership, cadence, reporting line) and the outline of a plain-language multi-year DEIA plan that passes the Equity Lens Rubric.
- Drafting the message platform all communicators use; holding office hours weekly for the first six months after the launch.
- Returning the evidence record and the analysis to the staff who contributed them — the most direct answer to the feedback-loop finding.

Planned outcomes

- Four working groups chartered: Recruitment and Onboarding; Workplace Climate and Accessibility; Service Delivery and Community Engagement; Metrics and Learning.
- The multi-year plan approved by the Executive Council and published on the Program.
- Communications campaign launched with a feedback channel; a pulse check showing most staff can name two priorities and know where the resources are.

Timeline

Charters Q1 2027 · plan Q2 2027 (after the baseline) · campaign from Q2 2027.

Challenges and barriers

- Depends on Workstreams 3 and 4.
- Needs Communications capacity and unit directors' quarterly discussions.

Support I need

- You and Heidi Hamilton: approval of the message platform and the plan.
- Managers: to host unit-level discussions each quarter.
- A named Communications partner.

6. Learning, leadership competencies and intercultural development

Status: Built · competencies proposed

Aligned to: ADSA Goal 4 (intercultural competence; the IDI Implementation Plan; leadership development) · One Minnesota Plan · Analysis categories 1 and 9

What I am doing now

- Built into the Program: the Intercultural Practice and Equity curriculum (38 modules), the learning journey, the Equity Analysis Toolkit companion, IDI orientation tutorials, and DEIA leadership and growth for One DSD; authored this month: the research analysis of leadership styles and their equity impact and its eleven-course series.
- Drafting a leadership competency framework tied to the Intercultural Development Continuum and to general equity practice, for supervisors, managers and directors.

Planned outcomes

- Leadership competency framework adopted, with development maps and feedback practices on the Program.
- IDI arrangements decided: a qualified administrator, group profiles, individual debriefs and development plans, voluntary and never recorded as an assessment of anyone.
- First supervisor and manager cohort completed.

Timeline

Competency framework draft Q4 2026 · IDI decision Q1 2027 · first cohort Q2 2027.

Challenges and barriers

- IDI administration needs a qualified administrator and license budget.
- Participation is voluntary; Program completion does not count toward required training unless leadership approves an exception.
- Cohort time competes with caseload.

Support I need

- Heidi Hamilton and ADSA: the IDI administration decision and budget.
- Managers: cohort time for their supervisors.
- You: whether to seek a training-credit exception.

7. Equity analysis in everyday decisions

Status: In progress

Aligned to: DSD non-negotiable 1 (mandatory equity analysis) · ADSA Goals 1 and 5 · Framework Equity Lens Rubric · Analysis category 3: the finding that assessments follow decisions

What I am doing now

- Built: the Equity Analysis Toolkit companion and the guided walkthrough that records an analysis on the Program.
- Building the practice infrastructure in sequence: Equity Pause; Equity Lens Rubric self-check; Standard and Impact Review; co-creation cycle and commitment register; the Team work-item cycle with its problem-solving protocol; the leadership decision brief and condition-based roadmap; job aids attached to courses; learning-pathway logic.

Planned outcomes

- Every major policy, funding or program change routed through an equity analysis with a record, before the decision rather than after.
- The Rubric applied to division materials before release.
- Procurement and contracting practices analyzed with the toolkit.

Timeline

Equity Pause, Rubric self-check and Impact Review Q4 2026 · co-creation, work-item cycle and decision brief Q1 2027 · procurement review Q2 2027.

Challenges and barriers

- Staff described equity assessments conducted after decisions are made and experienced as a check-the-box exercise. No tooling repairs that; it is a sequencing rule leadership sets.
- The system-of-record decision determines where records are kept.

Support I need

- Heidi Hamilton: to make equity analysis before the decision a standing requirement.
- Managers: to route their unit's decisions through the tools.
- You: to set that expectation with managers.

8. Community engagement and service delivery

Status: Proposed for 2027

Aligned to: ADSA Goal 2 · Framework Step Seven · DSD non-negotiable 2 · Analysis category 8, raised in twelve of twenty-three sessions

What I am doing now

- Built: Minnesota Communities briefs and community connections on the Program; the Community Engagement Planner protocol drafted in the Framework.
- Identifying projects that affect communities and the advisory councils to consult, including the Cultural and Ethnic Communities Leadership Council; anything concerning Tribal Nations routes through the Department offices that handle Tribal relations and consultation.

Planned outcomes

- The engagement planner in use on real projects, with documentation of how feedback was used.
- First co-creation sessions with community partners.
- Tribal consultation training completed by staff whose work requires it.

Timeline

Preparation Q1 2027 · first engagements Q2 2027, after the baseline.

Challenges and barriers

- Staff described distrust that must be addressed before engagement works, and engagement that is not sustained.
- Depends on Framework Steps Two, Three and Six.
- Consultation protocol and boundaries must be respected exactly.

Support I need

- Managers: to identify their projects that affect communities.
- Heidi Hamilton: sponsorship for advisory council consultation.

9. The legislative dimension

Status: Scope to agree · gap

Aligned to: One Minnesota and Olmstead commitments · statutory obligations behind DSD practice · Analysis category 10, and the second of the two gaps the analysis names

What I am doing now

- Not yet started. Proposed scope: follow the 2027 session for bills that affect DSD services, accessibility, workforce and Olmstead obligations; produce plain-language briefs on the Program; connect statutory obligations to the practice tools; support equity analysis entering legislative proposals before positions are set, as several sessions asked.

Planned outcomes

- A legislative brief series staff can use.
- A statutory crosswalk in the Program linking obligations to tools and resources.

Timeline

Scope agreed Q4 2026 · briefs during the session, Q1–Q2 2027.

Challenges and barriers

- Positions on legislation belong to DHS Government Relations; my scope is to inform practice, not to advocate.
- Capacity.

Support I need

- You: to agree the scope.
- A connection to DHS Legislative and Government Relations.

10. One DSD Team and Amplify Equity

Status: Planned start January 2027

Aligned to: ADSA Goal 3 (ERGs; Employee Engagement) · Framework DEIA Council pipeline · Analysis categories 6 and 9

What I am doing now

- Built: the Team page, workspace and Learning Lab, and the Amplify pages (gatherings, mentoring, ideas, well-being, co-leads, materials).
- Recruiting voluntary members; planning the monthly rhythm from January 2027, alternating practical team work with Learning Labs or open hours.

Planned outcomes

- The Team convened with its first accepted work items.
- Learning Labs running; the contribution map filled.
- A pool of prepared candidates for the DEIA Council and working groups.

Timeline

Recruitment Q4 2026 · first meeting January 2027 · quarterly review.

Challenges and barriers

- Voluntary participation needs protected time to be real.
- Risk that the Team becomes an Amplify referral desk rather than doing bounded divisional work.
- No dates are published to staff until confirmed.

Support I need

- Managers: to permit and protect participation.
- You: to confirm the rhythm.
- Heidi Hamilton: visible endorsement at an all-staff meeting.

Barriers that cut across the plan

- **Capacity.** One consultant against a ten-step framework. The Program multiplies my reach; governance, data collection and working groups still need named people with protected time.
- **Decision rights.** Until the Executive Council and DEIA Council are chartered, every step after Workstream 3 rests on goodwill.
- **Data access.** The baseline cannot be built without workforce data and Data and Analytics time.
- **Protected time.** The most frequently named constraint in the assessment, and the one every other recommendation depends on. Equity work is not declined in this Division; it is displaced.
- **Funding.** IDI administration and an accessible survey platform have costs that need a home.
- **Dates.** Nothing is published to staff as a schedule until confirmed.

Decisions and support, by owner and date

Decision or support	From	By	Workstream
Charter and chair the Executive Council	Heidi Hamilton (Director)	Q4 2026	3
Nominate DEIA Council members; protect four hours a month	Managers	Q4 2026	3
Authorize baseline data collection and the biennial assessment cycle	Heidi Hamilton / Leigh Ann	Q4 2026	4
Confirm each unit's organizational map	Managers	November 2026	2
Sponsor the first One DSD Team work item	One manager	November 2026	2
Read the Program, the analysis and this plan, and share thoughts	Leigh Ann Ahmad and Heidi Hamilton	December 1, 2026	all
Whether to open the Program, and the January 2027 date	Leigh Ann Ahmad and Heidi Hamilton	December 2026	2

Decision or support	From	By	Workstream
System of record: the Program, a SharePoint site, or both	Leigh Ann	Q4 2026	1, 7
Make equity analysis before the decision a standing requirement	Heidi Hamilton	Q4 2026	7
Legislative scope	Leigh Ann	Q4 2026	9
Records retention for consultation and staff-result records	Leigh Ann with records / legal	Before intake opens	2
IDI administration and budget	Heidi Hamilton / ADSA	Q1 2027	6
Approve the message platform and the multi-year DEIA plan	Leigh Ann and Heidi Hamilton	Q1-Q2 2027	5

How we use this

- A thirty-minute check-in every two weeks, working from this document, with the status column and the decisions table updated beforehand.
- A short written update each month, and a quarterly review with the managers so the support they are asked for is visible to them.
- Barriers are raised at the check-in where they appear, with what I have tried and what would unblock them, so nothing waits for a quarter.

This is a draft for our meeting next week. I would like to agree the workstreams, the targets and the decisions table with you, and then keep it current from there.

Reporting Process

How progress, barriers, and decisions are tracked and reported from October 2026 forward.

TO Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager, Disability Services Division

CC Heidi Hamilton, Division Director, Disability Services Division

FROM Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant

DATE September 18, 2026

STATUS Draft for review

The memorandum on how the Program came to be was reconstructed from notes. This document establishes how the work is tracked and reported from here forward, so that neither of us has to reconstruct it again: one set of work units, one set of status values, a fixed cadence of artifacts, the measures that matter, a decision log with owners and dates, and a defined path for escalation.

It is built on the Program as it stands, on the DSD DEIA Integration Framework's gate checks and quarterly learning reviews, on the Division operational plan's quarterly correction cycle, and on the Administration's expectation that each division's equity function plans, tracks and reports. It also answers a finding from the Division's own assessment: eleven of twenty-three sessions described feedback loops that do not close.

It serves three audiences in a single chain: you, for progress, barriers and support; Heidi Hamilton as Director, where a decision or exception is hers; and the Administration's Equity Committee, through the DEIA Council chair once that body is seated.

1. What is tracked

Everything reported is one of six things. Each has a record with an owner.

Unit	What it is	Where it lives
Workstream	One of the ten areas in the operational workplan, each with outcomes, a target and a status.	The operational workplan
Work item	A bounded piece of work with a decision owner, an intended outcome and evidence when done.	Team workspace record; workplan
Release	A change to the Program: content added, revised or withdrawn, a tool, or a curriculum. Recorded from now; visible to staff once the Division opens the Program.	Monthly release note
Decision or support request	Something a named person must decide or provide, with a date.	Decision log and support register

Unit	What it is	Where it lives
Barrier	What is blocked, since when, what has been tried, what would unblock it.	Barrier entry; raised at check-in
Measure	Evidence about program support and organizational patterns, never about individual employees.	Quarterly report; dashboard once the baseline exists

2. Status words and what “done” means

The same five words are used everywhere, so a status means one thing whether it appears in the workplan, a monthly update or a quarterly report.

- **Built.** Complete in the Program and ready for staff when the Division opens it. Not in use today; nothing has launched.
- **In progress.** Work has started and has an owner, an outcome and a target.
- **Proposed.** Designed and ready, waiting on a decision, a dependency or capacity.
- **Needs decision.** Cannot move until a named person decides; the decision is in the log with a date.
- **Blocked.** Started, then stopped by a barrier that is recorded and raised.

Done means the intended outcome exists and the evidence for it is recorded. Activity is not an outcome: a meeting held, a page viewed or a course completed is not reported as a result. Where a target is at risk the timeline is marked amber; where it will be missed, red, with the new date and the reason.

3. Cadence and artifacts

Artifact	What it contains	When	Who
Check-in	The workplan with status and decision log updated beforehand; barriers since the last check-in; what I need from you.	Every two weeks, thirty minutes	You and me
Monthly update	One page: Done · Next · Blocked · Decisions needed · Measures, with the month's release note attached.	First working day of each month; first on October 1, 2026	Me to you; shareable with the managers
Quarterly report	Progress against each workstream target; the measures in section 4; gate checks passed or not; support delivered or outstanding; a correction plan for any	Within ten working days of quarter end; first for October-	Me to you and Heidi Hamilton; to the ADSA Equity Committee

Artifact	What it contains	When	Who
	disparity not moving; next quarter's priorities.	December 2026 in January 2027	through the DEIA Council chair
Launch report	Whether the Program is ready to open, what remains, and the proposed January 2027 opening date.	December 2026	Me to you and Heidi Hamilton
Quarterly learning review	The councils examine the quarterly report and adjust strategy, as the Framework provides.	Once the councils are chartered	Executive Council and DEIA Council
Annual report	The year's outcomes against the Framework arc and the ADSA plan; charter reviews; next year's priorities.	December each year; first December 2027	Me to Heidi Hamilton through you
General division-wide equity assessment	A qualitative read of the Division in staff's own words, coded and reported as the 2023–2024 assessment was, with the previous cycle's findings alongside for comparison.	Every two years. The last concluded in 2024; the next runs with the 2027 launch, then 2029 and 2031.	Me, with a project partner and the DEIA Council

Why the biennial assessment sits in this table. The annual climate survey counts things; the biennial assessment listens. Findings such as performative equity, a culture of perfection, moral fatigue and loneliness do not appear on a scale. Both are needed and neither substitutes for the other. Repeating it also gives the Program its own feedback loop: the second assessment measures whether the tools built from the first changed what staff actually experience.

4. The measures that are reported

Measures examine program support and organizational patterns. They never measure an individual employee, and an empty record means no evidence in that record, not that nothing happened elsewhere.

Program support

- Can staff find trusted support faster: task success on Home, the One DSD entry and ASK, from moderated sessions.
- Do they apply it to real work: voluntary participant accounts with source, the change described, the period and its limits.
- Can they tell when human authority is required: escalation paths visible; intake used appropriately.
- What is inaccessible, outdated, missing, confusing or hard to apply: recorded dispositions with owners and review dates.

- Did bounded work produce a change: work-item outcomes, with delivery, application and benefit kept distinct.

Content stewardship

- Releases in the period; items added, revised and withdrawn; outside sources verified and reached before release; anything deferred to another office.
- Themes emerging from the end-of-module suggestion prompts, and what was built or revised in response.

Participation and use, in aggregate only

- Program use by area and resource type; Team and Amplify participation; learning cohorts started and completed. Never reported by name, never used to rank people or units.
- Course and practice-path completion, downloads by resource and format, and the questions most often put to ASK — counted, not attributed, and read for what to build next.

Governance and gate checks

- Framework gate checks answered yes or no with the verification named; decision-log items closed on time; protected time documented.

Disparities data, once the baseline exists

- Disaggregated by race, disability, gender and language with a minimum cell size of five; recruitment, retention, advancement, accommodation and pay. When a quarterly report shows a disparity not improving, the correction plan is triggered: specific operational changes, named owners, due dates and the measure to be read next quarter.

5. The decision log and support register

Every ask of another person is written down once, with an owner and a date, and reviewed at every check-in. Nothing is asked twice by accident and nothing is forgotten.

Field	Rule
What is needed	One sentence: a decision, an approval, time, data, a person.
From whom	A named person or role: you, a manager, Heidi Hamilton, HR, Data and Analytics, ADSA.
By when	A date. If none can be given, the entry says why and when it will be revisited.
Workstream	The workstream it unblocks.
Status	Open · Provided · Declined · Deferred, with the date it changed.

Field	Rule
Effect	What moved once it was provided, written when it closes.

6. Escalation

1. A barrier is raised at the check-in where it appears, with what I have tried and what would unblock it.
2. A barrier unresolved after two check-ins, or a decision past its date, goes into the monthly update under Decisions needed, addressed to you.
3. Where the decision or the time belongs to the managers, you convene them, or I bring it to the quarterly review with the managers.
4. Where it belongs to the Director, you bring Heidi Hamilton in; the entry names what is being asked and the consequence of waiting.
5. Where it belongs to the Administration, it goes through the DEIA Council chair to the ADSA Equity Committee once that link exists; until then, through you.

7. Records and boundaries

- **Where records are kept.** The workplan, decision log, monthly updates and quarterly reports are kept in one place: the Program's records, or the dedicated SharePoint site if that is the system-of-record decision, with the same structure either way.
- **What never enters a record.** Case, medical, personnel, complaint or identifying details about any person. Work items are described by the work, not the people.
- **Assessment records.** Findings from any general assessment are attributed to teams, never to individuals, as in the 2023-2024 record.
- **Voice.** Anything published to staff passes the staff voice standard and, once adopted, the Equity Lens Rubric.
- **Retention.** Follows the retention decision for consultation and staff-result records, made before intake opens.
- **Native American communities and Tribal Nations.** Any item concerning them is recorded as deferred to the Office of Indian Affairs and the Department offices that handle Tribal relations and consultation.

8. Templates

Monthly update, one page

- Done: outcomes reached this month, with the evidence.
- Next: what is planned for the coming month, by workstream.

- Blocked: barriers, since when, what has been tried.
- Decisions needed: from the log, with owner and date.
- Measures: the two or three numbers that moved, and the release note.

Quarterly report

- Summary: three sentences on the quarter.
- Workstreams: target, status, what was delivered, what slipped and why.
- Measures: section 4, with the prior quarter beside it.
- Gate checks: which passed, with the verification; which did not, and the plan.
- Support: delivered, outstanding, declined.
- Correction plans: any triggered, with owners and dates.
- Next quarter: priorities and the decisions they depend on.

Work-item record

- Title · workstream · decision owner · intended outcome · start · target · status · evidence when done · what changed for whom.

Barrier entry

- What is blocked · since when · what I have tried · what would unblock it · who can provide it · raised on.

9. Calendar, October 2026 to June 2027

When	What
October 2026	Reporting process starts. First monthly update October 1. Check-ins every two weeks. Unit organizational maps requested from the managers.
November 2026	Monthly update. Organizational maps confirmed. First One DSD Team work item sponsored. Governance charters with Heidi Hamilton for decision.
December 2026	Monthly update. Report on whether the Program is ready to open, and the proposed January date.
January 2027	Division-wide launch, after the election, with the date confirmed with colleagues first. First One DSD Team meeting. Quarterly report for Q4 2026.
February-March 2027	Monthly updates. Councils seated; gate checks One-A to One-C. Climate survey in the field. Working-group charters. Next general assessment prepared.
April 2027	Quarterly report for January-March: launch evidence, gate checks, first measures.

When	What
May-June 2027	Monthly updates. Barrier analysis to the Executive Council. Multi-year plan approved. Quarterly report for April-June in July.

10. From reconstruction to tracked work

The memo on how the Program came to be is the baseline, and the evidence record and analysis behind it establish where the Program came from. From October 1, 2026, the workplan is updated as the work happens, the decision log carries every ask, and the monthly update and quarterly report replace reconstruction.

This is a draft for our meeting next week. I would like to agree the cadence, the measures and the escalation path with you, and then run it from October 1.

Program Crosswalk

The Program checked goal by goal against the DHS ecosystem and ADSA's six equity goals.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
PREPARED FOR	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager — Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
DATE	September 18, 2026
STATUS	Draft for review

1. Purpose

A general assurance of alignment establishes nothing. This document examines one goal at a time. For each of the six equity goals set by the Aging and Disability Services Administration, it states what the goal actually requires, what the Program has built against it, and where nothing has been built yet. The three-year plan carries every gap named here into a sequence of work; this document exists so that plan rests on specific findings rather than a general impression.

2. Where the Program sits within the Department

Four levels govern this work, and each sets something different. Conflating them — treating a Division instrument as an enterprise standard, or an Administration goal as a Program feature — is the most common way a crosswalk misleads.

Level	Who's in charge	What it sets	Where the Program stands
DHS	DHS leaders; the Office of Employee Culture	The One Minnesota Plan; the DHS Equity Policy and its Equity Analysis Toolkit. These are the enterprise standards every administration and division builds against.	Examined, not adopted. In 2024 the Office of Employee Culture was studied to understand how an established administration shapes its equity work. That produced a practical indication of form for this Division — which is a different thing from a template.
ADSA	Aging and Disability Services Administration; Heidi Hamilton leads its equity work for our Division	The Administration's Equity and Inclusion Implementation Plan and its six goals, examined in section 3	The subject of section 3: every Program element traced to the goal it answers, or named plainly where no provision yet exists.
DSD	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager; the Division's own operational plan	Four non-negotiables: equity analysis before major changes; documented community engagement; accessibility and	The Framework's ten steps and the Program's ten workstreams are the same plan in two forms. The Framework

Level	Who's in charge	What it sets	Where the Program stands
		plain language; and disaggregated data	sets the sequence; the Program is what staff actually open and use.
The Program	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant	The working application: courses, ASK, practice paths, job aids, the One DSD Team, Amplify Equity, and every non-course resource available as a downloadable file	The implementation layer. Nothing above this row is something a staff member touches; everything at this row is.

One clarification the record requires: the Office of Employee Culture, a separate administration within the Department, was examined in 2024 to understand how an established administration shapes its equity work. It was not adopted as a model. What that examination produced was a practical indication of form for this Division, which is a different thing from a template.

3. Correlation to the Administration's six equity goals

The Administration's Equity and Inclusion Implementation Plan sets six goals. The table states each one, what it requires in a division's daily operation, what the Program has built against it, an honest status, and what remains absent. Three status values are used consistently throughout this document set: Built, Partly built, and Not yet built.

#	Goal	What it asks for	Built so far	Status	What's missing
1	Eliminate disparities	Every division is expected to reduce measurable gaps in outcomes, not merely state an intention to.	The Equity Pause — the practice of conducting analysis before a decision rather than after (Workstream 7); a chartered equity team with named decision rights (Workstream 3).	Partly built	The disparities themselves remain unmeasured. Absent the Workstream 4 baseline, the Division has a practice but no instrument to demonstrate its effect.
2	Community engagement	Sustained engagement with the communities the Division serves, documented rather than incidental.	Minnesota Communities briefs and the community engagement planner (Workstream 8).	Partly built	The planner exists as content but has not been applied to a live project with documented outcomes. That application is a Workstream 8 target, not an accomplished fact.

#	Goal	What it asks for	Built so far	Status	What's missing
3	Hiring and retention	A workforce reflecting the communities served, and conditions that retain people once hired.	The One DSD Team and Amplify Equity for engagement and belonging (Workstream 10); inclusive hiring and mentoring material (Workstream 1); the annual climate survey the goal itself specifies (Workstream 4).	Partly built	Retention is measured through turnover and exit data the Division does not directly control. The Program can establish the practice; it cannot by itself construct the workforce-data pipeline this goal presumes.
4	Learning and development	Staff and leaders develop the competence the work requires, along a documented arc.	The 38-module Intercultural Practice and Equity curriculum; Intercultural Development Inventory orientation material; research on leadership styles and its eleven-course series (Workstream 6).	Built, with one piece still planned	The curriculum is built. The competency framework it should feed — development maps and a funded coaching instrument — is proposed, not adopted. This is the best-served goal of the six, and still incomplete.
5	Contracts and procurement	Equity considered in contracting and procurement decisions before commitment, not after a contract is executed.	The Equity Pause practice (Workstream 7) addresses decisions generally but names no procurement instrument.	Not yet built	No content in the Program addresses a contract or a procurement decision directly. This is the weakest correlation of the six, and not marginally so.
6	Communication and accessibility	Communication that reaches everyone, with accessibility treated as a standard rather than an accommodation added afterward.	Accessibility checks, plain language in human services, language access planning, interpreter practice, and accessible-document practice (Workstream 1); the Program's own communications plan (Workstream 5).	Built	This is the one goal the Program satisfies as daily operating practice rather than instructional content — every resource is built to the accessibility and plain-language standard it teaches.

Read honestly, the table shows this: two goals, 4 and 6, are substantially answered. Three — 1, 2 and 3 — are partly answered, each with a specific and nameable missing element rather than

a general shortfall. One, contracts and procurement, has essentially no provision. That unevenness is the actual state of the work, and it is more useful to Division leadership than a claim that all six are in progress.

4. The implementation layer, workstream by workstream

The operational workplan ties each of its ten workstreams to a governing reference. This table consolidates that mapping so the correlation can be read across the whole Program at once, rather than one workstream at a time.

WS	Workstream	ADSA goal(s)	DSD rule	Framework step
1	Keep the Program current, accurate and ready for launch	4, 6	Non-negotiable 3 (accessibility and plain language)	Step Three
2	Launch throughout the Division	cross-cutting — enables all six	Readiness to open	Year One to Year Two
3	Governance and leadership accountability	1	—	Step One
4	Assessment, data baseline and accountability	1, 3	Non-negotiable 4 (disaggregated data)	Step Two
5	Vision, working groups and communications	6	—	Step Three
6	Learning, leadership competencies and the IDI	4	—	One Minnesota Plan
7	Equity analysis in everyday decisions	1, 5	Non-negotiable 1 (mandatory equity analysis)	Equity Lens Rubric
8	Community engagement and service delivery	2	Non-negotiable 2 (documented engagement)	Step Seven
9	The legislative dimension	no numbered goal — answers the One Minnesota and Olmstead commitments directly	—	—
10		3	—	

WS	Workstream	ADSA goal(s)	DSD rule	Framework step
	One DSD Team and Amplify Equity			DEIA Council pipeline

Two rows warrant comment. Workstream 2, the launch, is not tied to a single goal because it is the mechanism through which every other workstream reaches a staff member. It is cross-cutting by nature, not by omission. Workstream 9, the legislative dimension, carries no Administration goal number at all, and answers the One Minnesota Plan and the Olmstead Plan directly. That is not an error in this correlation. It is a finding: the Administration's goal structure names no legislative goal, while the Division's exposure to state law remains real. Where that work belongs organizationally is a decision for Heidi Hamilton and Leigh Ann Ahmad.

5. What this correlation establishes

- 1. The Program is strongest where it operates as a daily standard rather than instructional content.** Goal 6 is satisfied because every resource is built to the standard it teaches. Where the Program supplies content alone — hiring practice, mentoring guidance — the correlation weakens, because instructional material does not by itself change who is hired.
- 2. Every partly-built goal is missing the same element: measurement.** Goals 1, 2 and 3 each have an established practice and no means of demonstrating whether that practice has changed anything. This is the same gap staff themselves named — data and accountability — arriving here from the Administration's side rather than the Division's.
- 3. Contracts and procurement, Goal 5, is the largest gap.** Nothing in the built Program addresses a contract or a procurement decision. Unlike the other gaps, this is not a matter of degree; it approaches zero, and should be named as such rather than absorbed into a general statement about work remaining.
- 4. The legislative dimension sits outside the Administration's goal structure entirely.** It remains work the Division carries regardless of whether a goal names it, and should not be discounted because this correlation has no tidy place to record it.

6. Where this leads

Every finding in section 5 is carried forward by name into the three-year plan's gap analysis, including the two this correlation surfaced independently: contracts and procurement, and the goal structure's silence on legislative work. This document establishes the correlation. The three-year plan sets out what the Division does about it.

7. Related documents

- **Operational workplan** — the ten workstreams this document pulls its goal links from, with owners and dates.
- **Program logic model** — the chain from what we put in, to what changes because of it.
- **Three-year plan and blueprint** — what happens, in what order, to close the gaps named here.
- **The project-management version** — the same plan drawn as a timeline, a workflow, and a map of what has to happen before what.

Three-Year Plan and Blueprint

January 2027 through December 2029: what comes next, in order, and what is still to be built.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
PREPARED FOR	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager — Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
DATE	September 18, 2026
STATUS	Draft for review

1. The approach this plan takes

This plan doesn't treat the remaining sixty percent of this work as a simple to-do list. It treats it as a change effort, because that's really what our main finding describes. “Equity is carried as individual effort, without a system behind it” means, in plain terms, that staff do this work on their own, and the Division has never built it into how things officially get done. The next three years are about turning a habit some people practice into a habit the whole Division practices — a way of working that doesn't depend on which person happens to be doing it.

The sequence below follows an established pattern of organizational change: establish the case, secure leadership commitment, define what success requires, communicate it, enable people to act, produce early results, consolidate those results into broader change, and finally establish the new practice as standard. No step can be skipped without weakening the ones that follow.

Underlying the whole sequence is a simple test: a way of working becomes permanent only when it survives the person who introduced it, is documented well enough that someone else can carry it, and is reinforced by the Division's own decisions. Every gap named in section 6 is a practice that has not yet met that test.

Step	What it looks like here	When
1. Establish the case	The evidence is in hand: 172 findings, a central conclusion already accepted, and a Program well advanced and nearing the point where it can open.	Complete before this plan begins
2. Secure leadership commitment	Sponsorship from Heidi Hamilton and Leigh Ann Ahmad; the Executive Council and Division DEIA Council chartered.	Year 1, first half
3. Define what success requires	The multi-year plan and the working-group charters (Workstream 5).	Year 1, first half
4. Communicate it to staff	The communication plan prepared in December; office hours; a consistent message platform.	Year 1, first half, then continuous
5. Enable staff to act		

Step	What it looks like here	When
	Every staff member using the Program directly — downloads, ASK, courses — without the consultant as intermediary.	Year 1, from launch
6. Produce early results	The first completed work item; the first leadership cohort; the baseline survey fielded.	Year 1, second half
7. Consolidate and extend	Quarterly disparity reporting; the first legislative briefs in use; competency language entering performance plans.	Year 2
8. Establish it as standard practice	Equity analysis before a decision becomes a standing, audited requirement; the 2029 assessment measured against the original baseline.	Year 3

Read against the operational workplan: step 1 is complete, which is why the work now turns to opening the Program rather than to further research. Steps 2 through 5 fall in Year 1. Step 6, the early result, is genuine and worth marking — but it is not completion. Treating an early result as the finish is the most common way change efforts stall, and section 8 names it as the first risk in this plan.

2. The logic model, extended forward

The logic model that already comes with this package (Attachment E) reads from what we put in, to what we get out, as a story about the past: what we invested, all the way to what changes once the Program opens. This plan is that same story, run forward instead of backward. Year 1 is where real change for staff begins. Year 2 is where that change starts to add up. Year 3 is where we actually measure it, against the 2023–2024 numbers, at the 2029 check-in.

3. Year 1 — 2027: opening the Program

Year 1 covers steps 2 through 6. The division-wide launch occurs in January, following the November 2026 election. Governance is chartered in the same quarter. By year end, the Program should be able to demonstrate one completed piece of work, not a plan for one.

- **First quarter:** Launch. Leadership group and staff equity group set up. Work-group charters drafted. A decision made on the leader-coaching tool.
- **Second quarter:** The first supervisor and manager cohort completes leadership coaching. The baseline climate survey is fielded. The One DSD Team and Amplify Equity convene for the first time.
- **Third quarter:** Baseline results analyzed and presented to the Executive Council. The scope of the legislative workstream agreed with the Department's legislative and government relations office.

- **Fourth quarter:** Year 1 review: the first completed work item, the first disparity reading, and a candid account of what did not proceed on schedule, carried into Year 2 rather than set aside.

4. Year 2 — 2028: consolidating early results

Nothing in Year 2 is a new initiative. Each item is a Year 1 result, repeated until it no longer depends on Year 1 having been exceptional.

- **Data:** A second and third quarter of disparity reporting, so the correction protocol is exercised rather than merely defined. The first legislative brief published and applied in an actual session.
- **Learning:** Competency language enters performance plans for a pilot unit. A second leadership cohort, extending to directors.
- **Community and engagement:** The engagement planner applied to a live project with a documented outcome. Amplify Equity operating under rotating staff leadership rather than consultant facilitation.
- **Self-directed learning:** The reading list in section 7 published, reviewed once, and opened to staff nominations through the suggestion channel.

5. Year 3 — 2029: establishing standard practice

Year 3 is step 8, and the year this plan's central claim is tested against measurement rather than intention.

- **The 2029 division-wide assessment,** conducted on the biennial cycle the consultant's recommendations established, measured against the 2023–2024 baseline this Program was built from. This is the first point at which the Division can state, on evidence rather than impression, whether conditions have changed.
- **Equity analysis before a decision** operating as a standing, audited requirement rather than a practice some teams observe — established by Heidi Hamilton's Year 1 decision, and by Year 3 simply how decisions are made.
- **A leadership competency framework** standard in performance plans division-wide rather than confined to a pilot unit.
- **A practice other divisions could adopt,** which is the extension the analysis recommended from the outset: not inventing something new in Year 3, but demonstrating that what several Division teams already practiced in 2023 has become how the Division works.

6. Gap analysis: the remaining sixty percent

Seven gaps, each stated the same way: what exists today, what Year 1 must produce, what three years must produce, and the one condition this plan cannot satisfy on its own.

Gap	Today	Year 1 goal	Three-year goal	The honest limit
Leadership competencies and the Intercultural Development Inventory	The 38-module curriculum is built and orientation material exists. The assessment instrument itself, the development maps, and the link to performance plans are proposed rather than adopted.	Secure a qualified administrator and a license budget. Complete the first supervisor cohort with individual development plans on file. Introduce competency language into performance plans for one pilot unit.	Every supervisor and manager assessed at least once. Competency language standard in performance plans division-wide. A second cohort extending to directors.	Requires a decision and a budget from Heidi Hamilton and the Administration. Until that decision is made this gap cannot close in any year of this plan; it is constrained by a decision, not by capacity.
Staff engagement, through Amplify Equity	The One DSD Team and Amplify Equity are scheduled to begin in January 2027. Membership of the employee resource groups remains unverified.	Confirm rosters and joining arrangements. Establish regular Amplify Equity programming. Conduct a pulse check establishing whether most staff can name two Program priorities.	Amplify Equity operating under rotating staff leadership rather than consultant facilitation, with engagement evident in the aggregate usage measures Workstream 1 now records.	Sustained engagement is the outcome in this plan least amenable to scheduling. It is measured rather than mandated, and the Year 2 target is deliberately framed as sustaining rather than starting.
Self-directed learning beyond the Program	Nothing exists today. The Program directs staff only to its own material.	A curated, optional reading and listening list published on the Program, organized by the topics the courses already cover, explicitly marked as voluntary and never evaluated.	The list reviewed annually and expanded through staff nominations, once the suggestion channel in Workstream 1 is available to collect them.	This is new work proposed by this plan. It appears nowhere in the Program or the operational workplan before this document.

Gap	Today	Year 1 goal	Three-year goal	The honest limit
Data and accountability — the largest gap	No baseline measurement. No disaggregated reporting. No means for a team to observe conditions in its own area.	A baseline climate survey achieving at least sixty-five percent response. Data standards ratified. The first disparity report produced.	A second consecutive year of quarterly disparity reporting, with a correction protocol in active use rather than merely defined.	Every partly-built goal in the crosswalk traces to this gap. Closing it is what converts an established practice into demonstrated effect.
The legislative dimension	No legislative content exists. The scope of the work has not been agreed.	Scope agreed with the Department's legislative and government relations office. The first plain-language brief on a statute affecting the Division published.	A full legislative session in which the Division conducts equity analysis on a proposal before adopting a position rather than after.	This sits outside the Administration's six goals, as the crosswalk establishes. It remains real work. The Year 1 target is deliberately modest: agree the scope before committing to a result.
Governance, working groups and communications	Charters are drafted but no body has convened. No working group has begun.	Seat the Executive Council and the Division DEIA Council and convene both. Charter and convene all four working groups: Recruitment and Onboarding; Workplace Climate and Accessibility; Service Delivery and Community Engagement; and Metrics and Learning.	These bodies operating on their own cadence without consultant facilitation of every meeting, and the multi-year plan published and in its second annual review.	Nearly every other gap in this table depends on this one closing first, as the dependency map in the project-management version makes explicit.
Community engagement and service delivery	The Minnesota Communities briefs and the engagement planner exist as content. Neither has been applied to a live project.	Apply the planner to at least one real project and document how community input altered the outcome.	Sustained rather than episodic engagement documented across multiple projects, with community partners recognizing the change.	Depends on the communications capacity in Workstream 5 existing first. Engagement without a channel for response reproduces the 2023 finding that

Gap	Today	Year 1 goal	Three-year goal	The honest limit
				feedback goes nowhere.

7. Self-directed learning: a proposed reading and listening list

This is new. Nothing in the Program currently directs staff toward learning beyond it. The list below is a starting point intended to grow, organized by the same topics the Program's courses already cover. Every item is optional and none is evaluated, for the same reason course completion and leadership coaching are not.

Program topic	Suggested title	Why it fits here
Everyday equity habits at work	"The Person You Mean to Be: How Good People Fight Bias," by Dolly Chugh (2018)	A plain-spoken, practical starting point for staff who want the how, not just the why.
Working across cultures, the same topic our own course covers	"The Culture Map," by Erin Meyer (2014)	Written for the workplace, not for travel or theory — matches how our own course talks about working across cultures.
Belonging and feeling safe at work	"Belonging: The Science of Creating Connection and Bridging Divides," by Geoffrey L. Cohen (2022)	Speaks straight to the belonging and safety theme staff raised in the interviews.
Disability rights and self-determination	"Disability Visibility: First-Person Stories from the Twenty-First Century," edited by Alice Wong (2020)	First-person stories, in the same voice our own evidence record is written in.
Disability rights, in plain terms	"Demystifying Disability," by Emily Ladau (2021)	A practical, easy-to-use companion to the book above.
Bias and decision-making, tied to our Equity Pause habit	"Biased: Uncovering the Hidden Prejudice That Shapes What We See, Think, and Do," by Jennifer L. Eberhardt (2019)	Backs up our "check before you decide" rule with the research behind it.
Podcasts to listen to	"Code Switch" (NPR)	Short episodes on race, culture, and identity at work — easy to fit into a commute.
Podcasts to listen to	"Hidden Brain" (NPR)	Episodes on bias, belonging, and workplace culture, in plain language.

8. Risks and mitigations

Risk	Why it happens	How this plan answers it
Declaring completion prematurely	The most common failure in change efforts is treating an early result as if it were an established practice. This plan names its Year 1 milestones as early results deliberately, not as the finish.	Keep the biennial assessment on the calendar regardless of how Year 1 appears, so the 2029 measurement occurs whether or not Year 1 felt conclusive.
Governance that exists only on paper	A charter without meetings is not governance. The dependency map shows most of Year 2 and Year 3 waiting on this single workstream.	Track the Executive Council and the DEIA Council by meetings convened and decisions recorded, not by the existence of a charter document.
A single person carrying the load	Capacity is named as a cross-cutting constraint throughout the operational workplan. A three-year plan magnifies that risk rather than resolving it.	The plan already requires a named decision owner and a sponsoring manager for the first work item. No work is added here without also naming who beyond the consultant carries it.
A reading list mistaken for a requirement	A suggested list can drift toward appearing mandatory, which contradicts the voluntary-participation principle applied everywhere else in this Program.	State plainly on the Program page that the list is optional and never evaluated, using the same language already applied to course completion and leadership coaching.

9. How success will be measured

Four measures, each established elsewhere in this document set and carried through three years rather than one:

- The quarterly disparity report demonstrates movement, not merely existence, by the close of Year 2.
- The 2029 assessment is directly comparable to the 2023–2024 baseline on the same categories, so the question of effect has an evidenced answer.
- Aggregate usage — course completions, downloads, ASK queries, staff suggestions — shows adoption across the whole Division rather than concentration in one office.
- By the close of Year 3, at least four of the Administration's six equity goals move from Partly built to Built when the crosswalk is repeated.

The thinking behind these checks. Our evidence so far comes from one round of interviews and sessions — the right way to find our main finding, but one snapshot in time can't show whether anything changed. Three fixes make it stronger going forward. First, the 2023–2024, 2027, 2029, and 2031 check-ins all use the exact same list of themes, so they work as one long-running study instead of four separate ones — tracking change against our own starting point,

which is the strongest kind of proof a single division without a comparison group can realistically get. Second, the 2027 survey tests our interview themes against real numbers, and a short follow-up round of interviews explains why the numbers look the way they do — numbers first, then stories to explain the numbers, rather than just repeating interviews on a schedule. Third, no single number is trusted alone: interview and survey data, HR data, and the Program's own usage numbers are checked against each other, so a finding has to show up in more than one place before we call it real.

10. Related documents

- **Program crosswalk** — the goal-by-goal finding this gap list is built from.
- **Program logic model** (Attachment E) — the same story this plan runs forward.
- **Operational workplan** — the ten-month detail behind Year 1 of this plan.
- **The project-management version** — this same plan drawn as a timeline, a workflow, and a map of what has to happen before what.

Project-Management Version

The same plan as a timeline, a workflow diagram, a dependency map, and a decision-rights table.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
PREPARED FOR	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager — Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
DATE	September 18, 2026
STATUS	Draft for review

Why this document exists

The three-year plan and blueprint tells its story in words: what idea it's built on, what each year is for, what gap each workstream closes. This document tells the same story a different way — as a timeline, a workflow, and a map of what depends on what — because a good plan should make sense more than one way. Nothing here is new. Every date, every workstream number, and every dependency below comes straight from the plan and the operational workplan. This document just draws it out.

1. The three-year timeline, by workstream

Ten workstreams, laid out across the same three years as the written plan. Each bar shows how long that workstream stays in active work. The striped part of Workstream 1's bar marks the point where we shift from building the Program to simply keeping it running.

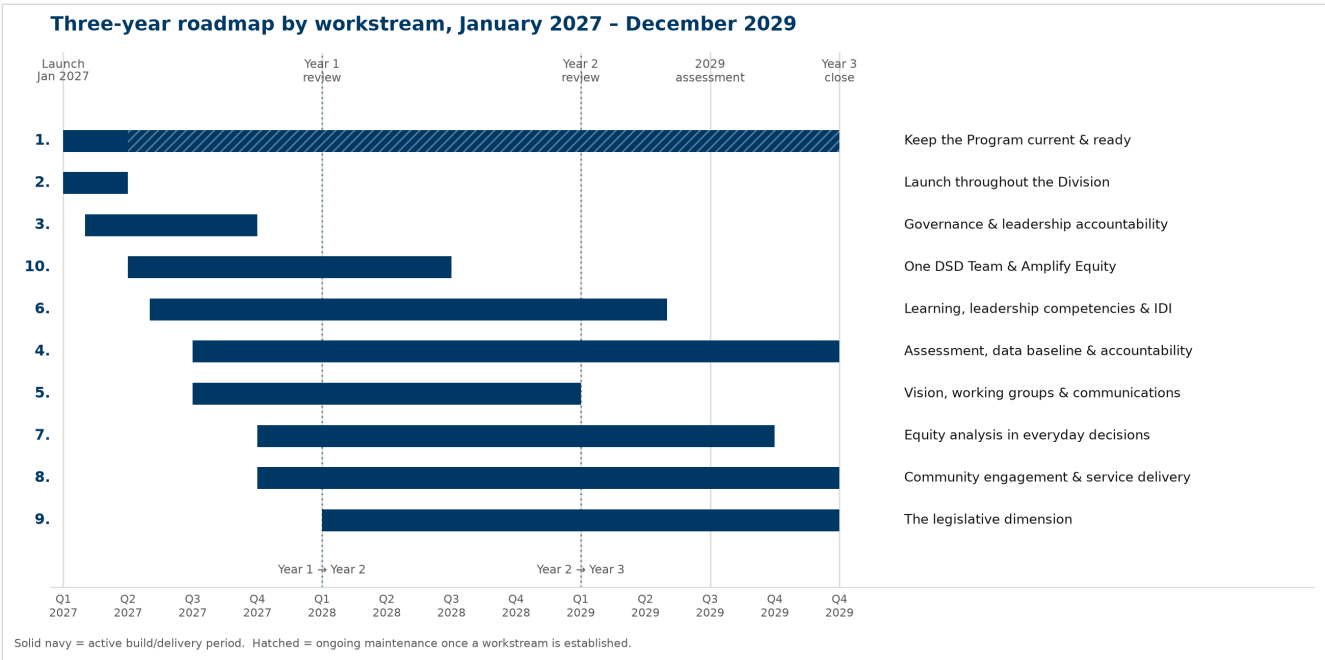


Figure 1. Three-year plan by workstream, January 2027 – December 2029.

Two things worth noticing that are easy to miss in the written version: Workstream 1 is the only bar that never ends — it's the base that everything else sits on top of. And the widest bars (4, 8, 9) are the exact three gaps the crosswalk found weakest. That's not an accident: the biggest gaps take the longest time to close.

2. How a piece of work actually moves

The operational workplan describes, in writing, how a work item gets a decision-owner and a result, spread across several workstreams. This is that same process drawn as one flow, because it's the same flow no matter which workstream the item belongs to.

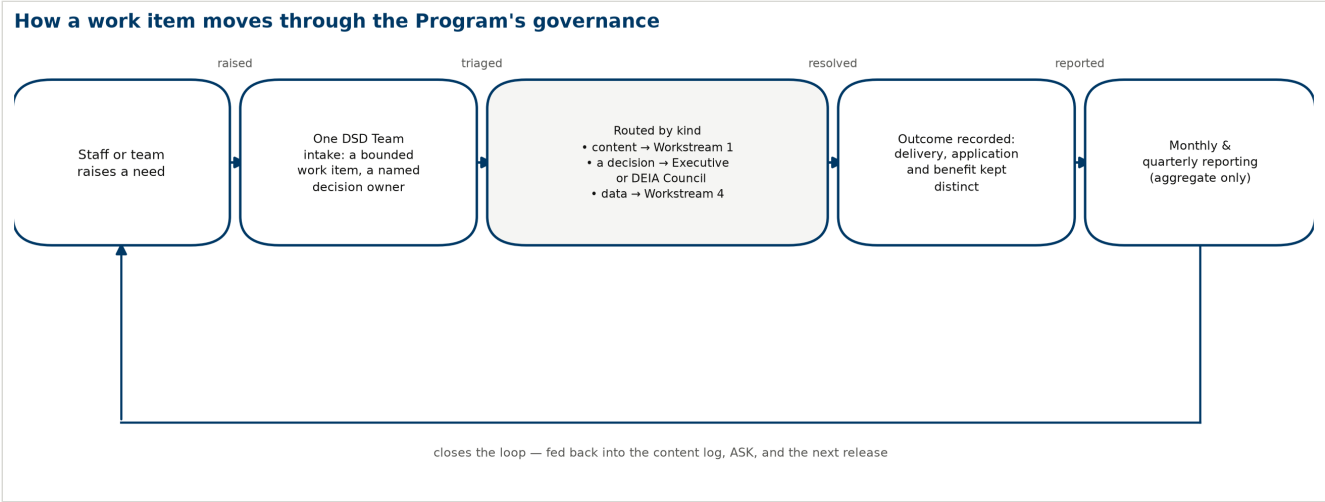


Figure 2. How a piece of work moves through the Program's leadership process.

The loop at the bottom answers the single most common thing staff told us: that feedback goes nowhere, raised in eleven of twenty-three sessions. Every piece of work, whatever kind it is, ends up back in the content list, in ASK, or in the next update — not filed away and forgotten.

3. What has to happen before what

Not every workstream can start on day one. Some really do have to wait on others. This map states that plainly, where the written plan only mentions it in passing.

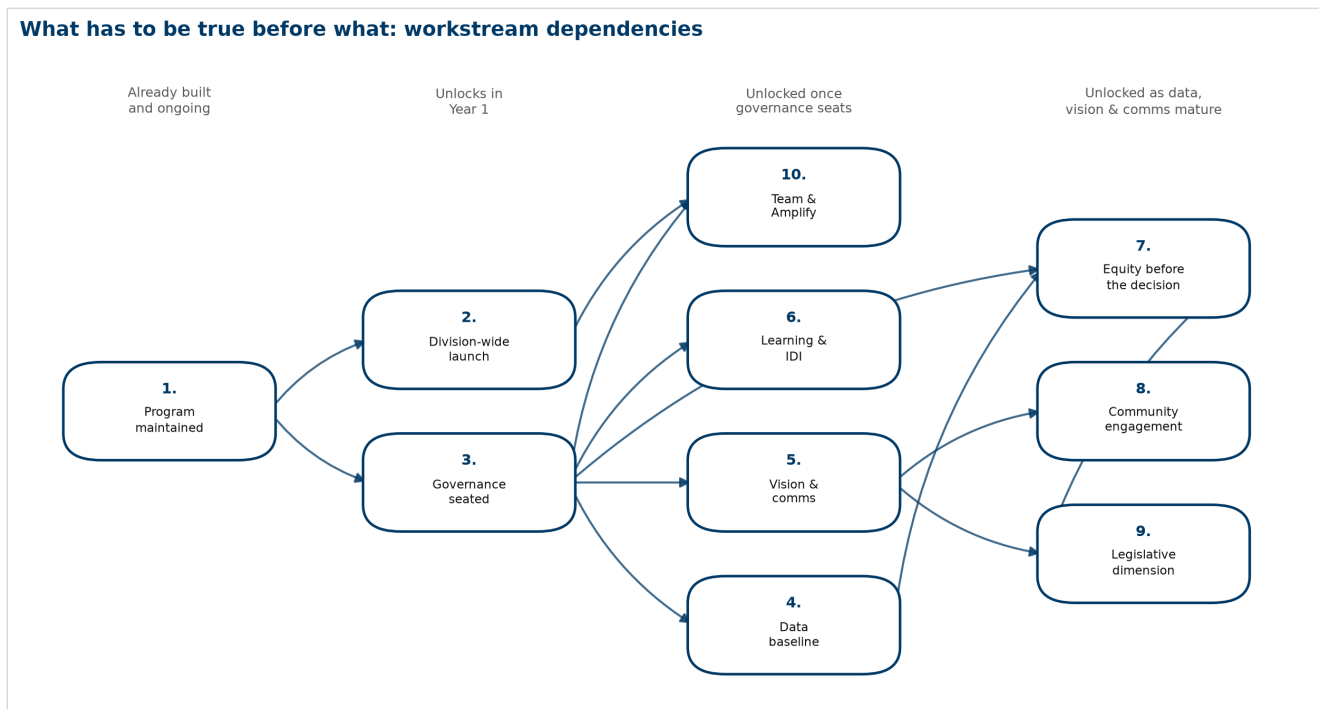


Figure 3. What each workstream needs in place before it can start.

The one line on this map that matters most: almost everything in the third and fourth columns is waiting on Workstream 3 — setting up leadership — to happen first. If chartering the leadership group or the staff equity group slips, that's not a small delay in one workstream. It delays most of Year 2 and Year 3. That's the very first risk named in the written plan, and this map shows exactly why.

4. Who decides what, in the first year

Decision	Accountable for the outcome	Carries it out	Consultant's contribution	Informed
Charter the Executive Council	Heidi Hamilton, Division Director	Heidi Hamilton issues the charter	Drafts the charter language and decision-rights structure	Managers; DEIA Council
Seat the Division DEIA Council	Heidi Hamilton, Division Director	Managers nominate; the Executive Council confirms	Coordinates the nomination process and member criteria	All staff
Decide IDI administration and budget	Heidi Hamilton and ADSA	Heidi Hamilton and ADSA	Researches options; brings a costed recommendation	Managers; supervisors

Decision	Accountable for the outcome	Carries it out	Consultant's contribution	Informed
Field the baseline climate survey	Heidi Hamilton, Division Director	HR and Data and Analytics administer it	Designs the instrument; brokers data access	All staff
Whether to open the Program in January 2027	Leigh Ann Ahmad and Heidi Hamilton	Leigh Ann Ahmad and Heidi Hamilton	Prepares the readiness picture they decide from	All staff
Agree the scope of the legislative workstream	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager	Consultant, with DHS Legislative and Government Relations	Scopes the Program content; does not represent the Division's legislative position	Executive Council

Where each piece of this work lives

- **Three-year plan and blueprint** — the full written version this document illustrates, including the idea behind the plan and the full list of gaps.
- **Program crosswalk** — the goal-by-goal findings behind the widest bars in Figure 1.
- **Operational workplan** — the ten-month detail behind Year 1 of the timeline.

Research and Evaluation Standard

A working document of mine. How the Program stays steady and trustworthy over time, as people and priorities change.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
PREPARED FOR	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager — Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
DATE	September 18, 2026
VERSION	1.1
STATUS	Draft for review

1. Why this exists, and why it has to outlast any one leader

Here's the main point, not a side note: this Program is built to stay steady even when leadership changes. A new Division Director, a new Manager, a new Supervisor, each with their own priorities — that's not some rare risk to plan for. It's just the normal reality of working inside a Division, inside a Department, inside a state government. A program that only keeps running because one particular Director happens to like it isn't really a program. It's that person's pet project, and it ends the day they leave. Everything in this document, and in the testing plan that goes with it, exists so that doesn't happen here.

This is a different, harder problem than a new consultant taking over, which section 6 also covers. A new consultant can pick up the existing evidence and keep going. But a new Director who was never told this Program is anything more than the last Director's personal choice has no reason to keep it running. That's why section 6 starts with leadership change, not staff change.

2. Version history

Version	Date	Author	What changed
1.0	September 18, 2026	Gary Banks	First version. Follows the crosswalk, the three-year plan, and the method discussion behind both.
1.1	September 18, 2026	Gary Banks	Fixed section 1 and section 6. Version 1.0 talked about a future consultant taking over. But the real point is bigger than that: this Program has to stay steady through a change in Division Director, Manager, or Supervisor — a change in leadership, not just a change in staff. Section 6 now starts with that, and section 7 is a new, step-by-step plan for exactly that moment.

This table grows over time. Any future change to this standard — a rule added, a rule dropped, a number changed — gets a new row here. It doesn't get a quiet edit to the row above it.

3. Ten habits we commit to going forward

Each one exists because something specific already went wrong, or could have, in this Program's own history. None of these are borrowed ideas from somewhere else. All ten trace back to a real weak spot in the evidence this Program is actually built on.

Habit	What it fixes	When we do it, going forward
Have a second person check the coding	One person coded the 2023-2024 findings. Relying on just one reader is a known weak point in this kind of work.	Every time we code a new round of findings — a new check-in, a new set of sessions — a second, separate person checks a sample of it, and we report how closely the two of them agree, before we publish anything.
Say plainly who wore which hats	One person can be the interviewer, the person who read the findings, the one who built the Program, and later the one grading it — all at once. The 2023-2026 record never said this out loud.	Any report of findings says, in one short paragraph, every role its author played in producing what it's reporting on.
Write down who we talked to, and who we missed	We never wrote down who was invited to the original 23 sessions and who actually showed up, so we don't really know how far our findings stretch.	Before publishing any findings, say who was invited, who took part, and what we do and don't know about the people who weren't there.
Check a finding against more than one source	A single source of information can be wrong in a way its own method can't catch.	We don't publish a claim that something “worked” based on one source alone. We check it against at least one other kind of source — interviews against HR records, say, or either one against how much staff actually use the Program — before we call it a finding instead of just a hint.
Explain why, not just what	Our analysis already shows that some teams feel safe and support each other, and others don't — and says this matters more than any other single finding — without yet explaining why the difference exists.	When we find that something worked in some places and not others, we say why — what was different about those places — not just that a difference exists.
Test new things with real staff before rolling them out	Courses, ASK, and the download feature were all built and finished before we ever asked staff what they thought.	Any new lesson, tool, or feature gets tried out with a small group of volunteer staff before we call it finished — in a quick trial-and-fix round — not just reviewed by whoever built it.
Decide what success looks like before we know the result	The measures of success in the three-year plan were written in September 2026, after most of the Program already existed.	Before any new project starts, or any new check-in begins, we write down and date how we'll know it worked — first. A measure written after we

Habit	What it fixes	When we do it, going forward
		already know the answer isn't really a measure. It's a description.
Ask the same questions the same way, every time	Four planned check-ins — 2023-2024, 2027, 2029, 2031 — could easily turn into four separate studies that just happen to ask similar things.	Every check-in after the first uses the exact same list of themes and questions as the one before it, so we're comparing like to like. We can add a theme if something genuinely new shows up. We don't quietly drop or redefine one.
Hold data to a fair standard	Data broken down by group can itself become a privacy problem, or a misleading comparison, if we're not careful.	Every new report using broken-down data compares against an outside benchmark, not only our own past numbers, and never publishes a group small enough that someone could be identified. No quiet exceptions.
Roll out big changes in stages, by default	The January 2027 launch happens for everyone at once. That's the one choice on this whole list that's already too late to change — and part of why this standard exists is to stop it from happening again.	Any future large rollout — a new course for the whole Division, or expanding to another division — starts with a small group first and adds more over time, by default, unless there's a stated reason not to. All-at-once becomes the exception we explain, not the plan we default to.

4. Before we publish anything new: a short checklist

Not every question below applies to every piece of work — a small content update doesn't need all of this; a new check-in needs most of it. But before we call something a finding, a result, or a success, whoever's reporting it answers these questions out loud, not just in their head:

1. If this uses new interview or session data: did a second person check a sample of the coding, and did we say how well they agreed?
2. If this reports findings: does it say who we talked to, who we didn't, and what that might mean?
3. If this claims something worked: is that backed up by more than one kind of evidence?
4. If this checks something new: did we write down how we'd know it worked, before we knew the answer?
5. If this repeats an earlier check-in: does it use the same questions and themes as last time, with no quiet changes?
6. If this publishes data broken down by group: does it follow our rules on comparison and privacy?
7. If this rolls out something new at scale: did we consider starting small first — and if we didn't, do we say why?

A fair “no, and here's why” is fine. Quietly skipping a question is not. This standard asks for honesty, not perfection — the same rule we already hold the Program itself to.

5. Who's in charge of this, and how it gets checked

Who follows it. Whoever holds the Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant role at the time — not tied to Gary Banks by name, because the whole point of this document is that it shouldn't depend on one person remembering.

Who checks it. The Division's staff equity group, once it's set up, reviews this standard once a year, at the same time as the year-end check built into our reporting plan. If a review finds this standard wasn't followed, it goes to the leadership group — and, separately from any yearly schedule, section 7's leadership-change plan kicks in the moment a new Director, Manager, or Supervisor takes office, no matter what else is happening on the calendar.

How it changes. A habit can be added, dropped, or changed at that same yearly review, and it gets written down as a new row in the table above. It can't quietly disappear just because a deadline made it inconvenient — if that decision gets made anyway, it gets written down too.

6. Five real situations this Program will run into

A new Division Director, Manager, or Supervisor takes office

This is the exact situation this document is built for. Section 7 spells it out in full, so it doesn't just live on this list: within a set number of days after any change at these levels, the new leader gets handed a fixed set of background material and a scheduled meeting with the staff equity group's chair. That way, the Program is handed over as something the Division has already committed to — not something a new leader has to discover on their own, and could just as easily choose to end.

A new consultant takes over the role

A smaller version of the same problem. They inherit this standard as their guide for how evidence gets produced here, along with a written record of how reliable our coding has been so far, and they're expected to keep that record going, not start over.

The Program spreads to another division

The new division does its early interviews and sessions using all ten habits from day one — a second coder, a written record of who was reached, a real starting survey collected at the same time as the interviews — instead of adding these habits years later, the way this Program did. This is the lesson from our own history, used on purpose this time, from the very start.

A future check-in gets pushed back or skipped

We say so, by name, in the very next quarterly report — rather than letting our long-running comparison quietly continue as if nothing changed. A missed 2029 or 2031 check-in, left unsaid, would break the whole point of comparing results over time, which is exactly what this standard is here to protect.

A new lesson, tool, or course gets proposed

It gets tried out with real staff first (habit 6) before we call it finished, and we check whether it's actually being used (habit 4), using at least our own usage numbers, before anyone claims it helped.

7. The leadership-change plan, step by step

This runs any time a new Division Director, Manager, or Supervisor takes office — triggered by the event itself, not by the calendar. It happens on its own, separate from the once-a-year review in section 5.

1. **Within 15 days:** the chair of the staff equity group — or the consultant, if that seat is empty — sends the new leader a standard set of background material: this document, the Program's logic model, the crosswalk to ADSA's six goals, and the governance rules currently in place.
2. **Within 30 days:** a written note goes in the decision log confirming that the Program's basis in official policy — the One Minnesota Plan, the Olmstead Plan, the DHS Equity Policy, and ADSA's own equity plan — hasn't changed. If it has, that gets said plainly, not assumed away.
3. **Within 60 days:** a scheduled, on-the-record meeting between the new leader and the staff equity group's chair, confirming the existing governance rules stay in force under the new leader, with no need to rewrite them from scratch.
4. **Within 90 days:** the new leader shows up in the regular quarterly report cycle for the first time — so their time in the role starts inside the same reporting rhythm every leader before them used, not outside it.

The one rule that makes all of this actually work: every governance rule this Program depends on is written about a job title, never a person's name — “the Division Director leads the leadership group,” never “Heidi Hamilton leads the leadership group.” A rule written to a name stops working the day that name changes. A rule written to a job title doesn't. Checking that this was actually done is itself one of the tests in the evaluation plan that goes with this document.

8. Where each piece of this work lives

- **Program crosswalk** and **the three-year plan and blueprint** — the method note in each is this same thinking, turned into ongoing practice.
- **What the Division Said: our analysis of what staff told us** — the coding that habit 1 (a second checker) applies to first, on our existing sample.

- **Reporting process** — the schedule this standard's yearly review rides on.
- **Evidence record: DSD equity sessions** — where the “who we talked to” note (habit 3) and the “who wore which hats” note (habit 2) belong, once written.
- **Program evaluation plan** — the real, step-by-step tests these ten habits turn into, including the job-title check named just above.

Program Evaluation Plan

A working document of mine. The regular checks the Program is held to as it continues.

PREPARED BY	Gary Banks, Equity and Inclusion Operations Consultant
PREPARED FOR	Leigh Ann Ahmad, Manager — Heidi Hamilton, Division Director
DATE	September 18, 2026
VERSION	1.0
STATUS	Draft for review

1. Why a checklist alone isn't enough

The Research and Evaluation Standard lists ten habits. A habit is something a person is supposed to remember to do. This plan is different: it's a fixed list of tests, each with clear steps and a clear pass-or-fail rule, run on a set schedule that doesn't depend on anyone remembering. This document turns every habit in the Standard into one or more real tests below, each with its own ID, so a specific problem can be named and tracked instead of just described in general terms.

Six groups of tests. Twenty tests in all. Most of them are things a person does on a schedule with a simple checklist — not computer code. That's exactly why the schedule in section 3 matters just as much as the tests themselves.

2. The six groups of tests

Group A — Are we coding the evidence carefully?

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
A1	A second person checks the coding	A second, separate person codes a random one-fifth sample of each new round of findings, on their own.	If the two readers agree closely (a standard score of 0.70 or higher), it passes. A middling score means the two readers talk it through and write down what they agreed on. A low score means we re-code the whole round.	Every check-in	The consultant plus a second, separate reader

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
A2	Check who we actually reached	Compare the list of people invited and the people who showed up against the Division's full staff list.	Any team with zero people represented gets named plainly in the published record — it doesn't get quietly folded into an overall number.	Every check-in	The consultant, double-checked by the staff equity group
A3	Check that our questions stayed the same	Compare this round's list of themes, word for word, against the list from the round before it.	Any theme that's added, dropped, or reworded needs a written reason, on record, before we publish anything.	Every check-in after the first	The consultant

Group B — Is our content clear, correct, and easy to use?

B1 finishes something we already owed. The American-English word check is the full language review that was talked about earlier and hadn't been run yet. It's now a permanent, scheduled test instead of a one-time cleanup.

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
B1	American-English word check	Scan every page, course, job aid, and document the Program publishes for British spelling. Check each hit: is it inside a quoted title from an outside source? If so, we leave it and note why. If not, we fix it.	Zero unfixed hits, outside of quoted titles from outside sources.	Before every update; a full check at each major version	The consultant
B2	Plain-language check	Run a standard reading-level score on every published page.	Staff-facing pages score at an eighth-grade reading level or easier, matching our own Division rule on plain language.	Before every update	The consultant
B3	Access check, for people with disabilities	An automatic scan of every page against the standard accessibility rules for websites (called WCAG, at the common government level called AA), plus a hands-on check	Zero failures on the automatic scan. Any hands-on finding gets fixed within 30 days.	Automatic scan: every month. Hands-on check: every three months	The consultant

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
		with a screen reader on a rotating one-tenth sample of pages.			
B4	Link and source check	An automatic check of every outside link the Program cites, to see if it still works.	No broken or unverified outside link at any update.	Every month, alongside the monthly update note	The consultant
B5	Staff-voice check	A person reads a rotating one-tenth sample of pages and checks: does this sound like it's written for staff, in plain, direct language — not like an academic paper or a government memo?	Any page that fails gets added to the list of content to fix.	Every three months	The consultant

Group C — Is our data fair and accurate?

These tests turn on once Workstream 4 builds our data baseline. Until then, they're written down and ready — so the data system gets built to already pass them, instead of needing rework later.

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
C1	Small-group privacy check	Every number broken down by group is checked before it's published: is any single group smaller than five people?	Zero published numbers for a group smaller than five.	Every report on gaps	Data and Analytics
C2	Fair-hiring check	For hiring, promotion, and selection numbers, compare each group's selection rate to the highest one. This follows a well-known federal rule: if one group is chosen less than 80 percent as often as the top group, that's a warning sign worth a closer look.	A ratio under 80 percent opens our fix-it process.	Every three months, once we have baseline numbers (2027 on)	Data and Analytics
C3	Outside comparison check	Compare our own workforce to the population of the area we serve — not just to our own past numbers.	Any real difference is stated plainly in the quarterly report, not left unsaid.	Once a year	Data and Analytics
C4					

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
	Follow-through check	For every gap flagged in the report three months before, check: is there a dated fix-it plan on file, with someone's name on it?	Zero gaps that carry over for two check-ins in a row with nothing done about them.	Every three months	Leadership group

Group D — Is the Program actually being used, and used fairly?

These turn on once the usage-tracking feature is added to Workstream 1.

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
D1	Fair-use check	Compare how much each part of the Division actually uses the Program — course completions, downloads, ASK questions.	No team goes silently unused for a whole quarter without someone following up.	Every three months	The consultant
D2	Where-people-quit check	For every course, check the finish rate at each lesson.	Any lesson where more than 30 percent of people quit, compared to the lesson before it, gets added to the content fix-it list.	Every three months	The consultant
D3	Privacy check on usage numbers	Try to filter or sort a usage report down to one identifiable person, and confirm it can't be done.	It must be impossible to identify one person from any usage report.	Any time the reporting tool changes, and once a year regardless	Data and Analytics

Group E — Can we back up what we claim?

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
E1	Two-source check	Before we publish any claim that something “worked,” someone other than the person making the claim checks: is it backed up by at least two separate kinds of evidence?	A claim that fails gets published as “a sign worth watching,” not as a finished finding.	Every time we claim a result	Someone other than the person making the claim

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
E2	Timing check	Compare the date we wrote down how we'd measure success against the date we found out the actual result.	If we wrote the measure after we already knew the result, we say so plainly — we don't present it as if it came first.	Every check-in	The consultant

Group F — Would this Program survive a change in leadership?

This group exists for one reason: to test, in a real and repeatable way, whether the Program would actually keep running through a change in Division Director, Manager, or Supervisor — not just assume it would. Test F4 matters most of all: a program that's only ever mentioned in its own consultant's paperwork has no real footing beyond whoever currently likes it.

ID	Test	How we do it	Pass or fail	How often	Who does it
F1	Job-title, not name, check	Read every governance rule and confirm it names a job title — never a person's name — for every duty.	Zero rules that name a specific person instead of a job title.	Once a year, and right after any rule is written or changed	Staff equity group
F2	Policy-still-applies check	Confirm, in writing, that the Program's basis in official policy — the One Minnesota Plan, the Olmstead Plan, the DHS Equity Policy, ADSA's equity plan — hasn't changed.	Any change gets stated plainly. Nothing gets quietly assumed to still apply.	Once a year, and right after any change in leadership	Staff equity group
F3	Ready-for-handoff check	Confirm the standard set of background material — this plan, the Standard, the logic model, the crosswalk, the current rules — is put together and current, ready to hand to a new leader.	That packet is no more than 12 months old.	Once a year	Chair of the staff equity group
F4	Outside-recognition check	Confirm the Program is named, by title, in at least one official Division or Administration planning document that exists on its own — not only in documents this consultant wrote.	At least one outside mention exists.	Once a year	Staff equity group

3. The full schedule

What runs, and when, across all six groups at once.

How often	Tests	What it covers
Every update	B1, B2, B4	American English, plain language, broken links
Every month	B3 (automatic part)	Access scan
Every three months	B3 (hands-on part), B5, C2, C4, D1, D2	Access spot-check; staff-voice check; fair-hiring; follow-through; fair-use; where people quit
Once a year	C3, D3, F1, F2, F3, F4	Outside comparison; privacy check; job-title check; policy check; ready-for-handoff; outside recognition
Every check-in (every two years)	A1, A2, A3	Second-person coding check; who-we-reached check; same-questions check
Whenever it happens	F1 (rule change), F2 (leadership change), D3 (tool change), E1 & E2 (any claim of a result)	Runs the moment it's needed, no matter what the calendar says

4. What happens when something fails a test

How serious	Example	What happens
Small	A broken link. A hard-to-read page. One access issue.	Added to the monthly to-fix list.
Medium	A fair-hiring ratio under 80 percent. A theme changed with no reason given. A team with zero use.	Named in the next quarterly report. The fix-it process opens.
Big	A rule that names a person instead of a job title. The Program found nowhere outside its own paperwork. A change in the policy this Program is built on.	Goes straight to the leadership group. It doesn't wait for the next quarterly report.

No failed test gets fixed quietly and re-run until it passes without a record. Every failure, big or small, gets written down before it gets fixed. That written record is part of what makes our next long-term comparison (habit 8 in the Standard) something people can actually trust.

5. How this connects to the Research and Evaluation Standard

The Standard lists ten habits, in plain language, with the reason for each one. This plan is those same ten habits turned into action: every habit in the Standard matches at least one test above, and a change to one document should lead to a look at the other. If the two ever seem to disagree, the Standard sets the rule, and this plan sets the exact steps that prove the rule is actually being followed.

6. Version history

Version	Date	Author	What changed
1.0	September 18, 2026	Gary Banks	First version. Turns the ten habits in the Research and Evaluation Standard into real tests, with steps, pass-or-fail rules, a schedule, and an owner.

7. Where each piece of this work lives

- **Research and Evaluation Standard** — the ten habits, and the leadership-change plan this group F tests against.
- **Program logic model** and **the crosswalk** — part of the standard background packet that test F3 checks is current.
- **Reporting process** — where a medium or big failure from section 4 actually gets reported.